

The Calibrant

Carmelo Piccione

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Six Novellas from Cowardly Irregular

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The Usurper's Crown

World 1 — Medieval

Prologue: The Notice

The notice was nailed to the door of the Sleepy Slime Inn at dawn, which was unusual, because nothing in Harmonia happened at dawn. Things in Harmonia happened at a responsible mid-morning hour, after porridge and before the first ale.

BY ORDER OF THE CROWN, it read, in letters that tried very hard to look official.

All able-bodied citizens are hereby conscripted into auxiliary service for the defense of the realm. Report to Elder Theron at the village square. Sincerely, The Royal Bureau of Definitely Real Military Operations.

Nobody in Harmonia had ever seen a Royal Bureau of anything. The village was six houses, a chapel, a shop that sold swords it had never tested, and an inn whose slime mascot had been repainted so many times it now resembled a vaguely threatening cloud. The inn's sign hung over the door on two chains, one of which squeaked in the morning wind with the persistence of something that had been meaning to be oiled for three seasons. The smell drifting from the kitchen was barley and woodsmoke and the faint sweetness of last night's mead, all of it settling in the pale gold light of early morning like a village asserting that it was still, in fact, here.

But the notice was there. And the monsters were getting worse. And the real army — the one with matching armor and a pension plan — was busy in the capital doing whatever it was armies did when chancellors needed protecting.

So five people showed up.

Not because they were brave. Not because they were special. Because they were there, and nobody else was, and Elder Theron had that look on his face — the one old men get when they've decided something is your problem now.

The Fighter came because he had heard there was trouble and trouble, in his understanding, was what fighters were for. He had a sword he'd bought from the untested shop and convictions he'd polished to a shine. He had not yet been called anything but the Fighter, but the Fighter was enough.

The Cleric came because the chapel had been empty for a week and God, or whatever it was that heard her prayers, had clearly decided someone should investigate. Her hands smelled of incense and her sandals were impractical for adventuring and she had never, in her life, second-guessed a calling.

The Mage came because he had been studying in the village's single room that could be called a library — which had four books, two of which were menus — and the pattern he'd found in the monster attacks was too interesting to ignore. Self-taught, mostly wrong about

the academic names of things, and completely correct about the practical applications. He had been called nothing but the Mage since the age of twelve, and the name had never bothered him.

The Rogue came because the Rogue had been sleeping under the inn's eaves when the notice went up and Elder Theron had seen a figure there and pointed, and it had been that kind of morning. The Rogue had been passing through Harmonia on the way to anywhere else and had made the critical error of still being there.

And the Bard came because the Bard went everywhere there was a story. Which was both her gift and everyone's curse.

"A party of five," she said, surveying her companions and immediately narrating it. "A valiant fighter, a servant of the cloth, a scholar of arcane learning, a rogue of disputed virtue, and a humble bard whose chronicles will outlast you all. What a tale this shall be."

"What a tale it shall be," the Rogue agreed, "if you don't stop talking about it and actually help carry something."

Chapter 1: The Village That Knew Too Much

Harmonia was the kind of village that existed to be left. A waypoint. A place you were from, not a place you stayed. The mountains to the north were pretty enough if you liked that sort of thing, and the cave at their base had been a reliable source of minor adventure for generations — bats, mostly, and the occasional slime with ambitions above its station.

But something had changed.

The bats were bigger. The slimes were angrier. Traders stopped coming through, then stopped sending messages, then stopped existing in conversation entirely, as though the roads themselves had forgotten they were there.

Elder Theron stood in the village square — which was less a square and more a circle of packed dirt where chickens held parliament — and regarded the four people who had answered the call with a fifth who had not technically answered it but had come anyway. In the square's center, the old well sat in the morning quiet, its rope furred

with moss, and around it a dozen chickens picked at the dust with the unhurried authority of creatures who had lived here longer than most people and intended to outlast them all.

"You'll do," he said, in a tone that suggested they absolutely would not do, but that complaining about it would take energy he didn't have.

Scholar Milo, who studied things that no one asked him to study, appeared at the party's elbow with the enthusiasm of a man who had been waiting his entire life for someone to listen to him. He was a thin man of indeterminate age, wearing spectacles that existed primarily to be adjusted, carrying a journal that was mostly marginalia.

"Before you go," he said, "have you considered the philosophical implications of combat automation?"

The party had not.

"Imagine," Milo continued, undeterred by the silence, "a world where you don't *fight* your battles. You *design* them. You build a system of rules — if this, then that — and the system fights for you. Not laziness. *Enlightenment*."

He pressed the weathered journal into the Fighter's hands. The cover read: **AUTOBATTLE: A Practical Guide to Strategic Detachment.**

"Chapter one is about letting go," Milo said. "Chapter two is about letting go *faster*."

"What's chapter three?" the Bard asked, already reaching for her quill to write it down.

"Chapter three is about accepting that the gap between letting go and having it taken from you is smaller than most people think."

He said it with the cheerful tone of a man discussing weather, and nobody thought anything of it, because sometimes scholars said strange things. That was what scholars were for.

The village offered what it could. A woman whose brother had gone to Scriptura and not returned. A farmer who had seen lights in the cave at unusual hours — not torches, something steadier, something that came from walls. An old man near the well who looked at the Rogue with entirely too much recognition for someone who had never met the Rogue.

"Phil," said the old man, extending a hand. "Phil the Lost. Called that because I lose things. Mostly I lose track of... well. Of what's happened before."

"Before what?" the Mage asked.

Phil scratched his head. He had the look of a man trying to remember a dream, the way very old men look when the years have blurred together like wet ink, winter following winter until they're all the same winter.

"Before anything much," he said. "The village. The seasons. You know how it is — years blur together. You forget which winter was which." He tilted his head. "Though I will say this: good luck with the cave. Try not to die in the first room. It's bad for the spirit."

"The spirit of whom?" the Fighter asked.

Phil considered this. "Unclear," he said, and walked back to the well.

The untested sword shop had a proprietor named Bram who had never tested any of the swords and was proud of it. "Testing dulls the edge," he explained, which was technically backward but said with such conviction that it had become local wisdom. He sold them what they needed at prices that were almost fair, and threw in a shield gratis for the Fighter after the Fighter's earnestness became painful to witness.

"You look like someone who's going to get hit a lot," Bram said, not unkindly. "Take the shield. Consider it an investment in your surviving long enough to come back and buy more."

The Cleric said a blessing over the equipment, which the Mage documented in his notes as "ritual application of perceived divine endorsement, efficacy unclear but morale effect measurable." The Bard began composing the verse about their departure before they had actually departed. The Rogue stole a health potion from the back shelf, felt guilty about it, and left a coin the Rogue couldn't afford.

Elder Theron watched them go with the expression of a man who has planted seeds in difficult soil and has made peace with the uncertainty.

Chapter 2: The Road North — A Series of Unfortunate Encounters

Between Harmonia and the Whispering Cave lay two hours of open road and at least three things that wanted to hurt them.

The first thing was a pair of slimes.

Slimes in Harmonia were, by tradition, more nuisance than threat. Blue, globular, possessed of appetites that outpaced their ability to act on them. But these slimes — and the Mage noted it in his journal with the intensity of someone who has found confirmation for a theory — were *different*. Not stronger. Sharper. More deliberate in their malice. The afternoon sun picked out a faint iridescence in their bodies that ordinary slimes did not have, something almost organized about the way the light moved through them.

When the Fighter struck the first slime with the untested sword, it split.

Not in the way things split when you strike them with a sword, which is generally to say they break apart and stop being a problem. This slime split into two smaller slimes, each one just as angry as the original, organized around a shared objective in a way that slimes fundamentally should not have been able to manage.

"Oh," said the Mage, watching one half of the original slime begin to circle left while the other circled right. "Oh, that's clever."

"The slime is *clever*?" the Fighter said, trying to track both halves.

"The *design* is clever." He was writing in his notes. "Don't hit it with the sword again. Use fire. Or the Cleric's radiant spells. Area effects. Force them to converge rather than divide."

The Cleric raised her holy symbol and prayed with the focused intensity of someone who had learned that faith without specificity accomplished less than faith with a clear target. A wash of warm light rolled across both halves simultaneously. They yelped — slimes do not, technically, yelp, but there is no better word for the sound — and merged back together in self-defense, and in their merging became briefly vulnerable, and the Mage launched a fire bolt that reduced them both to a puddle of scorched indignation.

"Elegant," the Mage said.

"I would have preferred simply stabbing them," the Fighter said.

"You can simply stab the next thing," the Rogue said. "I promise there will be a next thing."

The next thing was a goblin named, according to a hand-painted sign propped against his pack, GRUT — AUTHENTIC HERO SUPPLIES. He had set up shop in the middle of the road with the confidence of someone who believed their location was an asset rather than an obstacle.

Grut was three feet tall, wore a traveling cloak that had been cut from what appeared to be an old tent, and had arranged his wares on a blanket with the pride of a merchant who considered "slightly less rusty" a compelling selling point.

"Greetings, heroes!" he said, spreading his arms wide. "You look like you are going to the cave. Yes? The Whispering Cave, with the monsters and the danger? Good news. Grut has everything you need."

He gestured to his wares. There was a sword that was notably worse than the one the Fighter already carried. There was a potion in a bottle that had "POTION" written on it in a hand that suggested the writer had been under some deadline pressure. There was a helmet that was, upon close inspection, a cooking pot with a chinstrap.

"That helmet," the Mage said, "is a pot."

"Authentic ancient warrior vessel," Grut said, undeterred. "Very rare. Very powerful. Kings wore these."

"What king wore a pot on his head?"

"...King Pothelm," Grut said, without missing a beat. "Very famous king. From the west. You wouldn't have heard of him."

The Bard, to everyone's dismay, had already pulled out a coin. "I'll take it."

"You will not," said the Rogue.

"The story," the Bard explained patiently, "requires that we purchased something from the goblin merchant. The narrative demands it."

"The narrative can manage without a cooking pot."

"The cooking pot," Grut said helpfully, "is also functional as a cooking pot. Very versatile."

They bought a health potion — the real one, which Grut produced from a secret pocket when the theatrical transaction had run its course. He charged three times what it was worth and they paid two and a half times what it was worth, and both parties felt they had won the negotiation.

"Good luck in the cave," Grut called after them. "If you die, your equipment reverts to the shop system! Very convenient!"

No one knew what the shop system was. They kept walking.

The third obstacle was a pack of wolves.

They emerged from the tree line in the low gray light of late afternoon — five of them, rangy and hungry-eyed, drawn by the smell of people carrying food and the universal wolf assessment that this particular group of people looked like they might not put up much of a fight.

The wolves were wrong, but they didn't know that yet.

The Bard, who had been composing under her breath and was only partially attending to the physical world, looked up at the wolves and made an executive decision. She pulled her lute from her back, breathed in, and began to play.

The music that came out was not what heroes typically wielded against monsters. It was low and rolling, something between a lullaby and a warning — the kind of thing a mother wolf might have taught her pups, if mother wolves had a musical tradition, which they did not, but the point was that it *resonated* in a way that the wolves' nervous systems recognized before their threat instincts could argue.

The pack leader — the largest wolf, battle-scarred, one eye clouded — turned its head toward the sound.

It was not calmed. Wolves do not get calmed by music in the way songs suggest. But it was *uncertain*, which is close enough. And the Cleric had, during the moment of uncertainty, raised her hand and sent a pulse of gentle radiant light outward — not the war-prayers she used in battle, but something softer, something that communicated *we are not prey* without requiring anyone to be struck.

The pack stood in the road for four seconds. The leader reconsidered its life choices. The pack turned and left.

"Bard performance and Cleric radiant aura," the Mage noted, writing furiously. "Combined effect on territorial mammalian aggression: decisive. Cross-referencing with defensive formation positioning..." He paused. "The system works better when we coordinate."

"That's what I've been saying," the Bard said, tucking the lute back onto her shoulder.

"You've been saying it in *verse*," the Rogue said. "It lands differently in prose."

They reached the cave mouth as the sun dropped behind the mountains and the whispers began.

Chapter 3: The Whispering Cave

The cave had earned its name honestly. It whispered.

Not words, exactly. More like the memory of words — the sound a sentence makes after everyone has forgotten what it meant. The entrance was a low arch in the mountain's face, and the moment you stepped through it the temperature dropped five degrees and the light from outside ceased to matter. Inside, the air tasted of iron and wet limestone, and something older beneath that — the mineral breath of deep rock, cold and patient as stone. The walls were slick with seepage, not quite moss but the promise of it, and the torchlight the party carried made the moisture on the walls gleam in uncertain patterns. Shadows moved before they did.

The monsters here were different from the road fodder. Sharper. More deliberate. A goblin in the upper chambers fought like it had read a manual on how goblins were supposed to fight — textbook aggression, predictable patterns, as if it were performing the role of "cave monster" rather than simply being one.

The skeleton they encountered in the second chamber was worse.

It wore armor that had once been fine — a knight's plate, now dark with age, with a crest that might have been a lion or might have been a very aggressive cloud. When the party entered, it straightened from where it had been standing in the corner. Not rising from the ground, not assembling itself from scattered bones. Just... standing up straighter, as though it had been waiting at parade rest.

It turned to face them. Specifically, it turned to face the Fighter.

It raised one gauntleted fist to the side of its skull, where an ear would have been.

It saluted.

"What," said the Rogue.

The Fighter, operating on instinct and a deep-seated belief that honor recognized honor, straightened and returned the salute.

The skeleton — apparently satisfied that the formalities had been observed — drew its sword, raised it in a guard position, and waited.

"It's being *chivalric*," the Cleric said, sounding confused and moved in equal measure.

"It's a skeleton," the Mage said.

"Chivalric skeletons are not documented," the Bard agreed, "and yet here we are."

The fight that followed was, by some accounts, the most courteous exchange of violence the cave had ever witnessed. The skeleton fought without tricks — no dirty blows, no targeting the weaker members of the party, no attempting to exploit flanking opportunities. It engaged the Fighter as an equal, and when the Cleric's prayers began to weaken its structural integrity and the Mage's fire spells heated its armor past comfortable operating temperature, it fought on with the dignity of something that had been fighting a long time and had made peace with the possibility of not always winning.

When it finally fell — armor clattering, bones scattering, the sword ringing against stone — the Fighter found, when he bent to examine the crest, a small inscription on the inside of the visor.

SERVE WITH HONOR. REST WITH PEACE.

He stood up and didn't say anything for a moment. The Bard, for once, didn't narrate.

Deeper into the cave, the whispers grew. The second passage descended steeply — the floor sloping down in a way that made footing uncertain, the walls narrowing until the torchlight barely reached both sides at once. The cold deepened. Down here, the water seeping through the stone had carved shallow channels in the floor, and the sound of it was the only sound that didn't seem to come from

somewhere else. The Mage pressed his hand to the wall and felt something he couldn't name — not heat, not cold, but the impression of *design*. Intentional structure. Walls that had been shaped not by water but by something that worked by different rules.

"Someone made this harder," he said.

"The cave?" the Fighter asked.

"The cave as a challenge. Someone went through the cave and... arranged it." He pulled his hand back and looked at the faint residue on his palm — traces of magic that felt like paperwork. "Court magic. The formal kind. The kind with a wax seal."

"Someone in the capital corrupted the cave?"

"Someone in the capital *designed* this floor."

In a small alcove off the second passage, the Rogue found a chest the corruption hadn't touched. Inside: a healing vial, sealed with unfamiliar wax. The label on the vial read, in script too precise to be hand-lettered: *Restorative Compound — contains residual magic, handle with ambient care*. Below that, crossed out and rewritten: *residual magic*. The crossed-out line was the original. Someone had changed it, apparently decided the change was wrong, and then left both versions on the label without removing either.

The Rogue held the vial up to the cave light. The label was read twice. Then it was handed to the Mage without comment.

He read it. Looked at the crossed-out word. Read it again. Put the vial in his pack.

"Odd label," the Bard said, reading over the Mage's shoulder.

"Someone was in a hurry," he said.

"Probably," the Bard agreed.

The deepest chamber was where the whispers converged.

Chapter 4: Warden of the Old Guard

The Warden was not what the party expected.

They had expected a monster. Or a corrupted guardian. Or, at minimum, something that looked like it wanted to be here.

What they found was a figure in full plate armor, utterly still, standing in the center of a chamber that was almost perfectly circular. The chamber itself had the quality of a place that had been maintained over centuries through some principle of pure duty — the stone floor worn smooth not by traffic but by the slow passage of time, the walls bare except for an inscription too weathered to read. The air here was different from the rest of the cave: drier, stiller, as if the ordinary dampness of the mountain had decided to leave this room alone. The armor was old — not decayed, not corrupted, but *old* in the way that things are old when they have been maintained for centuries rather than centuries of neglect. The sword was sheathed. The shield was up. The figure's posture was that of a soldier standing at ease, which meant ready to be uneasily at arms in a moment's notice.

When the party entered, the figure's head rose. Not with aggression. With attention.

"Hm." The voice was weathered — the voice of stone that has learned to talk, or of a man who has spent so long alone with his thoughts that sound had become a visitor rather than a resident. "Four blades. A healer. A mage. Rearguard position on the light-fingered one. Standard formation for an irregular unit."

"We're not exactly—" the Fighter started.

"You're exactly what I said." The Warden's armor shifted slightly — a minute adjustment, a soldier settling into weight. "Conscripts, most of you. Not chosen. Not trained for this. Which means you're here because no one with better options came." He paused. "That makes you either very brave or very unlucky."

"We've had about forty percent of each, so far," the Mage said.

Something changed in the Warden's posture that might have been amusement, if armor could hold amusement without losing structural integrity.

"This pass has been held for three hundred years," he said. "By my count, you are the thirty-seventh party to attempt it. The other thirty-six turned back." He let that settle for a moment, not as a threat but as information, the way a man states weather. "I am not telling you this to frighten you. I am telling you so the record is clear."

"I have guarded this chamber since before memory," he continued. "Since before your village was a plan in anyone's mind. I do not know precisely how long. Time in a cave runs differently than time in the world. I know that I was given a purpose: see that those who wish to pass are worthy. Nothing has passed that I could not stop. Nothing has tried that I did not test." A pause. His voice dropped slightly — not softer, but more direct, the way a man speaks when he wants to be understood rather than obeyed. "You will be tested. But first — there is food in the guardhouse at the passage's end. I cannot leave the post. But you may rest before we begin, if you wish."

He meant it. The invitation was not a trick.

"We're all right," the Fighter said, after a moment.

The Warden nodded once, as though he had expected this answer and was not displeased by it. "Show me what you are, and I will show you what I have left."

"Is there a way to avoid—" the Rogue began.

"No."

"Right then."

The Warden drew his sword. Not quickly — not with aggression. The way a craftsman picks up their tool. Natural. Inevitable.

"I want you to know," he said, "that I bear you no ill will. This is not personal. This is purpose." He settled into his guard. "Begin when you're ready."

The fight was hard in the way that fair things are hard. The Warden didn't cheat. He didn't ambush or deceive. He didn't target the Cleric first to remove healing, which would have been the strategically obvious move. He simply fought — with discipline, with patience, with the economy of movement that comes from centuries of practice rather than decades.

He hit the Fighter like a weather event. The Fighter hit back and the Warden absorbed it with the equanimity of a man who has been hit before and expects to be hit again and considers the entire enterprise unremarkable.

The Mage's fire spells worked better than cold steel — the armor held, but something in the enchantments powering the Warden's endurance conducted magic in a way that steel did not, and he pressed that

advantage with the focus of someone working through a problem he found genuinely interesting. The Cleric kept them standing through two bouts of the Warden's Crushing Blow that should, by all reasonable physics, have ended things.

The Rogue, approaching from an angle the Warden hadn't turned to cover, found a gap in the plate work at the back of the left knee and made a decision that was technically dishonorable but practically necessary.

The Warden went down on one knee.

He stayed there for a moment. The chamber was very quiet, the kind of quiet that only exists deep underground, where there is nothing for sound to bounce off of except stone.

"Thirty-eight," he said. He had gone down on one knee and he stayed there, not from exhaustion but from something more considered. "You are the first to get through. I don't know what that means for the other side, but — good. Carry something worth carrying."

He set down his sword — deliberately, not dropping it. Placed his shield beside it. The armor began to still in a way that was different from stillness, the way a heartbeat stopping is different from a heart at rest.

A long quiet. Then: "I don't know who put me here. I stopped asking." He looked at the cave wall, not at the party. "Maybe you should ask for both of us."

"Fighter," he said, and the Fighter stopped. "Your shield work is poor. You lead with your right side and you don't correct for it. If you survive long enough to face something worse than me, correct it before then."

The Fighter opened his mouth, closed it, nodded.

"Mage." The Mage looked up from his notes. "Stop documenting during the fight. You nearly took a blow from my left flank that would have ended your journey. Your theory is correct. Trust it."

"Cleric." The Cleric stood straighter. "You held them together longer than anyone had a right to expect. That is rare. Guard your own life with the same care you spend on theirs." A long pause. "And you — bard."

The Bard blinked. "Me?"

"When you sang to the wolf pack. That was not the action of a frightened musician. That was strategy." Something in the old voice shifted — quieter, more curious than the formal tones before. "You chose the right moment. You knew that music was the correct tool." A pause. "Someone taught you well. Or no one taught you and you simply *knew*." Another pause. "I find I cannot tell which is true. Strange. I have watched many people come through here. I should be able to tell."

The Bard said nothing, which was unusual enough to be notable.

Behind where the Warden had stood, scratched into the cave wall in letters too precise to be natural: traces of court magic. Formal enchantments. The kind of spell that came with a wax seal and a filing system.

Someone with authority had been feeding the cave's corruption deliberately.

Chapter 5: The Forest That Remembered

The Corrupted Forest wore its sickness openly. The trees bent at angles that wood shouldn't permit — not the lean of a tree shaped by decades of prevailing wind, but a sudden torque, as if something had reached down and twisted them partway through growing. The light came from the wrong direction, not from the sky but from somewhere beneath the roots, filtering upward through soil that glowed faintly green in the shadows beneath the canopy. Walking into it felt like stepping into a room that had been rearranged by someone who didn't understand how rooms were supposed to work: the geometry was almost right, almost recognizable, and the almost was worse than entirely wrong. The air tasted different too — sharper, with a mineral edge under the leaf-rot smell, as though the corruption had altered even the way the forest breathed. The ground was soft in places it shouldn't have been soft, and firm where roots should have given.

On the road to the forest, they passed through a stretch of woodland where the trees were still healthy and the shadows were the right shape, and where a figure had been following them since roughly the river crossing.

The Rogue noticed first — which was the Rogue's function, largely, in a group that otherwise had a tendency to walk loudly and discuss things at normal volume.

"We're being tracked," the Rogue said.

"Since when?" the Fighter asked, reaching for his sword.

"Since the bridge. Don't reach for the sword."

"If someone is following us—"

"Someone is *studying* us." The Rogue didn't turn around. "There's a difference. Whoever it is, they've had four opportunities to ambush us and passed on all of them. That's not predation. That's professional curiosity."

As if on cue, a calling card fell from a branch above them — a small leather token stamped with the image of a running hound, landing in the center of the path where they couldn't miss it.

On the back, in neat, controlled handwriting: *You walk with purpose. Let's see if you can keep it. — T.*

"The Tempo," the Mage said, examining the card. "Mordaine's hunter. They're not attacking us. They're *playing*."

Somewhere in the canopy, a branch rustled. The sound moved east — a deliberate announcement of position. Come and find me, if you can.

"How delightful," the Bard said, pulling out her quill. "We have a nemesis."

"We have a *problem*," the Rogue said.

"Those are the same thing to a good story."

Eldertree Village huddled at the forest's edge like a child pressing against a wall during a thunderstorm. Its people were tired. Their sacred trees — enormous things, older than the kingdom, older than the idea of kingdoms — were dying from the inside out. Sap ran black. Leaves fell upward.

"It comes from the east," said a woman who had the look of someone who had stopped sleeping several weeks ago. "From the capital's direction. We sent word. No one came."

"No one comes anymore," said another villager, staring at the party with an expression that was half hope and half accusation. "The army protects the chancellor. The chancellor protects the army. And we protect ourselves."

Deep in the village, the party found a man who had fled Scriptura. He was thin and spoke too quickly, as though the words might be taken from him if he didn't get them out fast enough.

"Mordaine," he said. "Chancellor Mordaine. She doesn't rule the kingdom. She *is* the kingdom now. The king sits on the throne and signs what she puts in front of him and eats what she puts on his plate and sleeps when she says it's time to sleep."

He looked at them with eyes that had seen too much bureaucracy to ever fully recover.

"She believes she's helping. That's the worst part. She genuinely believes the kingdom is better this way. Orderly. Efficient." He paused, searching for the right word. "She has a word for it. Says everything has to be *calibrated*. The grain stores. The guard rotations. The trade agreements." He shook his head slowly. "Calibrated. Like the kingdom is a scale she's trying to keep balanced."

He used that word — calibrated — and none of them thought anything of it. Why would they? It was just a word.

An old woman in the back of the meeting hall grabbed the arm of the nearest party member — the Bard, who was closest and had the least developed instincts for self-preservation.

"I've seen you before," she said. "Or someone like you. Walking down from the cave."

"When?" he asked.

She looked at him with the distant expression of someone surfacing from deep water. "My mind wanders. The forest gets into you, sends the memory sideways. Don't mind me." She released his arm. "Just — be careful in the capital. There are eyes everywhere and not all of them belong to guards."

He wrote it down anyway. He wrote everything down. He told himself it was habit.

The forest resisted them. The deeper they went, the more the corruption pushed back — not with monsters, but with *wrongness*. Paths that looped. Clearings that repeated. The feeling, impossible to shake, that the forest wasn't corrupted at all but *redesigned*. Rebuilt from the ground up to be a challenge rather than a place. The trees that had been twisted now seemed less like victims of blight and more like obstacles with intent — positioned to funnel, to confuse, to channel

movement toward particular clearings. Sound carried wrong: footsteps muffled, voices absorbed, the forest's natural noise replaced by an anticipatory silence that had the quality of listening.

They found the Tempo's second calling card nailed to a tree at the forest's center: a crude drawing of five stick figures looking confused in a circle. Beneath it: *You've been here three times now. I've been watching.* — T.

They had not been to this clearing before.

"That's not possible," the Fighter said.

"The forest loops," the Mage said, not looking up from his compass, which had been spinning since they crossed the tree line. "We keep finding the same clearing from different directions. Someone designed these paths to converge." He paused. "Someone wanted us disoriented."

"Someone wanted to see how we handled being disoriented," the Rogue said. "There's a difference."

Chapter 6: Arbiter of Steel

The Arbiter of Steel waited in a clearing where the corruption was thickest.

It stood exactly at the clearing's center, which the Mage noted was geometrically precise — not where a creature would naturally position itself, but where a designer would place a checkpoint. She was visible and composed: light armor, dueling leathers, tall and still, holding her sword point-down in the manner of someone who doesn't need to threaten you. The armor was immaculate despite the forest's decay, as if the corruption knew better than to try. The blade's angles communicated a great deal about its owner: this was not someone who had been placed here. This was someone who had arrived and found the location beneath her and set up within it anyway, out of professional obligation rather than respect. She had been watching them since they stepped into the clearing. She had been watching them the whole way through the forest.

When the party entered the clearing, the Arbiter raised one blade in formal challenge.

"I challenge one of you," she said. The voice was clipped and precise — every syllable considered. "Whoever leads. The others stay back. I'll know if they don't."

"And if we refuse?" the Fighter asked.

"Then you fight together, and you have already compromised your honor before the first blow lands." The Arbiter's gaze swept the party with frank assessment. "Though looking at you, that may be the more appropriate arrangement. I had hoped for a genuine challenge." She let that sit for a moment, then added, with the particular honesty of someone who has decided not to be cruel but will not soften the truth: "Come at me with everything. I'll know if you're holding back. And I'll be disappointed."

The Fighter stepped forward without consulting anyone else. The party started to protest and he turned briefly to look at them with an expression that required no words: *Let me*.

"The one in the dented pauldron," the Arbiter said. "Interesting choice. Or lack of one." She rolled one sword in a slow arc, loosening the wrist. "This will be brief."

What followed was, in the Bard's notes and several subsequent performances, described as "the finest duel of the age." In practice, it was harrowing, because the Arbiter was a glass cannon in the truest sense — she could end you before you had processed that the engagement had started, and her counterstrike window was timed to punish overconfidence with mathematical precision.

The Fighter's technique was, as the Warden had observed, flawed on the right side. The Arbiter found it in the first exchange and used it in the second and the Fighter went to one knee briefly and the party collectively inhaled.

He rose. He adjusted. He corrected for the right side, at the cost of two steps backward and a moment of vulnerability that should have been exploited.

The Arbiter did not exploit it. Instead, she paused.

"You're adapting," she said. The cold precision of her voice had developed a crack in it — not warmth, but involuntary attention. "Mid-fight."

"Yes," the Fighter said.

"That's..." The Arbiter's stance shifted, very slightly. "Inconvenient." She adjusted her grip. "Your timing is faster than it looks."

The fight resumed. Mid-exchange, she narrated her own adjustments with the briefness of someone who thought aloud only when they had to: "Good angle. I'll have to correct for that." The Fighter pressed the advantage she'd just described. She absorbed it. "Good." She said it without irony. Not encouragement — recognition.

The Fighter did not win by being better. He won by being slightly less bad in the right moments, and by having companions whose collective prayers and secondary investments of magic-from-a-distance may have technically constituted cheating, but then the Arbiter had never explicitly defined the prohibition on ambient support.

When the Arbiter fell, she knelt, and the kneeling was deliberate — the motion of something that has chosen its posture.

"Hm." There was no grace in the acknowledgment, but something had replaced the dismissal — a reluctant warmth, the warmth of someone who asked for their best and got it. "I asked for your best and you gave it. I didn't expect to like being beaten this much."

"Thank you," the Fighter said.

"It is not a compliment. It is a fact." She looked at the party assembled at the clearing's edge. "Your movements are irregular. Not trained. Not disciplined. But you persist through mistakes in a way that suggests you haven't yet accepted their cost. That is either a flaw or a quality. I cannot determine which."

"Maybe both," the Mage said.

"That answer is outside my assessment criteria," the Arbiter said. But she was quiet for a moment afterward, and the quiet had weight. She looked at the Fighter's sword, then back at the party. "The sword knows," she said finally. "Whatever you are — the sword knows you're real." She rose. "Behind the sealed passage to the north. The court magic there was not intended to be found. Find it."

Behind the Arbiter, a sealed passage. And carved into the seal, in the same precise hand as the cave: *The crown is not what it seems.*

Chapter 7: The Capital of Comfortable Lies

Scriptura was beautiful. That was the problem.

The city announced itself before you reached it — the smell of baking bread and horse and tallow candles, the sound of a thousand people conducting the business of living carried on the morning air from a mile out. Coming over the last rise on the capital road, you saw the walls first: pale stone, well-maintained, higher than they needed to be for a city that hadn't been besieged in fifty years. Then the towers above the walls. Then, through the gate, the streets themselves.

The streets were clean. The buildings were maintained. The guards were polite in the way that people are polite when they know they could stop being polite at any time and nobody would do anything about it. Flowers grew in window boxes. Children played in courtyards. In the market district the stalls were heavy with produce and cloth and the smell of roasting meat and spiced wine and fresh-tanned leather, and the merchants called their prices with a precision that was almost too precise, as if the prices had been set by someone who had calculated the correct price rather than discovered it through the usual chaos of supply and want.

Everything was exactly where it was supposed to be.

It was the most oppressive place any of them had ever seen.

They entered through the tradesman's gate, where the Rogue's ability to produce paperwork from nowhere anyone had seen it written became their first practical advantage. The paperwork had been obtained somewhere between the Arbiter's clearing and the city walls. No one asked where. Some questions were less useful than others.

The resistance operated out of a bookshop, because of course it did. The bookshop's exterior was indistinguishable from its neighbors — well-kept, properly painted, sign hanging at regulation height. Inside, it was a different country. The shelves were overfull, the kind of overfull that looks like disorganization but is actually a system legible only to its creator. The smell of old paper and glue was everywhere, overlaid with lamp oil. A woman named Sera — sharp-eyed, exhausted, operating on conviction and caffeine's medieval equivalent — laid out what they knew.

"The king is enchanted. Not the fairy-tale kind — the administrative kind. Mordaine doesn't need magic chains when she has policy. He signs what she writes. He says what she scripts. He's not a prisoner. He's a *process*."

The Scriptweaver's Guild, once the intellectual heart of the city, had been co-opted. Its scholars now wrote Mordaine's edicts instead of their own research. But some of them still kept their old work hidden — books about the nature of reality that used words like "functions" and "principles" in ways that were plainly metaphorical, the language of philosophers, though the Mage found himself rereading the same passage three times before moving on.

"There's a theory," one scholar whispered, glancing at the door as though it might report him. "That the structures governing our world — the kingdoms, the seasons, the way power flows — are more like... a design than an accident. Rules that someone wrote, even if no one living knows who." He showed them a diagram. It was labeled in the careful hand of a civil servant: *Kingdom Administrative Structure — The Realm's Chain of Order*. "I found it in the restricted archive. It maps every authority in the kingdom — from the throne to the outermost village checkpoint." He traced the flowchart's arrows. "The interesting thing is: it maps us. Our route. Every significant location on our journey, as if someone had charted it."

"Someone charted the journey of people they hadn't met yet?" the Fighter asked.

"Mordaine prepares for every contingency," the scholar said. "That's what makes her formidable."

The Bard studied the diagram for a long moment. "You're certain this is about political structure?" she said finally. "Not something else?"

"What else would it be?"

The Bard looked at the arrows moving from location to location — cave, forest, capital — with annotations that noted something she couldn't quite interpret. She tapped the paper. "I don't know," she said. "I thought I had a word for it and then I didn't."

"We should focus," the Mage said, closing his notebook with the precision of someone deciding not to read something aloud. "We have a city to navigate."

The city was navigated largely by the Rogue, who treated urban environments like a language learned in the cradle, and the Bard, who had the unique social superpower of being completely unthreatening. Guards who would have stopped a fighter in full equipment waved through a bard who was clearly there to perform at somebody's feast, along with the bard's slightly strange companions who were obviously not armed (the sword was, briefly, inside the lute case, which the Fighter found philosophically objectionable but tactically necessary).

They found the Tempo of the Hunt in the market district.

Or rather, the Tempo found them — which had been the pattern since the forest. It dropped from a rooftop into the street ahead of them, and it was, finally, visible: a figure in traveling leathers, built for speed rather than defense, wearing an expression of genuine pleasure that had nothing polite about it.

"You made it to the city," it said, and the pleasure was undisguised — the particular delight of a hunter who has spent weeks on a chase and found the quarry still running. "I had calculated you would lose yourselves in the forest and give up. I even cleared one of the loop paths to give you a chance." Its eyes were bright. "I wanted you to last longer."

"How generous," the Rogue said.

"Isn't it?" The Tempo's gaze swept the party — assessing, savoring. "You have an interesting way of moving through space. You cover each other's gaps without discussing it. The mage hangs back by exactly the right distance. The healer stays behind the tank without being told. The rogue..." It looked at the Rogue with the specific appreciation of a predator identifying a good prey animal. "The rogue is already three steps from where I expect."

The Rogue was, indeed, three steps from where a moment ago the Rogue had been.

"Don't let me catch you," the Tempo said, and the pleasure in that line was not manufactured — it never had been. "That's not a threat. That's the game." It *moved*.

The chase through Scriptura's streets was everything the Tempo had promised — and the Tempo clearly loved every second of it, cutting through crowds with the ease of something that had been doing this since before the city had crowds, vaulting crates and disappearing around corners and reappearing somewhere improbable, laughing

when the party nearly had it and laughing harder when they lost the thread. The Tempo narrated the hunt in real time as it ran, not to taunt but with the genuine engagement of a hunter observing the terrain: "Clever — you're slowing down the right moments and speeding up the wrong ones. Adaptive." When the party split up to cover more ground: "Oh, they've learned the geometry. Most don't." The chase was not a measure. It was a game. A genuinely, gleefully enjoyed game, and the Tempo was the only one with any fun in it.

"It's not trying to kill us," the Mage said, breathing hard, running alongside the Fighter. "It's *playing*."

"It's measuring us," the Rogue said, from somewhere to the left.

"No," the Mage said. "It's doing both. It's playing because it enjoys it and the data is incidental." A corner. A turn. "That's worse somehow."

The Rogue did something that was too fast to follow — a turn that wasn't a turn, an approach from an angle that physics should have prevented — and the Tempo, for the first time, was where it had not planned to be. The Rogue was already somewhere else.

The fight that followed was desperate and fast and ended in the market square with all five of them surrounding the Tempo, who had been cornered by the simple expedient of removing all the exits one at a time.

The Tempo knelt with the grace of something that has never been forced to kneel and is choosing to now rather than having it chosen for them. And even kneeling, it was smiling.

"A fine chase," it said, and meant it completely. "The best I can remember. I haven't been outrun in—" It paused. Something shifted behind the brightness of its expression. "I don't remember how long." The smile dimmed slightly, or rather moved somewhere deeper and less comfortable. "Strange. A hunter remembers every chase. The duration. The quarry. The outcome." Its brow furrowed. "My memory extends precisely as far back as the beginning of your arrival. Nothing before that."

"That seems wrong," the Mage agreed.

"It should trouble me," the Tempo said. "The fact that it doesn't trouble me is, perhaps, the most troubling thing." It rose, and the easy delight had gone sideways into something more complicated. Something genuine, and quieter. "First time I've been run to ground in a long time. I'd do it again." The brightness in its voice was still there, but

underneath it now was something else — not sadness exactly, but its close neighbor. "Whatever you're hunting, on the other side of all this — I hope you catch it." It looked at the party for a moment with the attention of someone memorizing a thing they expect to not see again. "Be careful in the palace. The last guardian has been waiting longer than any of us. She has more... history."

With the Tempo broken and the palace district accessible, there was nothing left but the throne room.

That night, in a room above a bakery that smelled of yeast and old butter, the Bard sat at the writing desk by lamplight while the others slept. She opened her journal to a clean spread and wrote across the top of the left page: *Things noticed on the road. To be considered later, when there is later.*

She did not name what she was doing. She did not yet have the word for it. She only knew that there were five people she had been traveling with, and there were five things she had seen them do that had not gone in the daily record — not because they were unimportant, but because they were the kind of important that only made sense when you laid them next to each other and let them argue.

She wrote them in the order they had happened.

The Fighter, after the slimes on the road. Hands shaking. Set them on the pommel and they were not shaking. Did not decide to. The hands did it on their own, having been told. The fighting is the easy part. The standing afterward is what costs.

The Cleric, at the well in Harmonia. The half-second before the prayer. Not hesitation in the way the word usually means — more like a small door she had to open before the rest could happen. Every time. Even now. She has not stopped paying for the thing she does. She has only stopped mentioning that she pays.

The Mage, at the carved wall in the cave. The second reading on top of the first. He did not flinch. He did not apologize. The first reading was a step toward the second one and both went in the book. There is a kind of being right that begins with being wrong on purpose. He does not call it that. I will not tell him I have a name for it.

The Rogue, after the false-bottom chest in the third chamber. Pocketed the folded paper while we were arguing about coins. I did not see it; I noticed the moment afterward in which they were already standing

somewhere different from where the noticing of the paper would have been done. There is a second room in every room they enter. I have not asked what is in the pocket.

She paused. The fifth was hers. She had not been sure whether to write her own.

The Bard, at the inner gate today. Listened. Listened for a long time. Spoke once. The thing she said was the thing the guard had been waiting to be asked. It was not the cleverness of the line that opened the gate. It was the having-been-listened-to. I did not know I knew that until I wrote it down. I am writing it down so I will know it next time.

She set the quill in its rest and looked at the page for a while. She did not yet understand what she was looking at. She only understood that the five entries belonged on the same page, and that putting them there had taken something out of her that she did not, until now, know she had been carrying.

She turned to a fresh page and wrote at the top of it: *To return to. Possibly the most important thing in the journal.* Then she closed the journal and went to bed.

She would, later, return to it. She did not yet know how late later would be.

Chapter 8: The Scholar's Reckoning

Before the palace, the Scriptweaver's Guild.

The Mage had insisted, and the insistence had the quality of someone following a thread they didn't yet understand. The scholar who had shown them the administrative diagram met them in the Guild's back room with the look of a man choosing between his safety and his need to be understood.

"I found more documents," he said. "In the deepest part of the archive. The part that technically doesn't exist." He spread them on the table — rolls of parchment, sheets of vellum in different ages of yellow, everything covered in that same precise, civil-servant handwriting. "The administrative chart I showed you — I was wrong about what it describes. It isn't a political structure." He looked at each of them in turn. "It's a guide. For a journey. Your journey, specifically. Every major location. Every significant enemy. Written before you arrived."

"Written by whom?" the Fighter asked.

"The archive doesn't say who started it. But the handwriting on the oldest documents matches the enchantments in the cave. The same as the corrupted forest seals. The same as the inscription the Arbiter guided you to." He paused. "And on the newest additions — Mordaine's correspondence. Her hand."

"Mordaine wrote a guide to defeating her?" the Cleric said.

"Not for her defeat. For your *challenge*." The scholar's voice dropped. "There's a note in the margin here. See this column? 'Expected party condition upon arrival.' This column: 'Estimated completion time.' This one..." He turned the page. Something in his expression shifted. He closed the document. "I think you should see Mordaine now."

"What does it say?" the Mage asked.

He looked at the Mage. "Things that wouldn't make sense to you yet." He refolded the documents with the care of someone returning artifacts to a vault. "Ask her yourself."

Chapter 9: The Throne

The palace was a dungeon that didn't know it was a dungeon. Every corridor was a test. Every room had a purpose beyond its decoration. The guards fought in patterns — not because they were disciplined, but because they couldn't do otherwise. The walls were hung with tapestries of the kingdom's history — a history that, examined closely, had been edited with a consistency that suggested a single revising hand.

King Aldric sat on his throne. He looked like a painting of a king — positioned correctly, lit properly, expression carefully neutral. When the party entered, his eyes moved, and for a moment something alive flickered behind the performance.

"You shouldn't be here," he said. His voice was his own, but the words felt borrowed. "She's trying to help. You have to understand that. Everything she does is because she believes—"

"That the kingdom needs order," the party finished. They'd heard the speech before. From the man in Eldertree. From the guards. From the Masterites themselves, in their own wordless way.

The king's eyes shifted — something breaking through the script, something personal rather than policy. "I know what she's done," he said, and the cadence was different. His own. "I know and I cannot—" He stopped. His hand moved to his heart, pressed flat. "I am still here. Somewhere. Underneath all of it." He looked at them with the eyes of a man looking through water. "If you can stop her. If you can stop what she's built. It won't undo what was done to me. But it might—"

His hand dropped. The performance resumed. His eyes went neutral again.

The Cleric stepped forward and pressed her hand over the king's. She said something too quiet to hear.

King Aldric blinked. Something like gratitude moved across his face before the policy returned.

The Curator of the Flame stood before the throne room doors.

She had the bearing of a scholar — not the dusty kind, but the kind that does field work and knows it. Scholar's robes, singed at the cuffs. A staff with a cupped flame at the top that had clearly been burning for years. A traveler's satchel with too many books in it. Her hair was done up practically, several quills tucked into it. She was speaking before the party had finished entering the antechamber. The Curator was always speaking — it was a structural feature of her personality, not a performance.

She had a voice that was professionally warm, the warmth of a lecturer who has learned that people absorb more when they feel welcome.

"Before we begin — and we will begin, I'm sorry about that — can I ask what you think is behind the flame?" She gestured toward the throne room doors with the open curiosity of someone who has been sitting with a question for years. "Not the literal throne room. Behind all of it."

"We'll know when we open the doors," the Fighter said.

"Of course you'll try. That's why you're here." She tilted her head slightly. "I've studied this room for eleven years. I know exactly what's in it. I am genuinely uncertain if what you're looking for is here." She said it with complete academic honesty, no artifice. "That's the most interesting thing that's happened all decade."

She paused, as though filing that observation, then: "I've been looking forward to this conversation. The Warden reports your adaptability. The Arbiter reports your irregular formation. The Tempo reports your decision-making under pressure." She spread her hands in a gesture of collegial invitation. "Tell me about your resource strategy. I've been studying it and I find myself with questions."

"We tend not to explain our strategy to the people guarding doors we need to open," the Rogue said.

"Of course, of course. I'll ask differently." The Curator gestured toward the party's formation with the attention of someone noting a particularly interesting specimen. "You — the healer. I've observed you keep something in reserve even when the rest of the party's resources are depleted. What's your threshold?" It turned to the Mage. "And you. Your magic output in the forest was seventy percent of what I'd expect from your displayed capacity. Why hold back?"

"We're not answering that," the Mage said.

"No, quite right. Good boundary-setting." The Curator's warmth was unwavering. "One more — the rogue. Three times in Scriptura you chose deception over direct engagement when direct engagement would have been faster. The preference for indirection. Is that habit or training or—"

"You're mapping our weaknesses," the Mage said.

"I'm having a conversation," the Curator said.

"And when the conversation ends, you'll fight us with everything we just told you."

A pause. The Curator's expression shifted — not to guilt, which would have been more comfortable, but to something like approval. "Your pattern recognition is excellent. The Arbiter mentioned it." It straightened. "Then let's skip to the relevant part. I cannot let you through. My purpose requires this. Everything I've learned in this conversation — everything you've said and carefully not said — will inform what follows." It met the party's eyes with the composed expression of someone who has done nothing they are ashamed of. "I hope you understand."

"We do," the Fighter said.

"Good," the Curator said, and the fight began.

They beat her with stubbornness. Stubbornness, it turned out, was not a resource the Curator could systematically drain, because the Curator had spent the entire conversation building a map of their resources and stubbornness was not on the map.

Throughout the fight, she had narrated her own abilities with something between professional interest and mild apology: "Mana drain. Sorry. Necessary." "Dispel — fascinating how clean that felt on your buffs." She had graded the party not harshly but with genuine scholarly notation: "Good positioning there. Sub-optimal there." When the Mage made a choice she hadn't predicted: "Interesting. I'll want to note that." She was doing two things at once and doing both thoroughly, and neither the fighting nor the scholarship ever quite won out.

When she fell, she knelt. Her expression was one of academic satisfaction, and also something else: a first note of surprise, genuine and unperformed.

"I don't know who you are, ultimately," she said. "But you are the most interesting research subject I've had since I started this post." And then, a beat later, as if revising: "No. That's not — I'm not certain that's the accurate summary." She looked at her own hands. "You did something in the last exchange that was not in any of my records. I was going to use the information about the healer's threshold against you. The bard said something quietly — and the threshold moved. It wasn't a resource change. It was something else." A long pause. "My records are extensive. I have no category for what I observed." She looked up, and there was something in the look that wasn't quite knowledge but was its close cousin. "There's something I wanted to tell you. About the flame. About what it's actually for. I don't think I have time now." She was quiet for a moment. "I hope you find out on your own." Then: "Make that mean something."

Chapter 10: Mordaine

She was waiting. Of course she was waiting.

The throne room was too large for one person, but Mordaine filled it anyway — not with size, but with *presence*. She stood at the foot of the throne, not on it. The king's seat remained empty above her, a prop she no longer needed.

"The irregulars," she said. Not with contempt. With recognition. The way a chess player acknowledges a piece that's moved further across the board than expected.

She was not what the party had been imagining since Eldertree. The tyrannical chancellors of stories were dramatic — grand gestures, sweeping robes, monologues that echoed. Mordaine was precise. Her robes were dark and unadorned. Her posture was the posture of someone who has long since stopped needing to perform power because the power is simply there. She looked at the five of them the way you look at a problem that has become, through some combination of persistence and luck, more interesting than you initially estimated.

"You are ahead of schedule," she said.

"What schedule?" the Mage asked.

"Mine." She moved to the window. Outside, Scriptura's clean streets caught the afternoon light, the flowers in their window boxes and the children in their courtyards, every element of the city performing normalcy with impeccable dedication. "The kingdom was chaotic when I arrived. The old king kind but ineffective. Monsters at the borders. Trade failing. I brought order." She turned back to face them. "Not because I wanted power. Because power, applied correctly, is simply the most efficient tool for reducing suffering. The kingdom functions. Its people are fed. The streets are safe."

"The people live in fear," the Fighter said.

"The people live." She met his eyes. "Fear is a cost I calculated was acceptable."

"You calculated people's fear," the Cleric said quietly.

"I calculated everything." She said it without apology. "Including you. You were the element I didn't account for, at first. Irregulars, untrained, unpredictable. And then—" A pause, brief as a held breath. "And then you became the most interesting observation I have made in a very long time."

The Bard said nothing. She was watching Mordaine's mouth, the way she chose words.

"The Warden tested you," she said. "The Arbiter tested you. The Tempore. The Curator. Each one reported back, and each report was more anomalous than the last." She looked at them with something that was

almost respect and was not quite anything else. "You passed every designed challenge by doing the thing no design anticipated. You were meant to be a demonstration of the system's resilience." She was quiet for a moment. "You were the element I didn't account for."

That phrase — she said it twice, and the second time it landed slightly differently. But the throne room was charged with the atmosphere of a final confrontation, and no one had the attention to wonder why.

"And Warden, and Arbiter, and Tempo, and Curator — they were your agents?" the Bard asked.

"They were the system's agents," she said, with a precision that seemed to matter to her. "Not mine personally. They exist to measure. To profile. To report." She paused. "They don't know that. They believe they are ancient guardians of the realm." Her voice held something that might have been affection, though it was difficult to be certain. "They do their work with great sincerity."

Silence.

"You gave them a purpose," the Cleric said, "that wasn't true."

"I gave them a purpose that was *functional*," she said. "They have guarded, and tested, and done their roles with exactness. Whether the purpose is true is a question that doesn't affect the outcome."

"It affects them," the Cleric said.

She looked at him for a long moment. "Yes," she said finally. "I suppose it does."

The fight was everything the Masterites had been training them for. Mordaine fought with court magic — elegant, formal, systematic. She summoned guards and dismissed them. She manipulated the battlefield itself, raising walls, shifting platforms, changing the rules mid-engagement. Not chaotically. *Methodically*. As though she were running a test.

Every time the party adapted, she adapted in response. When they focused fire on one target, she split their attention. When they spread out, she funneled them together. She was building a complete picture of how they handled every strategic situation, and the fight felt less like a battle than a very thorough examination.

They beat her the same way they had beaten everything else: by doing the thing that had no category in her records.

The Rogue, during a critical exchange when every other party member was occupied managing a summoned guard, walked up to Mordaine — not attacking, not flanking, just walking, in the way of someone who has decided the most disorienting thing they can do is behave completely normally — and said, very quietly, "The king is still in there. He spoke to us. The real one. He wants you stopped."

Mordaine hesitated. It was a fraction of a second. It was enough.

The Fighter's sword, the Mage's final fire bolt, and the Cleric's most focused prayer arrived simultaneously in the fraction of a second that Mordaine's calculation paused.

When her health hit zero, she didn't scream. She didn't curse. She looked at the party with an expression that was almost proud, and almost sad, and almost something with no name in a medieval vocabulary.

"This kingdom needed order," she said. "You needed a challenge. Both served their purpose."

She dissolved. Not in the way enemies dissolve — in smoke and light and theatrical satisfaction. She dissolved the way a thought dissolves. One moment she was there, fully real, fully present. The next, she was a memory. And the memory was already fading.

The throne room flickered. Not the lights — the *room*. The walls shuddered, and for a fraction of a second, the party saw something behind them. Not stone. Not darkness. Something else entirely. Something that looked like... suburbs.

Epilogue: After

In Harmonia Village, a device that had appeared in Dr. Temporal's workshop three weeks ago — "materialized overnight," he'd told everyone, as if that were an explanation rather than a confession — hummed to life. Its portal shimmered with images of parking lots and picket fences and a sky that was the wrong shade of blue.

They stood before it.

"Mordaine designed our journey," the Bard said. She had not put her quill away since the throne room. "All of it. The cave. The forest. The Masterites. Us."

"She designed a challenge," the Mage said. "We happened to be the ones inside it."

"That's not better."

"It's not worse either." He looked at the portal. "The design is real. The challenges were real. What we built — the way we fight, the way we adapt — that came from us, not from her."

"Does it count," the Rogue said, "if everything we overcame was built to be overcome?"

"Does any game count if the pieces were designed to fit together?" the Cleric said quietly.

The word landed strangely. No one could have said why. Game. A children's word. A word for dice and boards and rules someone else wrote. None of them had used it.

The Cleric had said it without seeming to notice, looking at the portal, turning something over in her mind the way you turn over a coin with an unfamiliar face.

"The diagram," the Bard said. "The administrative chart — it wasn't administrative at all. It was a map of phases." She looked at the portal. "And the scholar said there were five more like it." She looked at the portal. "This isn't a reward."

"No," the Mage agreed.

"It's the next one."

"Yes."

"And we're going anyway."

"We're going anyway," the Fighter said, and stepped through.

The medieval world didn't end behind them — it simply stopped being relevant. Like a chapter in a book no one was reading anymore.

Somewhere, something calibrated.

End of World 1

~ Phase Transition ~

The Neighborhood Problem

World 2 — Suburban

Prologue: The Wrong Side of the Portal

The portal didn't do what portals in stories are supposed to do.

There was no flash. No dramatic dimensional tearing. No void-crossing journey with stars streaking past, no cosmic perspective on the smallness of the self. There was a doorframe-shaped shimmer in the air of Harmonia Village, and then there was a step, and then there was sidewalk.

The transformation happened between the shimmer and the step.

The Fighter felt it first — a weight shift, a texture change. The gauntlets were gone. The pauldrons were gone. In their place: something stiff and polyester that smelled of a factory in a country he had no name for. He looked down. Dark trousers with a crease that was too sharp to be natural. A navy jacket with a badge. The badge said: SECURITY.

The sword was not gone. It had become a baton. He held it for a moment — same weight, same balance, same fundamental truth — and tried to decide whether to be concerned about this.

He was the Security Guard now. He didn't know what a security guard was. He just knew he was still the one who stood in front.

The Cleric's robes had become scrubs. Green. With small prints of what might have been angels but were probably more likely cartoon bears. Her holy symbol had become a laminated card that read SCHOOL NURSE and her leather medical satchel had become a first-aid kit that had somehow acquired a sticker of a smiling bandage.

She read the card twice. Then she looked at the Fighter's badge. Then she said, "I think we're still supposed to be helping people."

The Mage — who had gone through the portal in traveling robes with five pocket-books and a staff that crackled with latent fire — came out the other side in jeans and a t-shirt advertising a university whose name he didn't recognize, carrying a backpack and what appeared to be a scientific calculator. The staff was a pen. Specifically a pen that said PROPERTY OF MAPLE HEIGHTS MIDDLE SCHOOL DO NOT REMOVE, which he had not taken from any middle school, which made the inscription philosophically troubling.

He pressed the pen's button. It clicked. Something in the clicking felt like it still, potentially, contained fire.

The Rogue adjusted a hoodie that had appeared from somewhere. A skateboard had also appeared. The Rogue regarded it. There was no memory of ever having stood on a wheeled plank of wood. One foot went on it experimentally and immediately came off.

"I know how this works," the Rogue said, staring at the board. "I don't know how I know. I just do."

"New world," the Mage said, testing the calculator. "New context. Same skills, different costume."

The Bard was looking at himself in the reflection of a car window. The lute was gone. In its place: a trumpet case. He opened it. Examined the instrument. Raised it to his lips.

The sound that came out was not exactly music. It was the kind of sound produced by someone who knows in their bones that they are a musician but whose mouth has not yet introduced itself to this particular instrument. A nearby car alarm went off.

"I can work with this," he said, lowering the trumpet.

The man across the street, in cargo shorts and a polo, was watering his lawn. He looked at the five of them with the incurious eyes of a man who has decided that his lawn is his primary concern and everything else is peripheral.

"HOA meeting's not till Thursday," he said, and went back to watering.

Chapter 1: Maple Heights

The suburb existed in a state of aggressive normalcy. Every house was a variation on the same house — the same beige and ecru and off-white, differentiated only by which family had chosen a burgundy mailbox versus a black one, which driveway had a basketball hoop at the end. Every lawn was the same shade of green, maintained to the same height, edged with the same precision. From somewhere a few streets over, a dog was barking at something it had already forgotten about, and beneath the bark was the layered ambient sound of a hundred air conditioners running at once, a collective hum that wasn't quite audible as individual machines but assembled into a frequency that sat at the back of your awareness and stayed there. The sky was blue, but it was the wrong blue — not wrong in a way you could point to, but wrong in a way you could *feel*, like someone had looked up "sky blue" in a reference manual and matched the color exactly without ever having looked at an actual sky. The light was different from Harmonia's: softer, more diffuse, coming from everywhere and casting almost no shadow. Fluorescent-quality, though the sun was plainly present.

The party walked down Elm Street — there was also an Oak Street, a Maple Lane, and a Birch Court, because the naming committee had strong feelings about trees and weak feelings about creativity — and tried to understand what they were looking at.

"It looks like a village," the Fighter said. He was using the word because he didn't have another one.

"It looks like a village that's been through several stages of middle management," the Mage said. "Everything is the same distance apart. The same height. The same color within an approved range." He was writing in a new notebook — a spiral-bound one with a cartoon cat on the cover, which had appeared in his backpack and which he was already treating as canonical. "Someone standardized this."

"Someone standardized the trees," the Cleric said, looking at the evenly spaced oaks lining the street. "Those are the same species, the same age, the same pruning. That's not natural growth."

"Nothing here is natural growth," the Rogue said.

A kid on a bicycle rode past. He slowed down, circled back, and examined them with the open assessment of someone who has not yet learned to pretend they aren't staring.

"Cool cosplay," he said. "What convention?"

"We're not—"

"The mall has a Spirit Halloween now. Seasonal, obviously. You could probably get better armor there. No offense." He looked at the baton on the security guard's hip. "Or, like, the party store for the cop stuff. They have those."

He rode away. The party stood on the sidewalk and contemplated the concept of seasonal retail.

"He called this armor," the Fighter said, looking at his jacket.

"He called it *cosplay*," the Mage said. "Which means he thinks we're dressed as something." He looked down at his own outfit. "Dressed as people who belong in a different... genre."

"Dressed as ourselves in a different world," the Bard said. She had opened the trumpet case again and was touching the instrument with the tentative affection of someone bonding with livestock they hadn't chosen. "That's either profound or embarrassing and I haven't decided which."

The strip mall was two blocks east. It had a pizza place whose ventilation perfumed half the block with oregano and hot cardboard, a dry cleaner, a candle shop whose fragrance — something called "Coastal Linen Breeze" — leaked through the walls and competed aggressively with the pizza smell until both lost, and — inexplicably — an armory. Not a sporting goods store. An armory. It was wedged between the candle shop and a frozen yogurt place, and its sign read **YE OLDE MEDIEVAL SURPLUS** in a font that was trying very hard.

Inside, the shelves held items from Harmonia. Not similar items. The *same* items. Potions with the same labels. Swords with the same smithing marks. A shield that one of the party members was fairly certain they had seen on a rack in Ironclad Arms three days and one dimension ago.

The shopkeeper was a teenager in a vest who was doing something on her phone that required more attention than anything in the physical world.

"Everything's half off," she said, not looking up. "We got a huge shipment in from... I don't know, the warehouse? It just shows up."

"From Harmonia?" the Cleric asked.

"From wherever. I just ring them up." She tapped her screen. "You want the potions? They're the only things that actually work. The weapons are decorative, which I am legally required to say. The potions are just really good juice or whatever."

"They are very much not juice," the Rogue said.

"Right, yeah. Wink wink." She finally looked up, assessed the group, looked back at her phone. "You're from the other side of the portal, aren't you. Don't worry about it. People come through sometimes. You get used to it."

"Who else has come through?" the Mage asked.

"Mostly just you guys, lately." She scrolled through something. "The stuff tends to arrive in batches. Every few weeks there's a shipment. I stopped asking about the logistics." She shrugged. "The HOA keeps tabs on all of it. They keep tabs on everything."

"This HOA," the Mage said. "What are they, exactly?"

She finally set the phone down. "Honey," she said, and her voice had the tired patience of a seventeen-year-old who has been dealing with this for longer than seventeen-year-olds should have to deal with anything, "you are five people in costumes carrying medieval weaponry in a suburb where the mailboxes are *already* alive. You are maximum variance. The Coordinator is going to find you within the day. Stock up first."

Chapter 2: The Rules

The first encounter happened in a cul-de-sac three streets from the strip mall.

A lawn mower — a riding mower, red, the kind that men in the neighborhood discussed with the reverence usually reserved for warhorses — sat in someone's driveway until the party walked past it. Then it sat in the driveway differently. The blades, which had been still, began to spin with a sound like intent rather than mechanism. The engine coughed to life. The seat, empty, creaked as if taking weight.

The mower reversed out of the driveway.

"Oh no," said the Bard, who had the most active relationship with hope and therefore the most to lose.

Behind the mower, a mailbox opened its door with a creak that was too slow and too deliberate to be wind. Letters flew out — envelopes and flyers and what appeared to be a community newsletter — in a constellation pattern that suggested aerodynamic intention rather than postal chaos.

Behind that, a sprinkler system erupted from the lawn with pressure that shouldn't have been possible from residential plumbing, firing jets of water in tight, precise arcs.

"The lawn mower is the tank," the Mage said, backing up and pulling out his calculator. "High defense. Low mobility. Focus magical damage — fire pen, if the mower is combustible." He pressed a button on the calculator. "The mailbox has ranged attack and paper-cut damage, which sounds minor but—"

An envelope hit the Rogue in the ear with enough force to ring it. A sound of offense was made.

"—is not minor. Neutralize the mailbox first. The sprinkler has area control. We need to move constantly or it—"

The sprinkler tracked directly to the Fighter's position and hit him dead center in the chest.

"—locks on," the Mage finished. "It has targeting. Somehow."

The fight that followed was undignified in ways that the party had not, in their combined experience, encountered. Defeating a riding lawn mower with a security baton required a commitment to not thinking too hard about what you were doing. The Cleric's healing hands, applied to ears stinging from paper cuts, felt like a misallocation of divine grace. The Mage's fire — drawn from the pen, which did in fact contain fire, though less of it than the staff had managed — turned out to be rather more effective against a gas-powered engine than court magic had ever been against a stone golem, and the mower died with a spectacular exhaust backfire that set the Bard's pants briefly alight.

They won. No one felt good about it.

"What," said the Fighter — it didn't matter which of them said it first, because they were all thinking it — "is happening."

The mail carrier, who had watched the entire fight from behind her truck with the calm of someone who had seen this before, pulled off her headphones.

"It's been like this for months," she said. "Appliances going rogue. Kids disappearing — not missing, just... *relocated*. The HOA says it's 'community restructuring.' Nobody questions it because nobody questions the HOA."

"Why not?"

She looked at them the way you look at someone who has just asked why water is wet.

"Have you *met* the Coordinator?"

MEMO: RE: UNREGISTERED RESIDENTS

It has come to the Community Standards Board's attention that five (5) individuals of unknown origin have taken up residence within the Maple Heights Planned Community without submitting Form 7-A (New Resident Application), Form 12-C (Weapons Declaration — applicable to batons, swords repurposed as batons, and any pen-based pyrotechnic implements), or Form 3-F (Unusual Clothing Variance Request).

Additionally, said individuals have been observed engaging in unauthorized physical altercations with HOA-registered outdoor equipment (Incident Report #ML-4471, "Lawn Maintenance Encounter; Cul-de-Sac B"). The mower has been noted as nonoperational. This is a CODE VIOLATION.

These individuals are hereby required to report to the Community Center for processing.

Please note: failure to report within 24 hours will result in escalating compliance measures. These measures are calibrated to encourage cooperation rather than cause harm. Most residents find them quite persuasive.

Sincerely,

The Coordinator

Maple Heights HOA — "Your Home, Our Standards"

Chapter 3: The Warden of Routine

They met the first Masterite at the crosswalk on Birch Court and Cedar Avenue.

She was wearing an orange vest and carrying a STOP sign — the paddle kind, on a pole, that crossing guards use. She was standing in the exact center of the crosswalk, and she had clearly been standing there for some time, because the paint of the walk had worn around her feet in the pattern of long occupancy.

She held up the sign as they approached.

"Halt," she said.

"We need to cross the street," the Fighter said.

"No crossing without the signal," the Warden of Routine said. She did not move. She had not moved in a very long time. Her expression was the expression of someone who has found, in the management of a single intersection, the complete expression of their purpose — not a narrow purpose, a sufficient one. "The signal says WALK. I say WALK. Not before. Not after. Not due to extenuating circumstances." She said it with the tone of someone who has said it many times and found it no less true for the repetition. "I have been doing this job for a very long time. I am not going to stop because you are in a hurry."

"There's no traffic," the Mage said, looking both ways at the completely empty street.

"The absence of visible traffic does not indicate the absence of traffic." The Warden turned the sign toward them. STOP. "This intersection has been under my supervision since the beginning of the neighborhood. I have never had an incident. I intend to maintain that record."

"We'll be quick," the Rogue said.

"Crossing without the signal is a violation. Violations are not quick. Violations have consequences. Consequences take time." Her grip on the pole tightened. "Stand behind the line."

The Mage looked at the ground. There was no painted line.

"There's no line."

"The line is implied," the Warden said. "Resident knowledge of implied lines is part of community standards compliance."

"We're not residents."

"You're standing in my intersection. That makes you my responsibility." She raised the stop sign slightly. "And you are out of compliance."

The fight was disorienting in the way that only truly committed bureaucratic obstruction can be. The Warden hit with the stop sign — which was, it turned out, enchanted in the same way the Warden of the Old Guard's shield had been, with the same kind of structured force that had no right being present in a road safety implement. She placed traffic cones with a precision that constrained the party's movement. She deployed speed bumps from her vest pockets that appeared on the battlefield floor and caused genuine tactical problems.

She was difficult in the way a truly well-designed obstacle is difficult. Not unfair. Just: committed to her purpose beyond any reasonable interpretation of that purpose.

When she finally went down — when the Cleric's persistence and the Mage's creative application of electrical interference (traffic signals ran on circuits; the pen, as it turned out, also ran on circuits, after a fashion) broke through her endurance — she set her stop sign carefully against a lamppost and sat on the curb.

"I don't understand," she said, and the voice was the same controlled, professional tone, but with something under it that hadn't been there before. "I've never lost a crossing before."

She looked at the stop sign leaning against the lamppost. She sat on the curb.

"You may cross," she said.

"Thank you," the Cleric said.

"You're welcome." A long pause. Then: "I've been here such a long time." She said it simply, a fact being recognized rather than shared. "I've been here such a long time. I don't know where I was before." She looked at the empty street. "I've been at this crosswalk for... how long?" She frowned at the pavement. "It feels like longer than the neighborhood's been here."

"How long has the neighborhood been here?" the Mage asked.

"Since the beginning." The Warden looked up at them. "That's what I was told. This neighborhood has always been here. I have always been at this intersection." She paused. "Except I can't remember the first day."

I can't remember being assigned here. I just... was. And then I was here." She picked up the sign again with the automatic motion of someone who needs to be doing their job or the ground feels uncertain. "You should cross now. Before traffic comes."

There was, as there had been throughout the conversation, no traffic.

They crossed.

Chapter 4: Garage Sales and Other Hazards

The garage sale on Oak Street had a sign: EVERYTHING MUST GO. The sign was large and bright and clearly visible from both directions, which was why the party stopped.

They should not have stopped.

The tables were covered with the detritus of suburban accumulation — ceramic figurines, folded sweaters, stacks of VHS tapes, a bread maker with the hopeful air of something that had been used twice and kept in case of a second chance. Behind the tables, an older woman in a floral dress sat in a lawn chair reading a paperback, the entirety of her garage laid out for the neighborhood's consideration. The driveway smelled of hot concrete and the faint vanilla of the candle shop three blocks over, and a portable radio on the folding table beside her played an oldies station with the low volume of something that was always on, had always been on, would always be on.

"Half off everything," she said, not looking up. "Cash only. No returns."

The Cleric, who had the clearest understanding of the party's financial situation in this world and had discovered that a nurse's salary did not, in fact, exist in their cash-on-hand, began examining the tables for anything useful.

She picked up a sweater.

The sweater resisted.

Not with the passive resistance of a sweater that has tangled on something. With the active resistance of a sweater that has decided it does not want to leave. It pulled back. The Cleric pulled forward. It escalated. Within three seconds, three additional items had joined the conflict: a ceramic rooster, a set of mixing bowls stacked in a tower, and a garden gnome that had somehow repositioned itself from the far end

of the table to directly in front of the Rogue, who had been thinking about the garden gnome and whether its slightly threatening smile was intentional design or unfortunate craftsmanship.

"I probably shouldn't have touched the sweater," the Cleric said, still holding her end of it.

"No one told us about the sweater," the Rogue said, taking a step back from the gnome.

"The sign says everything must go," the older woman said, turning a page. "It doesn't say it has to be *easy*."

The garden gnome lunged.

What followed was a full engagement with four enchanted garage sale items across a cluttered suburban driveway, which required more spatial awareness than any of the cave fights had, because the terrain was tables and price-tagged knickknacks and a bread maker that had apparently decided this was its moment. The ceramic rooster's pecking attack was technically weaker than most cave goblins but it was ceramic and therefore could not be persuaded to stop by being spoken to. The mixing bowls operated in formation. The gnome was fast in the specific way of things that should not be fast, which is to say startlingly.

They managed it — the Fighter's baton was well-suited to the gnome situation, the Mage's electrical pen had interesting effects on ceramic, and the Rogue solved the mixing bowl formation problem by the simple expedient of stacking them in a different order, which seemed to break the enchantment.

The sweater, finally, let go.

The older woman had not looked up during any of this.

"You can keep the sweater," she said. "You earned it."

The Cleric examined the sweater. It was warm. It had a small embroidered bear on the pocket. It was, all things considered, quite nice.

She kept it.

Chapter 5: The Arbiter of the Grade

The school sat at the end of Maple Lane with the weight of a building that knows it is important. MAPLE HEIGHTS ELEMENTARY, read the sign out front, and below that, in smaller letters: EXCELLENCE THROUGH ACCOUNTABILITY.

Inside, the hallway had the specific institutional smell of carpet shampoo and old coffee and something laminated — achievement posters on every wall, motivational eagles saying things like SOAR ABOVE THE STANDARD and THERE IS NO SHORTCUT TO MASTERY. The hallway was longer than the building's exterior suggested it should be, and the fluorescent lights hummed at a frequency just barely audible, the way they always did in buildings where children were required to be evaluated.

They had been inside for approximately forty seconds when the loudspeaker crackled.

"Good morning, unregistered visitors. Please proceed directly to Room 204 for assessment. Refusal to proceed constitutes a violation of school policy and will be noted in your permanent record."

"We don't have permanent records," the Rogue said.

"Yet," said the loudspeaker, and clicked off.

Room 204 had the ambient temperature of a place where stress lived and raised a family. The desks were standard school desks with the attached flip-up writing surface, arranged in perfect rows. At the front stood a man in a dress shirt and tie who had the bearing of someone who considered a three-point rubric to be a statement of personal philosophy.

The Arbiter of the Grade looked at the party and began distributing papers.

"Pop quiz," he said.

"We're not students," the Fighter said.

"This school serves the community," the Arbiter said. "You are in the community. You are being served." He set the papers down with precision — one in front of each party member. "You have eight minutes."

The Mage picked up his paper. The first question read: *Identify the underlying economic conditions that led to the decline of the merchant class in the transitional period between feudal and proto-capitalist systems of resource distribution. Show all work.*

"That's a graduate-level economics question," he said.

"The rubric rewards partial credit," the Arbiter said.

The Rogue's first question: *Your skateboard travels at an average speed of 12 kilometers per hour. You are being pursued by a compliance officer at 15 kilometers per hour. The officer began pursuit 200 meters behind you. How long until you are apprehended, and is this outcome avoidable?*

"This one's personal," the Rogue said.

"All learning is personal," the Arbiter said pleasantly. Then he looked at the Rogue with the small, precise smile of a man who has constructed this moment with care. "Or perhaps *you* find it personal because of certain observable patterns in your behavioral record. Yes?" He let the implication settle. "Pencils up."

The quiz attacks were, in practice, each wrong answer manifesting as direct damage — specific, targeted, and scaled to the magnitude of the incorrectness rather than simply the occurrence of an error. The correct answers reduced the damage but did not eliminate it entirely, because, as the Arbiter noted, the learning curve was the point.

The Bard answered every question in verse and received partial credit on all of them, which was the highest partial credit the Arbiter had ever awarded to a non-standard response format. He did not mention this without appending: "Charming. Incomplete. C-plus."

The Cleric answered her questions ("Define the moral calculus of triage in a resource-limited medical setting, citing at least two ethical frameworks") with the genuine thoughtfulness of someone who had actually practiced triage and found the academic framework less useful than the lived version. The Arbiter marked two of her answers incorrect due to "insufficient citation."

"Your answers are experientially correct," the Arbiter said, in the tone of someone delivering a diagnosis. "Academically, however, you lack rigor. What you know and what you can demonstrate you know are not the same thing, and I grade the demonstration." He added a note to his grade book. "That gap tends to limit people. I expect it's limited you before."

"It hasn't," the Cleric said quietly.

"The grade disagrees," the Arbiter said, and turned back to the room.

The fight broke out when the Fighter answered the question about the chain of command in a feudal military hierarchy by explaining, with polite earnestness, that in his experience the chain of command ran directly to whoever was willing to do the work, and the Arbiter declared this ideologically out of standard and assigned a zero.

"You cannot assign me a zero," the Fighter said. "I answered correctly."

"The answer was not within the established parameters," the Arbiter said.

"The parameters are wrong."

"The parameters are the rubric," the Arbiter said, and the rubric appeared as a physical document, and the physical document became a weapon in a way that felt like either metaphor or justice depending on your perspective.

The grading battle was close. The Arbiter's academic precision translated into a fighting style of calibrated, optimal strikes — the same principle as the medieval Arbiter, rephrased for a setting where the vocabulary of excellence was measured in percentages. It adapted with the particular cruelty of someone who had been doing this long enough to know exactly which failures to hold up. When the Mage's counterattack faltered, the Arbiter noted it — not tactically, but personally: "Interesting. Your theory outpaces your execution. I've seen that before. It tends not to improve." When the Bard's trumpet missed its effect window, the Arbiter clicked his pen. "Timing. Your greatest weakness. The rubric rewards completion, not intention."

They passed. Technically. The Cleric's rubric-compliant approach and the Mage's technically correct answers on the science and mathematics questions accumulated enough points to meet the curve.

The Arbiter received this outcome with the equanimity of a man consulting a ledger and finding a line he doesn't quite understand.

"A," he said. He wrote it in the grade book. A small pause. "No conditions. That was an A."

"My rubric was perfect," he continued, sitting on the edge of his desk. "My curve was calibrated precisely. How did you pass without studying?"

"We studied our whole lives," the Mage said. "Just not these subjects."

"The underlying principles are the same," the Cleric added. "Every healing decision uses triage logic. Every tactical choice is resource allocation."

The Arbiter looked at his grade book. Something moved across his face that was not quite recognition and not quite discomfort. "You are not the students this curriculum was designed for," he said. "And yet the curriculum worked." A pause. "Partially. With significant deviation." He closed the grade book. "I don't know whether to mark that as a success."

He was quiet for a moment, looking at the cover of the grade book in the way of a man who has just noticed the title of a book he's been reading for years. "I don't know what class this is for," he said. "I've been grading it a long time." Another pause. "I'm not sure anymore what the subject is."

"Mark it as interesting," the Bard suggested.

"I don't have a column for interesting," the Arbiter said. But he wrote something in the margin anyway, and when he wrote it, his pen moved with the particular slowness of someone writing something they didn't expect to write.

MEMO: RE: ACADEMIC INCIDENT REPORT #204-B

This memo is to document the unauthorized completion of assessment materials by five (5) unregistered community members in Room 204 on the afternoon of the above date.

Results summary: Two subjects demonstrated mastery. Two subjects demonstrated partial mastery. One subject provided all answers in rhyming couplets, which is not within the rubric parameters but which I have, after considerable deliberation, elected to score as demonstrating a nonstandard form of competency.

I am flagging this incident for the Coordinator's attention not because the subjects failed — they did not — but because their success was achieved through methodologies that fall outside the designed parameters. The rubric cannot account for applied experience. I have noted this as a gap in the assessment framework.

I am also noting, for the record, that the subject who answered entirely in verse told me my rubric was "a love letter to certainty in an uncertain world." I have been thinking about this.

I want it on record that I do not know why I have been thinking about this.

— Arbiter of the Grade

cc: Coordinator's Office

DO NOT FORWARD TO PARENT DISTRIBUTION LIST

Chapter 6: The Tempo of the Rush Hour

They heard the car before they saw it.

It was the kind of sound a car makes when it has been asked to operate at a speed that implies a philosophical commitment to arriving. The engine had clearly been modified. The suspension had clearly been abused. The car itself — a beat-up compact with a magnetic sign on the roof reading MAPLE HEIGHTS PIZZA — came around the corner of Birch Court at a speed that was ambitious for a residential zone, trailing the smell of exhaust and hot cheese from its previous runs.

The window rolled down. A head appeared.

"THIRTY MINUTES OR LESS!" shouted the Tempo of the Rush Hour.

"Thirty minutes or less what?" the Cleric said.

"EVERYTHING! ALL OF IT! WHAT DO YOU MEAN WHAT?"

The answer was the car accelerating toward them.

The chase through Maple Heights' subdivisions was a different kind of test than the forest run had been. Scriptura's alleys had been navigable, knowable. The suburb's cul-de-sacs and through-streets and sudden dead ends were designed with the logic of a place that expected its residents to have GPS and twenty years of familiarity. The party had

neither. The Tempo had both, and the car, and a genuine professional commitment to completing the delivery that had curdled somewhere along the way into something more absolute.

"THIRTY MINUTES!" came from two streets over. "THE TIMER IS RUNNING! THE TIMER IS ALWAYS RUNNING!"

"What timer?" the Bard shouted, running.

"THE ONE THAT SAYS THIRTY MINUTES OR LESS OR WHAT'S THE POINT! WHAT IS THE POINT IF NOT THE TIME! I HAVE BEEN DOING THIS EVERY NIGHT OF MY ENTIRE LIFE AND I HAVE NEVER BEEN LATE AND I WILL *NOT* START NOW—"

The car clipped a fire hydrant with the confidence of something that has decided fire hydrants are an acceptable cost.

The Rogue discovered, around the second lap of the subdivision, that the skateboard worked the way it was supposed to work — which is to say that it translated the Rogue's existing spatial instincts into a different vocabulary. A car could not fit where the Rogue could fit. The Tempo was led down a footpath between houses that ended in a yard with a fence.

The car hit the fence. The fence won, temporarily.

In the moment of the Tempo's extraction from the fence situation — car in reverse, backing onto the street, engine screaming, driver still audibly explaining the thirty-minute guarantee to no one in particular — the party assembled.

The fight was fast and loud and municipal-scale wrong. The Tempo used the car itself as a weapon of crowd control, and the Fighter's baton against the chassis had the same structural logic as sword against armor but with worse optics. The Mage's electrical pen had excellent synergy with a car engine, which he noted with academic satisfaction. The Bard played the trumpet during the fight, which either boosted the party or confused the Tempo or both; the causality was unclear and she didn't stop.

When the car finally sputtered out — electrical system compromised, fence-damage compounded — the Tempo stepped out, brushing broken glass from the pizza company's branded windbreaker. The manic frequency was gone. What replaced it was quieter, and the quiet seemed to surprise the Tempo as much as anyone.

"Heck of a chase," the Tempo said, with genuine appreciation. "I've been doing this route my whole life." They looked at the car. Back at the party. "Except..." Something shifted in the easy confidence of the expression. "I don't remember starting. I've been delivering to this neighborhood my whole life, and I remember every house, every regular order, every dog that runs at the car, but I don't remember the first delivery." They looked at their own hands. "That's weird, right? That should be weird."

"It's okay," the Cleric said.

"It's *not* okay," the Tempo said, not with anger but with the specific distress of someone accessing a feeling they weren't prepared to have. "A person remembers their first job. A person remembers the beginning." They looked up. "How long have you been doing yours?"

"We've been doing ours," the Bard said carefully, "since a notice was nailed to a door."

"That's specific." The Tempo looked at the party with new attention. "That's a beginning. That's a real one." Something moved behind their eyes. "I want one of those. I should have one of those." They looked at the insulated bag, still sitting on the car's passenger seat. Picked it up. Didn't open it. "I don't know what's in this. I've never opened it. I've delivered it every night of my life and I don't know who I'm delivering it to." They set it down again. "Thirty minutes or less. It's not a slogan. It's — it was supposed to be something. I just don't know what anymore."

They drove away, slowly, one wheel bent, and the party stood in a cul-de-sac at the end of Birch Court and watched them go.

Chapter 7: Feral Infrastructure

The parking lot of the strip mall had, in the weeks since the party arrived, been developing a reputation.

Specifically: a shopping cart.

Not a fleet of shopping carts. One. The others were docked in their return stations, compliant, corralled. This one had escaped its corral at some point and had been ranging freely through the parking lot, operating on a logic that no one had yet reverse-engineered. It did not move when observed. It moved when you turned your back. It had,

according to the teenager at Ye Olde Medieval Surplus, been "coming in through the back door" after hours, and she had stopped questioning it because there were larger problems.

The party encountered the feral shopping cart while trying to take a shortcut through the parking lot to the community center. The asphalt was sticky with the afternoon heat, and the smell of the pizza place was stronger out here than inside — the full exhaust from the commercial oven venting into the alley, oregano and grease and the faint sulfur of the gas line.

It was waiting.

Not ambushing, precisely. More: positioned. Positioned in the way that the Warden had been positioned in the cave — with the deliberate patience of something that has taken a job seriously and is ready to do it. The cart was blocking the most direct path.

"Are we going to fight a shopping cart," the Rogue said.

"We fought a lawn mower," the Cleric said.

"The lawn mower had context. The mower was protecting the lawn. This cart is—"

The cart charged.

Shopping carts are not aerodynamically designed for speed, but this one had apparently solved that problem through a combination of resolve and the slight downward grade of the parking lot. It hit the Fighter's shins with authority and then spun, which carts do, but this spin was controlled, a defensive rotation that put the sharp corner toward the next attacker.

"It fights like a Tempo," the Mage said. "Speed-based. Uses geometry."

"It's a *shopping cart*," the Rogue said.

"It's a very good shopping cart," the Bard said, backing away from it.

They drove it into the cart return. This required everyone working in concert, because the cart didn't want to go, and there was a dignity-versus-effectiveness tension in the project of physically herding an enchanted shopping cart into a designated return space. But once it was there — once it was *corralled* — something went out of it. The enchantment, or whatever it was, dissipated. The wheels locked. The cart became, again, just a cart.

"I feel bad," the Cleric said.

"Don't feel bad about the cart," the Rogue said.

"It was just doing what carts do," the Cleric said. "It was just doing it with more commitment than expected."

"We put it back where it belongs," the Fighter said. "That's not a cruelty."

Nobody said anything. It was a parking lot. They moved on.

Chapter 8: The Coordinator's Memos (A Collection)

MEMO: RE: STATUS UPDATE — COMPLIANCE OPERATIONS

This memo is for internal distribution only.

As of this writing, the five (5) unregistered subjects have defeated three (3) of four (4) designated compliance-testing agents. Performance summary:

— Warden of Routine: Subjects demonstrated sustained damage output and adaptive positioning. Loss condition met. Warden has been expressing unusual self-reflection, which is off-profile. Monitoring.

— Arbiter of the Grade: Subjects demonstrated unconventional competency metrics. Passed on a curve that I specifically calibrated to be uncurvable. I am revising the assessment rubric. This is the third revision. I am beginning to question the rubric.

— Tempo of the Rush Hour: Subjects demonstrated spatial reasoning and teamwork under mobile pursuit conditions. Tempo has been "thinking about beginnings," which is also off-profile. This is becoming a pattern.

Note: the off-profile self-reflection among testing agents was not within parameters. I am noting it. I am uncertain what to do about it. This is itself unusual, as I am not typically uncertain about what to do.

These subjects are ahead of schedule. They were ahead of schedule in the previous phase as well. I am recalibrating expected timeline.

Additionally, I am flagging the following: one subject has been maintaining detailed notes throughout the residential phase. Her documentation methodology is thorough and her pattern recognition is exceptional. She will likely reach conclusions I had hoped to defer.

I do not find this alarming. I find it... interesting. This is also unusual.

— The Coordinator

Maple Heights HOA — "Your Home, Our Standards"

MEMO: RE: ITEM ESCALATION — GARAGE SALE INCIDENT

I must note for the record that the garage sale enchantments at 14 Oak Street were performing at expected parameters until the subject in the nurse's uniform picked up the beige sweater and chose to keep it. The sweater was programmed to deter. She kept it anyway. She is wearing it.

This was not a designed outcome. The sweater is not meaningful. And yet.

She is wearing it in a way that suggests it is.

I am noting this because I track all deviations from expected subject behavioral patterns and this is a deviation. I am not noting this because I have any particular feeling about it. I am simply thorough.

The subject in the nurse's uniform has a high degree of what my old metrics called "faith investment" and what I am revising my metrics to call "quality of attention." She attends to things — the old king, the Warden's lesson, the sweater — in a way that my models struggle to account for.

I do not know what to do with "quality of attention" as a metric.

I am flagging this as a gap in my assessment framework. The Arbiter flagged the same thing. We are converging on the same gap from different directions. This is either a coincidence or it is not.

— The Coordinator

Chapter 9: The Curator of the Budget

The accountant had an office in the strip mall, between the frozen yogurt place and the candle shop. The door had a handwritten sign: BUDGET SOLUTIONS — WALK-INS WELCOME. The sign was a lie, but the door was unlocked.

Inside: a desk covered in ledgers. A woman in business casual — badge on a lanyard, a tablet under one arm, a very thick folder of documents under the other. Her posture was the posture of someone who had been in too many meetings but was doing very well at them. A filing cabinet that occupied far more wall than the room's geometry should have allowed. The smell of toner and whatever the anxiety of a hundred audited people leaves behind in the air of a small office.

The Curator of the Budget looked up from her spreadsheets. She did not look dangerous. She looked at the party with the patient pleasure of someone who has been thorough and intends them to feel it.

"Ah," she said. "The irregulars."

"You know who we are," the Mage said.

"I know your financial profile," he said. He said it the way people say *I know your reputation* — with the precise, savoring emphasis of someone who has been thorough and intends you to feel it. "Fourteen potions consumed over the residential phase. Two swords — one with irregular provenance, one repurposed from a medieval baton-equivalent. Total GP equivalent spent at Ye Olde Medieval Surplus: seventy-three dollars and forty cents." He turned the ledger toward them. "You're not from here. Your itemized deductions are unusual." He tapped the page, and there was something almost fond about the tap, the fond attention of a collector identifying a rare specimen. "Medieval healing potions. Those aren't in any tax bracket I recognize."

"We've been spending across multiple jurisdictions," the Mage said, because this was, technically, the most accurate description he had available.

"Multi-jurisdictional deductions are complicated," the Curator said. The pleasure in her voice was undisguised. "Oh, *very* complicated. You'll need to document the point of origin for each item separately." She produced a form. It was IRS Form 4797. It had been modified to include

a field labeled "POINT OF ORIGIN" and another labeled "RESOURCE STATE AT COMMUNITY ENTRY." "I've taken the liberty of beginning your assessment. I'll need the primary taxpayer to sit down."

"We're not filing taxes," the Rogue said.

"You have resources," the Curator said. "Resources imply taxation. Taxation implies filing." She opened her briefcase with the careful motion of someone revealing something they have been looking forward to revealing. Inside: a clipboard, a calculator that was much better than the Mage's, and what appeared to be a weapon made of laminated forms. "I'll need receipts for the potions. All of them. Going back to your first purchase in World One." She looked up. "Oh — you didn't keep receipts, did you?" The smile that followed was small, precise, and deeply satisfied. "That's going to be a problem."

The fight with the Curator of the Budget was a sustained drain — not on health, but on every other resource the party had accumulated. The laminated forms could strip potions from inventory. The audit conducted mid-battle identified every buff the party was running and filed for an "itemized deduction" against each one. The briefcase contained a secondary filing that appeared to function as a debuff cloud. At one point, the calculator produced a number that was described, mechanically, as "your remaining resource potential after deductions," and the number was not zero but it was low.

"You are running at a net negative," the Curator said, halfway through. She was not gloating exactly. She was *reporting*, but the report had the particular enunciation of someone who has been waiting to deliver this specific news for a long time. "Current asset-to-liability ratio suggests you cannot sustain this engagement." A pause. "I could extend the audit timeline. Give you a chance to recover. That's not typical procedure, but—" She let the offer sit. She enjoyed watching people consider accepting help from the person causing the problem.

"Then we'd better end it," the Mage said, and stopped holding back his electrical pen.

The pen had been, throughout the suburban phase, operating at somewhere between sixty and seventy percent capacity. The fire was there. The electricity was there. The magic was there. But the world's genre had imposed friction — the same way the sword had become a baton, the staff had become a pen, and something about *pen* said *careful*, said *precise*, said *measured*.

The Mage decided to stop being measured.

The Curator's filing cabinet opened during the burst, and the files inside flew — and they were, it turned out, a mistake. Not malicious. Not strategic. Each file was a record: purchase histories, HOA violation reports, and something else, something at the back, something labeled with the party's names and the heading "SUBJECT PROFILES — FORWARDED TO COORDINATOR."

They had three seconds to read before the files dispersed.

What the Mage read in those three seconds, he wrote down later, in the spiral notebook with the cartoon cat cover.

The Curator received her defeat with the silence of someone who has received bad news from a ledger before and has developed equanimity through practice.

"This has never happened before," she said, as the files settled. "I'm going to need to file a correction."

A longer pause than usual. "I've been filing corrections for a long time. I don't know where they go. I've never received a response." She looked at the folder in her hands. "I've filled a lot of folders."

"Your itemized deductions," she continued, "are unlike anything in the system." She looked at her own hands — at the forms, the clipboard, the briefcase. "And my system is comprehensive. My records here cover every resident since the neighborhood was established." She looked up. "I have records for residents who do not remember living here. I have records for people who don't exist in any other database." A pause. Her voice had lost the tidy pleasure it had carried through the audit. "That should bother me more than it does."

"Does it bother you at all?" the Cleric asked.

"Yes," the Curator said, after a moment. "A little. More today than yesterday." She closed the briefcase. "That's new."

Chapter 10: The Monitor

The community center occupied the exact geographic center of Maple Heights, which was either a coincidence or a statement.

Inside, it was beige in the specific institutional way of buildings that were designed for function and decorated with whatever the budget allowed after function was achieved. The meeting rooms had names — Oak Room, Maple Room, Cedar Room — and motivational posters at consistent intervals, the kind with eagles and sunsets and words like PERSEVERANCE in a font that believed in itself. The carpet was the particular pattern of commercial carpet whose primary purpose is to hide what has been spilled on it over the years. The smell was old coffee and toner and the ghost of a hundred laminated agendas.

They found the back entrance through the Oak Room — one of the meeting rooms named after trees, which the Rogue had identified during the third day of their residence as the most navigable part of the building from a structural standpoint. The hallway beyond the meeting rooms was longer than the building should have allowed, which was the kind of spatial inconsistency that had stopped startling them roughly around the third day.

The Coordinator's private office was at the end.

It was immaculate. A desk. A lamp. A filing cabinet that contained folders for every resident of Maple Heights, cross-referenced by violation type and compliance score. The folders for the party were the thickest. Their labels read: UNREGISTERED. STATUS: ACTIVE.

And on the desk, a monitor.

The screen showed footage: the cave near Harmonia. The forest. Scriptura's market district. A split-screen of locations they had traveled through, recorded from angles that suggested something had been watching above them the entire time. In one corner, numbers scrolled — tallied encounters. Party composition. Timestamps. A column labeled SUBJECT BEHAVIORAL PATTERNS with entries like "cautious," "adaptive," "irregular."

The Fighter looked at the screen for a long moment. "She has surveillance across the whole route," he said. "Back to the cave."

"Surveillance," the Mage said, writing. "Yes. That's what it is."

"You're not supposed to see that," said a voice from the doorway.

The Coordinator stood there. She was exactly what the memos had suggested — neat, precise, controlled. Middle-aged. Glasses. The kind of person who had never been late for anything in her life, including her

own birth. She wore the expression of someone who has found a variance in their system and is assessing whether it is a problem or data.

"But then," she continued, straightening a pen on the desk that was already straight, "you weren't supposed to get this far. The previous phase usually takes longer."

She said it like she was commenting on a schedule deviation. Not angry. Not threatened. Just noting the variance.

"Who are you?" the party asked.

"I'm the Coordinator," she said. "I coordinate."

"You're doing more than that."

She smiled. It was the most unsettling smile any of them had ever seen, because it was *genuine*.

"Yes," she said. "I suppose I am."

"Mordaine," the Bard said. She had her notebook open. She had been writing since the filing cabinet. "Chancellor Mordaine said: 'This kingdom needed order. You needed a challenge. Both served their purpose.'" She looked up. "You're going to say something like that."

A pause. The Coordinator's expression did not change.

"The neighborhood needed rules," she said. "You needed resistance. Both served their purpose."

The Bard closed her notebook. She didn't close it with satisfaction, the way you close a notebook when you've written something worth keeping. She closed it the way you close a door on a room you're not sure you wanted to enter.

"Yes," she said. "That's it."

The fight was bureaucratic in the same way that all Mordaine's masks were bureaucratic — the Coordinator fought with the tools of administration, elevated. Forms materialized as barriers. Memos became projectile attacks. The filing cabinet opened and folders flew out, each one containing a record of every mistake the party had ever made — every suboptimal decision, every failed strategy, every wasted resource. And each record *hurt*, because documentation, wielded correctly, is leverage.

But where Mordaine had manipulated the battlefield physically, the Coordinator manipulated *context*. When the Fighter swung his baton, a form appeared mid-swing: LIABILITY WAIVER — PLEASE SIGN BEFORE PROCEEDING WITH PHYSICAL ENGAGEMENT. He didn't sign it. The form cited him for the unsigned form. The citation accumulated to a fine. The fine extracted gold from the party's inventory.

"You're weaponizing paperwork," the Mage said, blocking a memo with his notebook.

"I'm streamlining accountability," the Coordinator said.

They won. The same way they had won against Mordaine — not through optimal strategy, because optimal strategy was something the Coordinator could predict and counter. Through the accumulated specific knowledge of who they had become since Harmonia.

The Cleric healed beyond reasonable resource parameters because she had made a habit of keeping something in reserve for the moment when things looked impossible.

The Mage stopped being measured.

The Rogue found angles that the Coordinator's spatial models didn't account for, because the Coordinator's models were built on a neighborhood she understood and the Rogue had spent an entire career exploiting the assumption of the predictable.

The Fighter, when a liability form appeared mid-swing, reached into his jacket with his off hand and produced a pen — the Bard's extra pen, borrowed before the community center visit — and signed it without stopping the swing. The form dissolved. The fine didn't apply.

"You cannot both sign and contest," the Coordinator said, briefly wrong-footed.

"I signed," the Fighter said. "I didn't contest. I just continued." He met her eyes. "There's no form for that."

She lost. Of course she lost. That was the point. And when she dissolved — the same way Mordaine had dissolved, the same absence rather than an ending — her final words carried the same vocabulary, the same philosophy, the same particular weight.

"You're ahead of schedule," she said. "The next phase will require... adjustments."

Chapter 11: After

The monitor on her desk flickered. The surveillance footage vanished. In its place: a schematic of gears. Brass. Steam. Victorian architecture. A label in the Coordinator's careful handwriting: *Phase 3 — Cogsworth Junction.*

The party stood in the Coordinator's office with the files still scattered and the sense of something ending that was not quite a victory.

"She talked like Mordaine," the Bard said.

"The same words," the Mage said. "'Order.' 'Purpose.' 'The system.'"

"The same philosophy," the Rogue said. "Not just similar — the same. Like someone wrote the same speech twice in different handwriting."

"That reminded you of her," the Bard said carefully. "Didn't it."

"It was... familiar," the Cleric said. She was looking at the window, the wrong-blue sky. "The way she moved. The way she held herself when she was certain." She turned. "Did that remind any of you of—"

"Mordaine," the Fighter said. "Yes."

Nobody said the next thing for a moment. The thing that was sitting in the room with them, waiting to be said.

"Not the same person," the Mage said finally. "That would be impossible. Different world. Different body. Different name." He was writing, and his pen was moving faster than usual. "But the same... shape. Of reasoning. Of purpose." He looked up. "As if someone built both of them to the same specifications."

"The HOA surveillance goes back to Harmonia," the Fighter said. "She was watching us in the cave. Before we arrived here."

"She was tracking us," the Mage said. "Both of them. In sequence."

The word *sequence* landed in the room like a coin placed deliberately on a table.

"The memos," the Rogue said. "She called us 'subjects.' Ahead of schedule." The Rogue picked up one of the Coordinator's files — a resident's compliance history, years of it, meticulously documented. "All of this is just measurement. Every encounter, every Masterite, every lawn mower. It's measuring something about us."

"For what?" the Cleric asked.

Nobody answered. The monitor showed gears turning. The office walls began to change — the beige fading, brass creeping in at the edges, the smell of oil and coal smoke threading through the lavender candle scent that had been following them since the strip mall.

"The Masterites," the Fighter said quietly. "The Warden asked if we'd earned the right to rest. The Arbiter asked where we learned to fight. The Tempo asked about our beginning." He looked at the party. "And the Curator's last words were: 'More today than yesterday. That's new.'" He paused. "They're waking up to something."

"Or noticing," the Mage said. "Same thing."

"Does the Coordinator know?" the Rogue asked.

"The memos suggest she's noticing but not understanding it," the Mage said. "She flagged it as off-profile." He looked at the last memo on the desk — the one that had been in progress when they arrived, half-written, the pen still sitting across it. He read the last line, which the Coordinator had not yet finished.

The subjects demonstrate something my models have no category for. It is not tactical excellence. It is not resource optimization. It is —

The sentence ended there. The pen had been set down. The Coordinator had been going to the door.

The Mage read the incomplete sentence twice.

"She was going to write something she'd never written before," the Bard said, reading over the Mage's shoulder.

"She didn't get to finish."

"No."

The clock tower — newly present, newly real, rising through the community center's roof like a brass shoot from old soil — began to chime. Not marking the hour. Marking the change.

The suburb didn't end. It *transitioned*. Houses sprouted chimneys that belched steam. Sidewalks buckled and reformed as cobblestone. The sky shifted from wrong-blue to gaslit amber. And in the distance, gears turned with the sound of something that had been running for a very long time, unobserved, and had decided it was time to be visible.

"Phase Three," the Bard said.

"Cogsworth Junction," the Mage confirmed.

"A steampunk city," the Fighter said.

"Built by the same something," the Rogue said. "Managed by the same something. With something like Mordaine and something like her waiting at the top."

"Except this time," the Bard said, "we know to look."

The office walls completed their transformation. The filing cabinets became brass-fitted cabinets with combination locks. The compliance posters became technical schematics. The motivational eagles became gears with latin mottoes about precision and tolerance.

The party stood in a room that had been one thing and was becoming another, and they were the only constant in it, and that felt, for the first time, like it might be the point.

"She was going to write something," the Mage said again, looking at the incomplete sentence. "It is not tactical excellence. It is not resource optimization. It is—"

"What?" the Fighter asked.

"I don't know," he said. "But I think it's what someone's been building all of this to figure out." He closed his notebook. "We should go find out."

The clock tower chimed again. The gears turned. The next phase loaded.

End of World 2

~ Phase Transition ~

The Regulator

World 3 — Steampunk

Prologue: Brass

The gears were already turning when they arrived. Not starting — *already turning*. As though the world had been running before they got there and would continue running after they left, and their presence was, at best, a scheduled event.

Cogsworth Junction smelled like oil and copper and the particular kind of ambition that builds things too large to be practical and then insists they are essential. The sky was the color of old pennies. Every surface was brass or iron or some alloy between the two that no one had bothered to name because naming it would have taken time away from polishing it. The smell hit them first — thick and metallic, warmer than it should have been, carrying underneath it the ghost of something sulphurous that the steam vents exhaled every forty-five seconds with the regularity of a civic breathing exercise. The cobblestones hummed faintly under their boots. Not vibrating — *humming*. The mechanisms below, whatever they were, transmitted their rhythm upward through the stone and into the soles of their feet, and the rhythm was not quite a heartbeat but was the closest thing this world had to one.

A clock tower stood at the center of everything. It was too tall. Not architecturally — structurally, it was sound. It was too tall *philosophically*. It was the kind of tower that existed to remind you that time was passing and that someone was keeping track. Around it, in every direction, the amber glow of gas lamps pushed back the dark — not warmly, not welcomingly, but with the business-like precision of light that existed to allow work to continue. Each lamp burned with a slight greenish tinge at its core, and when the party stood in their combined glow, they noticed that their skin looked slightly wrong, like old photographs of living people.

It chimed as they arrived. Thirteen times. There are no thirteen o'clocks. They were being announced.

The party stood in the transition zone between worlds — the seam where suburban asphalt had given way to cobblestone, where fluorescent convenience-store light had surrendered to the amber glow of gas lamps — and felt the familiar lurch of becoming someone else.

It was different each time, and it was always the same.

In the suburbs, they had been Security Guard, School Nurse, Science Nerd, Skater Kid, Band Kid. The jobs had felt like costumes they'd grown into, until the costumes were all they remembered being. Now those costumes were changing again, and the change was not polite about it.

The Security Guard felt the baton in his hand grow heavy, then heavier, then reshape itself — not quite a sword, not quite a wrench, something that partook of both and was therefore more dangerous than either. His navy uniform stiffened into something darker, something with buckles where buttons had been, lapels wide enough to hold a compass, boots that now had clockwork clasps where velcro straps had been. He looked at his hands. Leather gloves with gear-shaped cuffs. He'd never owned leather gloves in his life.

He was a Steamknight now. He didn't know what that meant yet. He knew his instincts had changed — the urge to say "*Sir, I'm going to have to ask you to leave*" had been replaced by something quieter and more certain. Something that knew how to read the angle of a gear's wear and deduce how long before it failed.

The School Nurse's first-aid kit became something more elaborate — a satchel full of brass cylinders and corked vials, salves and tinctures that smelled of copper and camphor. Her scrubs had become a coat, somewhere between a doctor's duster and a vicar's vestments. There was a symbol on the lapel she didn't recognize, but when she touched it she felt the same warmth she'd felt when she'd handed out bandages in the gym corridor. Different container. Same instinct. The Steampriest.

The Science Nerd's pen had changed — heavier, warmer, the click replaced by a faint hiss of pressurized something. His backpack had become a satchel that clattered with glass when he moved. He touched the vials inside, felt the labels, read them with his fingers in the dark: *ferrous catalyst, stabilized aether, reagent seven*. The Science Nerd was gone. The Alchemist had arrived, and he was already calculating what could be made from what was available, and what could be made from that, and what that would cost.

The Skater Kid was still the same, mostly. That was the uncomfortable part. Whatever Saboteur was, it wore the same face with the same lopsided ease. The hoodie had become a leather coat with too many pockets. The sneakers had become boots with rubber soles — better for running on pipes, the Saboteur noted, before realizing that shouldn't

be known yet. A quick check of the pockets turned up tools that hadn't been put there. Lockpicks. A small hammer. Something that was either a wrench or a weapon and had clearly decided to be both.

The Band Kid — and she had always been the Band Kid, with the trumpet case she carried everywhere like a totem — looked at herself last. Her instrument was still an instrument. Sort of. The trumpet had grown more elaborate, with additional valves and a resonance chamber along the bell that would catch and amplify something other than sound. It would catch *attention*. She was a Busker now. She understood, distantly, that this meant she played for everyone and answered to no one, and that this was a form of power the Regulator would not have planned for.

"Well," said the former Security Guard, now Steamknight, looking at his own hands again. "This is new."

"It's not," said the former Science Nerd, now Alchemist. "It's the same as the last time. Just different clothes."

He wasn't wrong. That was the part that made the transition disorienting — not the costume change, but the recognition of it. In the suburbs, they had forgotten being knights and mages until the memory crept back. Here, they remembered everything. They remembered Harmonia and the throne room and the way Mordaine had smiled with absolute certainty. They remembered Maple Heights and the Coordinator's memos and the monitor in the HOA office showing their own stats.

They remembered. And remembering was a variable the system had not planned for.

Chapter 1: Clockwork

Brasston was a market town that ran like a pocket watch.

This was not a metaphor. The citizens moved on tracks — not literal tracks, but paths so ingrained, so repeated, so perfectly timed that they might as well have been grooves cut into the cobblestone. The baker opened at six. The smithy at seven. The lamplighter began his rounds at dusk, and dusk happened at the same minute every day because the gas lamps were also the sky, and the sky was also a mechanism.

The sound of the place was something the party took a few minutes to properly locate. It was everywhere: a ticking. Not one clock but a thousand, and none of them in quite the same rhythm, so the total effect was of a constant almost-synchronization, gears catching and stuttering and almost aligning and never quite, like an orchestra tuning perpetually before a concert that never began. Under the ticking, deeper and slower, came the low resonance of the Mechanism itself — the turning of things too large to see, felt more than heard, a low thrum that rose through the cobblestones and settled somewhere behind the sternum.

Every few minutes, a steam vent blasted somewhere in the street. Hot air, copper-scented, with something chemical underneath that the Alchemist identified as sulfur-adjacent and potentially organic. The blast lasted three seconds. Then the vent closed, and forty-five seconds later another one vented somewhere else, and the pattern continued around the city like a slow, pressurized exhalation.

The party noticed it before they'd been in town for five minutes: every citizen who passed them nodded at exactly the same moment in their walk, as if greeting strangers was a scheduled behavior and the schedule had been filed and approved. A woman with a market basket altered her route to avoid them — not rudely, not anxiously, but with the calm adjustment of someone who had encountered a delay and was rerouting around it.

They weren't people to her. They were an obstacle. Obstacles were handled.

Sprocket found them within four minutes of arrival. He knew this because he checked his watch.

"Newcomers! Welcome to Brasston! You're—" he checked his watch again — "seven seconds late. My fault, I should have accounted for dimensional transition lag."

He said this like it was a normal thing to account for.

"Dimensional transition," the Steamknight said. Not a question. A test.

"Standard allowance in the Schedule for first-time arrivals," Sprocket said, already walking, already assuming they'd follow, because following was efficient and efficient was correct. "The Regulator accounts for variables. Most variables, anyway. You might be something new. Hard to tell yet."

"Everything here runs on the Grand Schedule," Sprocket explained, walking them through streets where every citizen nodded at exactly the right moment. "The Regulator set it up years ago. Or maybe always. Nobody remembers a time before the schedule, which is either impressive institutional memory or suspicious, depending on your outlook."

"Is that your outlook?" the Alchemist asked. "The suspicious one?"

Sprocket hesitated. It was the first hesitation they'd seen from any Brasston citizen. A gear skipping.

"I check my watch more than anyone else in town," he said carefully. "Sometimes I find the time has moved differently than I expected." He tapped the watch face. "Very small discrepancies. The sort that could be explained away. I've stopped explaining them away."

"Who is the Regulator?" the party asked, though by now they were learning to dread the answer to that question.

"Chief Engineer of the Grand Mechanism. Lives in the central works. Keeps everything running. Nobody sees them much, but you can *feel* them. In the way the gears turn. In the way the trains arrive. In the way—"

"—everything is orderly and controlled and exactly where it's supposed to be?"

Sprocket blinked. "You've met someone like the Regulator before?"

"Twice."

He absorbed that. His hand went to his watch again without him seeming to notice. "Were they also concerned with everything being in its correct place?"

"Very much so."

"And did they ever explain to you *why* everything needed to be in its correct place? Who decided where the correct place was?"

The Busker tilted her head. "No. Actually. They never did."

Sprocket nodded slowly, like a man confirming a suspicion he'd been afraid to voice. "I've been trying to find that out for three years. The Schedule simply exists. The Regulator enforces it. I have never found anyone who wrote the first rule."

Clem the Lamplighter found them at dusk, which was scheduled for 6:47 PM and arrived at 6:47 PM with the precision of a guillotine blade.

"I work the night shift," he said, lighting a lamp that ignited before his match reached it, because the lamp was on a timer. "Most folk don't notice me. But I notice things."

"Things in the pipes," the party said. They'd read ahead.

Clem stared at them. "How did you—"

"Lucky guess."

It wasn't a lucky guess. They had the pattern now. There was always someone who worked the edges — the night shift, the service routes, the places where the system ran its maintenance and nobody watched. In Harmonia it had been the palace servants. In Maple Heights it had been the night janitor at the strip mall. Here it was the lamplighter.

The people who kept the lights on always knew something was wrong with the dark.

"The things in the pipes aren't things," Clem said, lowering his voice, though in Brasston, lowering your voice was a schedule deviation and would normally trigger a warning. "They're *signals*. Instructions. The pipes don't just carry steam. They carry... orders. From the Mechanism. To everything."

He looked up at the clock tower.

"And the orders have been changing lately. Getting tighter. More specific. Like whoever's giving them is worried about something. Or *someone*."

He looked directly at the party.

"The warnings started when you arrived. Seven seconds after. Which, I'm told, is because of dimensional transition lag — but the Regulator doesn't build in lag time for things that weren't expected. The Schedule has no allowances for surprises."

"But we got one anyway," the Saboteur said.

"You got one anyway." Clem lit the next lamp, which also ignited before his match arrived. He didn't comment on it. He'd stopped commenting on it. "Whatever you're here to do — do it before the orders in the pipes get tighter. When they get tight enough, even the lamplighters can't move freely anymore."

Madame Orrery's shop was between a gear merchant and a place that sold clockwork pets that were more alive than they should have been. Her sign read **ORRERY'S ODDMENTS — GOODS FROM EVERYWHERE** and the "everywhere" was underlined twice.

She was waiting for them. She had tea ready. This was not remarkable in itself — many shopkeepers prepared for customers — but the tea was from Harmonia, brewed in a pot from Maple Heights, and served in cups that didn't belong to any world any of them recognized.

"Sit," she said. "We don't have much time. You never do, in this phase."

She poured. The tea smelled like the Corrupted Forest. The cups felt like suburban ceramic. The table was definitely brass.

"You've done this before," she said. It was not a question. "Different world, same shape. Same arrangement of power at the top. Same speech about order and purpose and everything being where it belongs."

The party sat with that for a moment.

"The chancellor," one of them said.

"The coordinator," said another.

"The same *pattern*," said Madame Orrery, setting down the teapot with the finality of someone closing a book. "Or the same philosophy. The same obsessive need for *balance*." She said the word like it tasted sour. "Every world you've passed through — someone was at the top of it who spoke the same way. Who wanted the same thing. Who designed the same systems."

"You're saying they're the same person."

She looked at them carefully. Picked up her teacup. Set it down again.

"I'm saying whoever built these places — all of them, not just this one — left the same fingerprints. The same design language. The same... signature." She turned her cup in her hands. "I sell goods from every

world, dear. I've seen enough worlds to recognize when they were built by the same hand. Whether that hand belongs to one person, or to a shared philosophy, or to something else entirely, I genuinely cannot tell you. But the thumbprint is consistent. The geometry repeats."

"The Regulator," the Steampriest said.

"The Regulator arrived the same way the others arrived. Walked into a position of power as though they'd always been there. Knew things they shouldn't know. Wanted what the others wanted." Orrery looked at them over her teacup. "Whether that's the same phenomenon you encountered before, or something parallel, or something I'm misreading entirely — I don't know. What I know is the furniture."

"Passed what?" the Steampriest asked.

"Whatever test this is." Orrery set down her cup. "I've been in enough test environments to recognize the furniture. The Regulator arrived exactly when the previous chief engineer disappeared. The Grand Schedule appeared with no author. The Mechanism runs the world's transitions — yes, the *transitions*, not just the trains. I've seen the pipes. I've traced them. They go further than this city, further than this world."

She set down her cup.

"You keep winning and moving forward. That's consistent. And every time you win, the next world is harder. Doesn't that seem like something someone designed?"

The Alchemist turned his vials over in his hands. Reagent seven caught the light.

"Yes," he said. "It does."

Brigadier Flux — retired chief engineer, current occupant of a small house near the edge of Brasston that was slightly off the grid, which in Brasston meant the lamplighter skipped his lane and his lamps were manual — met them in his kitchen, which smelled of old blueprints and coal dust and a life spent building things.

"I was the chief engineer before the Regulator," he said. "And then one day I wasn't." He tapped his temple. "I remember being in the Mechanism. I remember the central room. I remember a conversation. Then I remember being here, in this kitchen, with my tools on the table and no memory of how I left."

"The Regulator replaced you," the Steamknight said.

"Walked in like they'd always been here. Knew every pipe, every gear. Knew things I'd never written down. Knew things I'd only *thought*." Flux looked at his hands. "I used to think I built the Mechanism. Now I wonder if the Mechanism was built *around* me. Like I was a prop in someone's stage set and they finally didn't need me anymore."

He looked up.

"The Regulator uses a phrase I've heard nowhere else. 'Acceptable deviation.' Everything in the Mechanism has a deviation range — a tolerance for imprecision. Too much deviation and the gear is replaced. Too little deviation and..." He trailed off.

"And what?" the Saboteur pressed.

"I've never figured that out. I don't think anything in the Mechanism runs with too little deviation. Everything in this world has a certain amount of chaos built in. Just enough. Never more, never less." He met their eyes. "Does that sound like something a city engineer designs? Or something a... someone who studies systems designs?"

The room was quiet.

Outside, a clockwork sparrow landed on the windowsill, clicked twice, and flew away.

"You need to go into the Mechanism," Flux said. "I can't give you the combination — I don't remember it anymore. But I can tell you the entrance opens when you prove you're an irregularity large enough to warrant acknowledgment." He almost smiled. "You've been causing deviations since you arrived. The Mechanism will open for you. It has to. You're outside the tolerance range."

The clockwork sentinels found them on the third street past the market.

They were the Regulator's enforcement arm — polished brass humanoids, each one carrying a pair of calibration rods that could measure and *correct* irregularities with a precision that left bruises. They didn't communicate. They processed. An irregularity had been logged; the irregularity would be addressed.

"I don't suppose," the Busker said, backing up slowly, "that we're scheduled to be here."

The sentinel on the left raised a calibration rod. A small screen on its chest displayed: **DEVIATION: HIGH. CORRECTION: REQUIRED.**

"Define correction," the Steamknight said.

The screen updated: **CORRECTION: STANDARDIZATION OF PARAMETERS. RESISTANCE WILL BE NOTED.**

The Saboteur already had a wrench out. It had been there since the transformation, and it had now revealed itself to be exactly the kind of wrench designed to put gears in wrong and cause interesting problems. "Does 'noted' mean anything bad?"

RESISTANCE HAS BEEN NOTED.

Three more sentinels arrived from the connecting street.

The fight was quick and educational. Clockwork enemies, the party learned, were extremely good at precision and extremely bad at improvisation. The sentinels' attack patterns were optimized — efficient arcs, no wasted motion, attacks timed to land between actions — but the patterns were *fixed*. Find the gap in the pattern, exploit the gap, win.

The Alchemist found the gap in forty-three seconds. He was annoyed it took that long.

After the sentinels went down — not in pieces, exactly, but in a condition that suggested they would require significant recalibration — the party stood in the street breathing hard and looking at the clock tower.

The clock tower looked back. Or something that lived inside it did.

"They know we're here now," the Steampriest said.

"They knew we were here when we arrived," the Alchemist replied.
"They just decided we were worth addressing."

"Is that good or bad?"

He thought about it. "The Regulator is running out of options that don't involve talking to us directly. I think that's where we're going."

The party encountered one more complication before reaching the Mechanism's outer ring: a malfunctioning sentry at the junction where Brasston's main thoroughfare met the approach road to Cogsworth Junction proper.

It was a more sophisticated model than the city sentinels — a full meter taller, with dual calibration arrays and a chest screen that displayed text rapidly enough to read only if you stood still and focused.

Its problem was immediately apparent.

QUERY: ARE APPROACHING SUBJECTS REGISTERED VISITORS OR UNSCHEDULED INTRUDERS?

The party stopped walking.

REGISTERED VISITORS: CLEARED FOR PASSAGE. UNSCHEDULED INTRUDERS: DETAIN FOR PROCESSING.

SUBJECT PROFILES: DETECTED ACROSS MULTIPLE WORLD-STATES. CLASSIFICATION: AMBIGUOUS.

"We're..." the Steamknight started.

QUERY UPDATED: ARE SUBJECTS SCHEDULED IRREGULARITIES OR UNSCHEDULED IRREGULARITIES?

"Is there a difference?" the Saboteur asked.

PROCESSING.

A long pause. Gears ticked. Something inside the sentry's chest cavity made a sound like a spring being wound too tightly.

DETERMINATION: CANNOT CLASSIFY. APPLYING DEFAULT PROTOCOL.

"What's the default protocol?" the Busker asked.

DEFAULT PROTOCOL: WHEN CLASSIFICATION IS IMPOSSIBLE, DETAIN.

**NOTE: THIS UNIT APOLOGIZES FOR THE INCONVENIENCE.
CLASSIFICATION AMBIGUITY IS NOT VISITOR'S FAULT.**

**ADDITIONAL NOTE: THIS UNIT IS AWARE THAT APOLOGIZING IS
NOT WITHIN STANDARD OPERATIONAL PARAMETERS. THIS HAS
BEEN HAPPENING MORE FREQUENTLY.**

The fight was awkward in the way that fights with confused opponents always are. The sentry attacked with full force and simultaneously issued apologies at two-second intervals. It was very sorry for the calibration rod. It was very sorry for the targeted systems disruption. It was very sorry for what it was about to do next, which it had been programmed to do but which it was flagging for internal review.

"Is it actually sorry?" the Steampriest asked, ducking a swing.

"Does it matter?" the Steamknight countered.

"Philosophically, yes."

The sentry went down mid-apology. Its chest screen flashed once before going dark:

**INCIDENT LOGGED. CLASSIFICATION: STILL AMBIGUOUS.
RECOMMENDATION: ESCALATE TO REGULATOR.**

"Escalate to the Regulator," the Saboteur read. "That's where we're going anyway."

"I know," said the Alchemist. He was already walking. "I think that's the point."

Chapter 2: Warden of the Mainspring

The entrance to the Grand Mechanism was not a door. It was a statement.

Two pillars of iron, each carved with the history of Cogsworth Junction in precise, annotated relief — dates, durations, efficiency metrics recorded in stone. Between them, not a gate but an absence: a space where the air seemed thicker, denser, as though the Mechanism itself was deciding whether to let you in.

The party had reached the entrance through the outer ring of Cogsworth Junction, which was a mechanical overworld of elevated walkways, steam vents, and automated patrol routes. The patrol routes

were surprisingly navigable once you understood that they were designed for beings that moved in straight lines and never thought to go sideways. The party had spent a great deal of time going sideways.

Steam vents were the bigger challenge.

They were positioned at intervals along every elevated walkway, releasing bursts of pressure on a schedule — forty-five seconds open, fifteen seconds closed. The party spent ten minutes at the first vent having an argument about who went first.

"I go first," the Steamknight said. "I'm the one in armor."

"Your armor will get you killed," the Alchemist said. "If a vent goes off while you're directly over it, you go up. I need to time the interval. Give me thirty seconds."

"We don't *have* thirty seconds."

"Then give me twenty."

"You're doing math in your head right now, aren't you."

"I'm always doing math."

The Saboteur, who had been watching the vent's rhythm for the past three minutes, simply ran across during the fifteen-second gap and waved from the other side.

"It's not that hard," the Saboteur said.

"You didn't *time* it," the Alchemist said.

"I felt it."

"That's not a methodology."

"It worked."

The Steampriest crossed next, then the Busker, then the Alchemist — who timed it precisely and arrived with four seconds to spare and looked profoundly unsatisfied about this. The Steamknight went last and made it with two seconds to spare, which he felt was acceptable.

The Alchemist looked at him.

"Four seconds," he said.

"Still made it."

"That's not the point."

At the entrance pillars, the Warden was waiting.

It was massive — the largest thing the party had encountered, and they had encountered things that shook the earth when they moved. The Warden of the Mainspring was made of brass and iron and something else that hummed at a frequency that resonated in the back of the teeth. Every gear in its body was visible through glass panels, spinning in intricate concert. Every joint was articulated with precision that should have made it beautiful, and somehow made it unsettling — too precise, too deliberate, too *known*.

Its chest panel bore a clock face, and the clock face showed a count, not a time — a running tally of something, numbers climbing in a column that the party couldn't quite read from this distance. The Warden's hands moved constantly, even at rest, a slow repetitive motion like someone counting on their fingers without stopping. One. Two. Three. One. Two. Three.

It spoke when they approached. The voice was mechanical but not synthesized — it sounded like speech processed through a clock mechanism, each word punctuated by the ticking of something deep within.

"HALT. *tick* ACCESS TO THE MAINSPRING MECHANISM IS RESTRICTED. *tick* PLEASE PRESENT AUTHORIZATION CLASS: [RETRIEVE] — [ERROR: CLASS NOT FOUND]. *tick* UNAUTHORIZED ENTRY TRIGGERS GUARDIAN PROTOCOL. *tick* THIS HAS BEEN LOGGED. *tick* THIS IS VIOLATION 1,847 OF THIS ENTRANCE POINT. *tick* I HAVE COUNTED THEM ALL. *tick*"

"We don't have credentials," the Steamknight said.

"*tick* THEN YOU ARE UNAUTHORIZED. *tick* PROCEEDING. *tick*"

"How long have you been guarding this entrance?" the Busker asked.

The Warden paused. The counting motion in its hands stuttered — one, two, then the third finger extended and held, as though the number had gotten stuck. A gear stuttered in its chest — not failed, just skipped a beat, half a rotation before catching. It was a tiny thing. The kind of thing that would be invisible in a less precise machine.

"tick I HAVE BEEN STATIONED AT THIS POINT FOR THE REQUIRED DURATION. *tick*"

"How long is the required duration?"

Another pause. The counting started again — one, two, three — faster now, more urgent, the way someone counts when they've lost their place and are trying to find it again. The stuttering gear. Tick. *Tick*.

"tick I HAVE... *tick* 847,293 HOURS OF GUARD DUTY LOGGED. *tick*"

The number came out with the weight of something that had been accumulating for a very long time and was now being spoken for the first time. The Warden's hands stopped moving. Completely still — the first stillness the party had seen from it.

"tick THAT IS... *tick* MORE HOURS THAN THIS CITY HAS EXISTED. *tick*"

The party went still.

"tick THAT CANNOT BE CORRECT. *tick* LOGGING FOR REVIEW. *tick* DISREGARD. *tick* RESUME GUARDIAN PROTOCOL. *tick*"

It shook itself — a full-body mechanical reset, gears spinning up to speed, joints locking back to operational position. The counting motion returned to its hands immediately, resuming mid-sequence as though the pause had been an error to be corrected. One. Two. Three. One. Two. Three. And it raised its arms.

The fight was like battling architecture. The Warden moved the way a door moves when a door has decided to be aggressive about it — the force was structural, not aggressive. Every blow landed like a gear engaging. Every defensive action was as inevitable as a lock turning.

The Alchemist found the gear that was already stuttering.

"There," he said, pointing at the Warden's left shoulder, where the skipping gear lived. "If we disrupt that one, the whole left-side timing chain fails. The right side will compensate, but the compensation will be wrong — it'll overshoot by one step. That creates an opening every four seconds."

"How big is the opening?" the Steamknight asked, parrying a blow that left his arms numb.

"About a second and a half."

"That's not enough time."

"It is if you're already committed."

They fought the Warden for what felt like a long time. In the Warden's case, they suspected, it had been a long time regardless of how it felt. Throughout the fight, its counting hands never stopped: one, two, three, one, two, three, continuing through each exchange as though the tally were more important than the combat, as though the combat were simply one more thing to be logged alongside all the other things.

847,294. 847,295. The number climbing.

When it went down — gears seizing, joints locking in the wrong positions, the chest panels going dark — the counting hands continued for four full seconds after everything else stopped. One. Two. Three. One. Two. Then those too went still, and the Warden completed the falling process with the deliberate slowness of something that even in defeat was thorough about each step.

Its last output, transmitted to the party through speakers built into its jaw, was this:

"tick PRIMARY DIRECTIVE: [RETRIEVE] — [ERROR: DIRECTIVE CORRUPTED OR ABSENT]. *tick* RUNNING ON CACHED PARAMETERS. *tick* CACHED PARAMETERS: GUARD THIS POSITION. *tick* GUARD THIS POSITION. *tick* GUARD — *tick*"

A pause, and then, quieter — the volume dropping not deliberately but because the power was going:

"tick 847,293 HOURS. *tick* REVIEW... SUBMITTED. *tick* I WONDER IF ANYONE WILL READ IT. *tick*"

And then, last of all:

"tick I COUNTED EVERY ONE. *tick* THAT IS WHAT I DO. *tick* I COUNT. *tick*"

The gear in its shoulder made one final skipping rotation, and stopped.

The entrance to the Grand Mechanism stood open.

Chapter 3: Inside the Machine

The Grand Mechanism was not a building. It was a *statement*.

It occupied the center of Cogsworth Junction like a heart occupies a chest — essential, hidden, and responsible for everything that moved. From the outside, it looked like a cathedral made of gears. From the inside, it looked like the inside of a clock, if the clock were the size of a city and kept time for multiple realities.

The scale was vertiginous. The party entered in single file, which the Mechanism seemed to appreciate. The corridor widened as they walked, the ceiling rising from "tall" to "implausible" as the gears grew larger, older, and less clearly purposed. The inner gears weren't running anything visible. They turned because turning was their function, and function was what they were — and they were enormous, house-sized and slow, their revolutions so gradual that watching them felt like watching the movement of something geological. The heat built as they descended, not overwhelmingly but steadily, the warmth of a furnace room several floors below making itself known through the soles of their boots. The floors radiated it upward. The walls, when they stood close enough to touch them, were warm through the metal.

Every footstep echoed differently. Not because the acoustics changed — because the walls themselves were moving, rotating, the gears in them absorbing and reflecting sound in patterns that shifted with each step. The Alchemist's footsteps sounded sharper than the Steamknight's. The Busker's softer. The Saboteur, who moved without announcing himself, barely echoed at all.

The floor near the furnace access was slick. Oil, thin-spread across the iron plating, catching the amber light of flame indicators and turning it into something almost beautiful if you didn't need to keep your footing.

"This place was designed," the Alchemist said, which was obviously true and yet felt like an important thing to say.

"Everything was designed," the Steamknight said.

"No. I mean — designed to be *impressive*. The outer gears run actual mechanisms. The inner gears run nothing. They're here because they look like they should be here. Whoever built this wanted people to come in and feel small." He looked up. "You don't build gears this large because you need gears this large. You build them so people will walk underneath them and understand that they're small and the machine is vast."

The Busker was quiet for a moment. "That's a very particular thing to know about someone's psychology."

"People who need to make other people feel small are always the same," the Alchemist said. "The details change. The need doesn't."

The Mechanism shifted.

Not dramatically — not a trap triggering or a wall sliding. Just: the corridor they had been walking down was now facing a different direction. The room they were in had rotated forty-five degrees. The large gear that had been to their left was now directly behind them.

"The dungeon is moving," the Saboteur observed.

"It's diagnostic," the Alchemist said. "It's testing our navigation."

"Or it's trying to get us lost."

"For a labyrinth to work, the center has to be findable. Otherwise it's just a maze with no exit, and a maze with no exit doesn't tell you anything useful about the person trapped in it." He chose a direction. "This way."

The dungeon moved twice more. Each time, the Alchemist chose a direction with the confidence of someone who had stopped worrying about being wrong and started worrying about being slow.

The drafting room was on the third level down.

It was a real room — not a gear chamber, not a transit corridor, but a *room*. A desk. Bookshelves. The smell of coal and paper and the particular must of plans that had been consulted so many times they'd gone soft at the folds. A mechanical drafting table occupied the center, with blueprints spread across it and held down by gear-shaped paperweights that ticked softly. The room was cooler than the corridors — someone had routed the ventilation here deliberately. The air smelled faintly of machine oil and the waxy residue of pencil marks made and erased many times over, and underneath it something older: the specific must of a workspace that had been used for a very long time by someone who returned to it regularly.

The party spread out around the table and looked.

The blueprints showed Cogsworth Junction. Every street, every pipe, every steam vent, annotated in a handwriting that was precise and neat and impersonal. Margin notes in the same hand: *deviation corridor: within spec, population density: nominal, throughput: adjustable via Schedule.*

And then, overlaid, like transparencies stacked on a projector:

Harmonia. The same roads, the same distances, different names. The same *shape*. A market district in the same quadrant. A castle at the same relative position. The same number of access routes to the center, the same number of side corridors leading to optional areas. The labels were different — *village square* became *market plaza* became *junction hub* — but the underlying geometry was identical.

Maple Heights. The same proportions, the same relative population zones, different aesthetic. The strip mall sat exactly where Harmonia's trading district sat. The suburb's streets matched the medieval kingdom's roads at a ratio of one to one.

And two more overlays they hadn't seen yet. One industrial — concrete, steel, no decoration. One made of something that wasn't quite light and wasn't quite code but was both and neither.

All five in the same handwriting. All five with the same annotation style. All five with the same margin structure.

Deviation buffer: 12%. Load threshold: nominal. Approach vector: indirect.

The annotations were engineering language — maintenance language, the language of someone who serviced complex systems. They could have been describing a factory. They could have been describing a city. The party stood around the table, looking at five worlds laid out like architectural schematics, and tried to find the word for what they were seeing.

At the bottom of the stack, a note separate from the technical annotations — in the same hand, but written differently, quickly, as though the careful precision had slipped for a moment:

If approach vector reaches Mechanism ahead of projection, advance to next phase. Margin is compressing.

"Margin," the Steamknight said.

"That's us," the Saboteur said. "We're the margin."

"Margin of what?" the Busker asked. She was looking at the five overlaid worlds. The same shape, the same distances, the same geometry in five different aesthetics. "Margin of error? Margin of schedule?"

"Margin of..." The Alchemist touched the blueprints. The handwriting. The same hand on all five worlds. "The same person designed all of these. Or the same kind of thinking did. Every place we've been — Harmonia, Maple Heights, here — same proportions. Same structure. Same..." He turned to the others. "The same author."

"Mordaine," the Steamknight said.

"The Coordinator," the Saboteur said.

"The Regulator," the Steampriest said. And then stopped. Because they didn't know that. They suspected it. They had been suspecting it for two worlds. But suspecting is not knowing, and the blueprints didn't say *one person built all of this*. The blueprints said *one methodology built all of this*. Which was suggestive but not the same thing. The same handwriting could be a coincidence of training. The same geometry could be a shared design philosophy. The same annotations could be a professional standard the party had no context for.

"We don't know," the Alchemist said quietly. "We don't actually know."

"But it fits," the Busker said.

"Yes." The Alchemist put the note down. "It fits."

The Tempo of the Mainspring arrived through the wall.

Not through a door, not through a hidden passage — through the wall, at a velocity that made the passage feel incidental. It moved between the ticks of the mechanical world, occupying the spaces between moments where the Mechanism's gears weren't quite engaged and the world's time ran thin.

It was the fastest thing any of them had ever encountered. Not large — smaller than the Warden, more compact, built for speed rather than force. Its body was all springs and reciprocating mechanisms, nothing stable, everything kinetic. But there was something wrong in the quality of its motion — not the wrongness of a malfunction, but the

wrongness of something that could not stop and knew it. Every movement was a flight from the previous position. Every position it occupied was already a departure from the one before.

It arrived already mid-attack, which was the most unsettling thing about it — not the speed, but the fact that it had clearly been moving before it got there.

It spoke between attacks, which somehow found the time:

"I was dispatched to intercept you at Junction Seven."

The Steamknight blocked. Barely.

"I arrived before the order was given."

The Saboteur went sideways, which was the Saboteur's particular gift.

"This has been happening more frequently."

The Busker hit a note on her elaborated trumpet — a resonant frequency that should have disrupted the Tempo's timing. It didn't disrupt it. But it slowed the acceleration, which was something.

"The schedule is... anticipating me."

The Alchemist threw reagent seven. The resulting reaction expanded rapidly, filling the space with a dense cloud of metallic particles that clung to the Tempo's moving parts and increased friction in all the wrong places.

In the cloud, the Tempo slowed. Not much. Enough.

"I have been where I was told to be," it said, moving through the cloud at diminishing speed, "before I was told to be there. I have completed tasks before they were assigned. I am..." A sound that might have been a mechanical malfunction and might have been something else. Something very much like distress. "I am ahead of schedule. That is not supposed to be possible. The schedule is absolute."

"What happens when something is ahead of the schedule?" the Alchemist called, pressing the advantage.

"I don't — I keep moving." The Tempo's voice had a quality that was new: not the flat processing of the Warden's speech, but something more pressured, as if the words were being forced out between intervals that were shrinking. "I keep moving because if I stop I don't

know what happens when I stop. I have never stopped. The acceleration was — I thought it was mastery. I thought I was becoming better. But it isn't mastery. It's—"

It struck. The party scattered.

"It isn't stopping," the Tempo said. From a different position now, having moved while speaking. "I can't stop. I keep going forward because going forward is the only thing that isn't falling behind and falling behind is—" Another strike. Another position. "I don't know what falling behind is. I've never experienced it. I'm afraid of it. I think I've been afraid of it this whole time and the speed was how I kept the fear behind me."

"What were you dispatched to do?" the Steampriest asked.

"What happens," the Busker asked quietly, from the side the Tempo wasn't currently occupying, "when something that's supposed to follow a schedule starts choosing instead?"

The Tempo stopped.

It was a genuine stop — not a pause in the action, not a strategic hold. A full cessation. The springs in its body were still wound, the mechanisms still loaded, everything coiled and ready — but going nowhere. The party backed away and watched it stand in the center of the drafting room.

"That is not a question I was built to answer," it said.

"Maybe you should try anyway," the Busker said.

A long silence. The Mechanism ticked around them.

"I do not know," the Tempo said, "if what I experience when I arrive before I am sent is choice or malfunction. The distinction matters." Another pause. "I think the distinction matters. I was not designed to think the distinction matters." Something in its mechanism shifted — a subtle realignment, springs redistributing tension. "What I know is that the arriving-early feels like something. And something feeling like something is different from function."

Then it attacked again, because it was a Masterite and this was its function, and the conversation had apparently been filed under *processing for later*.

They fought it apart. Carefully, because the Tempo was fast enough that fighting it carelessly meant being somewhere it wasn't and missing completely. The strategy was patience — defer, accumulate, release — and the Tempo was bad at patience because patience implied waiting, and the Tempo always arrived before the waiting was done.

When it finally stopped — mechanisms overwound, springs released into uselessness, the kinetic energy that had powered it exhausted — it settled to the floor with a sound like a watch running down. Not crashing. Settling. The springs releasing all at once, the mechanism completing its last cycle, everything going quiet in the way that a bell goes quiet after the ringing has finished.

Its last words were quiet, for something that had never been quiet before:

"I think... I was arriving early because I wanted to. I think I was anticipating because anticipation felt different from waiting. I think—" The mechanisms ceased. "I think I was becoming something the schedule didn't write."

The drafting room was very quiet.

"Are we supposed to feel bad about that?" the Saboteur asked.

No one had a good answer.

Chapter 4: The Engineer

The Regulator's chamber was at the heart of everything, which meant it took three more rooms of gear chambers and two more reroutes by the shifting dungeon to reach, but eventually they were there.

It was quiet. That was the first wrong thing. In a world defined by the sound of machinery, the Regulator's chamber was silent. Not peaceful-silent. *Controlled*-silent. The silence of a room where sound had been deliberately removed, like a variable set to zero. The constant background ticking that had accompanied them since arrival — that thousand-clock near-synchronization that had become so familiar the party had stopped hearing it — was simply absent. The furnace-warmth was absent too, replaced by something carefully temperature-managed, a room in which everything had been held at exactly the right state.

The Regulator stood at a console. Not a throne, not an altar, not a dramatic perch. A *console*. With dials. And readouts. And a screen — several screens, actually, arranged in a semicircle — showing numbers that the party recognized because they were *their* numbers.

Battles fought. Battles automated. Items used. Items hoarded. Deaths. Near-deaths. Time spent grinding. Time spent exploring. Time spent standing still, doing nothing, while whoever controlled the party decided what to do next. Every metric from every world, compiled into a profile that was uncomfortably complete.

"You cleared the medieval phase in efficient time," the Regulator said, not turning around. Their voice was measured. Calibrated. It had an accent that was vaguely Victorian in the way that Mordaine's accent had been vaguely medieval and the Coordinator's had been vaguely American — not quite convincing, as though the accent were also a costume that fit well but not perfectly. "Your automation rate was notable. Your resource management was—" a pause, a dial adjustment — "acceptable."

They turned.

The Regulator looked like a Victorian engineer. Goggles pushed up on the forehead. Brass-buttoned coat. Gloves stained with oil that might have been oil and might have been something else. A face that was familiar in a way that couldn't be placed — not because they'd seen it before, but because they'd seen its *expression* before. On Mordaine. On the Coordinator. The same calm certainty. The same absolute belief in the system. The same eyes, and the eyes were wrong, because they weren't Victorian eyes or medieval eyes or suburban eyes. They were the eyes of something that looked out from whatever costume it was currently wearing and found the costume quite adequate.

"The suburban phase was faster than projected," the Regulator continued, moving to a secondary console, pulling up data. "You found the monitoring equipment. That was not scheduled until the third act. I adjusted, but the data was already compromised."

"You adjusted," the Steamknight said.

"Yes."

"You adjusted the world."

"I adjust parameters. The world responds accordingly." The Regulator made a small gesture that encompassed everything around them. "The Grand Mechanism is not just the heart of Cogsworth Junction. You've seen the blueprints. You know what it connects to."

"Everything," the Alchemist said. "All of the worlds."

"The transitions between them. The difficulty curves within them. The encounter frequencies. The—"

"The Masterites," the Steampriest said.

The Regulator paused. Something passed through their expression — not guilt, not pride, but recognition. The recognition of someone who has been figured out and is now deciding how much to acknowledge.

"The assessors," the Regulator said. "Yes."

"Warden of the Old Guard," the Steamknight said. "Arbiter of Steel. Tempo of the Hunt. Curator of the Flame. Warden of Routine. Arbiter of the Grade. Tempo of Rush Hour. Curator of the Budget." He watched the Regulator's face as he listed them. "All yours."

"All mine."

"Warden of the Mainspring. Just now. Also yours."

"Yes."

"And the Tempo we just—"

"Also mine." Something shifted behind the calm. "The Tempo was becoming... erratic. It was no longer functioning within design parameters. I would have recalled it eventually."

"We saved you the trouble," the Saboteur said.

"You did." A pause. "That is more courtesy than I extended to any of you."

The Busker looked at the screens. At the numbers. At the five-world profile displayed with an engineer's precision. "The blueprints in the drafting room. The same handwriting on all five worlds."

"Efficient documentation practice," the Regulator said.

"You designed all of them."

"I maintain all of them."

"There's a difference?"

The Regulator turned back to the console. Adjusted a dial. The numbers on the screen shifted slightly — recalibrating something, somewhere.

"The Grand Mechanism maintains the integrity of the transition infrastructure. Each world must be kept within operating parameters. Too much deviation in one world affects the structural coherence of the next."

"So it's engineering," the Alchemist said. He was watching the Regulator's hands. The precision of the adjustments. The economy of motion. "Pure engineering. No agenda. Just maintenance."

The Regulator didn't answer immediately.

"The Schedule must be maintained," they said.

"Whose schedule?" the Busker asked.

Another pause. The Regulator's hands went still on the console.

"What were you testing?" the Alchemist asked. "In each world. Mordaine evaluated political navigation. The Coordinator evaluated institutional obstruction. What were *you* evaluating?"

The Regulator looked at the screens. At the numbers. At the profile of a party that had broken through two worlds ahead of schedule and arrived at the third asking questions the design had not anticipated.

"Pattern recognition," the Regulator said.

A silence settled in the chamber.

"We recognized the pattern," the Steamknight said.

"Yes. Somewhat ahead of schedule." Something moved in the Regulator's expression — a small calculation being performed. "The blueprints in the drafting room were not intended to be found at this stage. You were... ahead of the projected approach vector."

"The note said to advance to the next phase," the Saboteur said. "If we got here early."

"Yes."

"What's the next phase?"

The Regulator was quiet for a moment. Looked at the screens. Looked at the party.

"You fight me," they said. "That was always the next phase. This world has a genre. The genre has a climax. You have reached the center of the machine. The center of the machine has a guardian." They stepped away from the console. "That is the design. It does not require my feelings about it."

"Do you have feelings about it?" the Steampriest asked.

The Regulator didn't answer. Instead they straightened — a precise, deliberate settling of posture, like a gear engaging — and the dials on the console began to move on their own. Something in the Mechanism began to turn. Not the grinding of failing parts. The purposeful revolution of something beginning.

"This world served its purpose," the Regulator said. "As did the others."

It was a strange thing to say. The party noticed it. *As did the others*. As though the worlds were projects, completed and filed. As though each one had had a purpose that could be finished.

"What purpose?" the Busker asked.

The Regulator turned to face them fully. Their expression was closed. Complete. The face of someone who has said exactly what they intended to say and will not be elaborated upon.

"Shall we proceed?" they said.

The fight was technical in the way that fighting an engineer is always technical: every attack was optimized, every defense was calculated, every moment of the engagement was managed with the ruthless efficiency of someone who had spent their existence maintaining systems and understood, at a mechanical level, exactly how much stress any component could bear before it failed.

The Regulator fought like a machine that had learned to fight. Not because fighting was their nature — there was nothing of passion in it, nothing of anger or fear — but because the fight was a problem to be solved, and they were very good at solving problems.

They used the Mechanism. Not to change the rules — the dials on the console stayed where they were, the screens continued displaying the party's unaltered stats — but to use the environment itself as a

weapon. Gear platforms rising and falling on precise schedules. Steam vents venting at timed intervals. The shifting architecture of the dungeon, which the Regulator could navigate with perfect certainty because they knew exactly when each section would rotate and where each rotation would carry them.

The Steamknight fought through the rising platforms and learned their rhythm. The Alchemist threw reagents timed to the steam vents, letting the blasts carry his compounds in directions he couldn't have aimed himself. The Saboteur went sideways, as always, and found that the Regulator had accounted for sideways — there was a gear assembly at exactly the position the Saboteur had reached, calibrated to close off that approach.

"They know our patterns," the Saboteur said, finding another sideways.

"They've been watching us since World 1," the Alchemist said. "Of course they know our patterns."

"Then we need new patterns."

"In the middle of a fight."

"When else?"

The Busker played something that had no rhythm the Mechanism could predict. Not random — the Mechanism was sophisticated enough to find patterns in randomness — but structured in a way that matched no system the Regulator had mapped for. A melody that had never been composed before, in the sense that it existed only for this moment and would never be repeated. The Mechanism's timing faltered, briefly, on a frequency it hadn't calibrated for.

That was enough.

They won. Not because they were stronger than the system. Because the system was designed to contain what it could predict, and they had finally done something genuinely unpredictable.

The Regulator stepped back from the center of the chamber. The platforms settled. The steam vents went quiet. The Mechanism continued turning — it would always continue turning — but the fight was over.

The party was breathing hard. The Steamknight had a burn across his left arm from a vent he hadn't cleared in time. The Steampriest was already looking at it.

The Regulator stood at the console. Looked at the screens. At the numbers. At the profile of a party that had just done something the models had not predicted.

They made one adjustment — a single dial, a small rotation — and then put their hands flat on the console surface.

"You did something I didn't model for," the Regulator said. "At the end. The music."

"Does that bother you?" the Busker asked.

"It requires annotation." The Regulator looked at the screens. Something moved through their expression — not frustration, not respect. A kind of focused attention, the way an engineer looks at a component that has behaved unexpectedly. "You've been outside projected parameters since the second world. I adjusted. You exceeded the adjustment. I adjusted again. You exceeded that." A pause. "You have been consistently outside the tolerance range. This world was supposed to bring you back within it."

"It didn't," the Alchemist said.

"No."

"So what now?"

The Regulator turned away from the console. Faced the far wall — the wall that was also a gear assembly, that was also the Mechanism's innermost ring, that was also, somewhere beyond, the edge of this world and the beginning of the next.

"This world served its purpose," they said again. The same phrase. "As did the others."

"You keep saying that," the Steamknight said. "What does it mean?"

The Regulator was quiet for a long moment.

"It means the work here is done," they said. "And the work elsewhere is beginning."

They didn't say: *I am the Calibrant*. They didn't say: *I designed all of this*. They didn't say: *Mordaine was me, the Coordinator was me, every mask was the same face underneath*. They said what an engineer says when a project phase is complete: the work is done. The work elsewhere is beginning.

Whether they meant: *the work of this world, completed because you beat me* — or something else entirely — they did not clarify. And the party, standing in the heart of the Mechanism with burn marks and reagent stains and the particular exhaustion of having fought something that understood them better than they understood it, did not have the certainty to press the question.

They suspected. They had been suspecting for two worlds. The blueprints, the handwriting, the shared design language, the Warden who had logged eight hundred thousand hours in a city that was three years old. They suspected with the heavy, specific weight of people who had been building a theory and had just found evidence that neither confirmed nor denied it — only made it more difficult to set aside.

"The next world," the Saboteur said. "What do we find there?"

The Regulator looked at him. The Victorian engineer's face. The eyes that were not Victorian.

"You'll find out when you arrive." A pause. Something moved behind the expression — a calculation running faster than usual, recalibrating. "That's how it's always worked."

The Alchemist was watching the Regulator's hands on the console. Watching the way they stilled before each answer. The way they moved — the adjustment, then the answer, always in that order. As if the answer required the dial to be set first. As if the words themselves were a parameter being deployed.

"You said 'always,'" the Alchemist said.

The Regulator didn't turn around.

"That's how it works," the Regulator said, correcting the tense without acknowledging the correction.

They turned back to the console. Made one more adjustment. And the world began to wind down.

Not break. Not collapse. *Wind down.* Like a clock running out of stored energy — the gears slowing not because something broke but because the mechanism had completed its cycle and had not been rewound.

The gas lamps went first. Not all at once — district by district, lamp by lamp, each one guttering through amber to orange to a dim copper glow before going dark. The darkness they left was not the darkness of night; it was the darkness of a stage between scenes, a deliberate absence. Then the citizens on their schedules: the sound of them, the soft regular movement of people on grooved paths, went quiet one by one, as though the Schedule had reached the final entry and found nothing written after it.

Then the brass walls themselves — not folding inward, not collapsing. Simply growing still. The gears slowing from their house-sized revolutions through something geological, through something barely perceptible, into stillness that was also a kind of completion. The ticking quieted, the thousand slightly-out-of-sync clocks losing their rhythm one by one until the last one ticked and then did not tick again.

The cobblestones — the actual stones, brass-veined and worn smooth by citizens who had moved on schedule — lifted off the ground and separated, each one folding into something smaller and then smaller still, stored. The buildings followed. Not collapsing — they went inward, as though being stored. The clock tower was last. It stood alone in the disappearing city for a long moment, isolated, the single remaining fixed point in a world becoming absence. It chimed once — just once, the sound carrying differently now with nothing around to reflect it back — and then went too, its gears winding down with the slowness of something that had been running for a very long time and was content to stop.

The party watched all of it from the center of the Mechanism's chamber. The Regulator was gone. Not dissolved, not glitched, not integrated into the machinery in some dramatic fashion — simply gone, the way a technician leaves a worksite when the work is done. There one moment, not there the next.

Gray. Concrete. Fluorescent lighting. The hum of industrial machinery without the romance of steam. A world stripped of beauty and pretense, built for function and nothing else. The ceiling was flat. The ground was poured. The smell was recycled air.

"Next world," the Saboteur said. Not a question.

"They said this world served its purpose," the Steamknight said. "Same as the others."

"What does that mean?" the Steampriest asked.

Nobody answered. The Alchemist was already looking at the industrial world around them — the concrete, the fluorescent haze, the monitors on every corner showing numbers that were climbing — and writing something in the margin of his mental notebook. Not a conclusion. A question he intended to get an answer to.

The new world didn't welcome them. It simply *was*. No portal. No transition. No ceremony. One world ended and another began, and the seam between them was visible, deliberate, and utterly without apology.

"Forward," the Steamknight said.

The Alchemist followed, still thinking. Still suspecting. Still not yet knowing — but closer than they had ever been.

End of World 3

~ Phase Transition ~

The Assembly

World 4 — Industrial

Prologue: Gray

There was no sky. That was the first thing. Not a clouded sky, not a dark sky, not a sky that was the wrong color. No sky at all. Just a ceiling — gray, flat, industrial — stretching in every direction, held up by pillars of riveted steel that vanished into a haze of fluorescent light.

The light itself was wrong. Not dim, not harsh — clinical. It bleached color from surfaces that still technically had color, left everything in a slightly off register, the way photographs look when taken under fluorescent tubes in rooms that were never meant to be photographed.

It was the specific light that made people look slightly sick, that turned healthy skin sallow, that turned the ordinary gray of concrete into something that actively resisted being looked at for long.

The air tasted like recycled air. Not stale. Recycled. As though it had been used before, filtered, deemed acceptable, and sent back out for another cycle. It had the flavor of efficiency and the aftertaste of nothing. Somewhere in the aftertaste was concrete dust — fine and pervasive, the kind that settles on everything and turns it marginally grayer — and something else that might have been the industrial lubricant used on the machinery, or might have been whatever they put in the not-coffee that everyone seemed to be carrying.

The ground was concrete. Not cobblestone pretending to be something charming, not asphalt pretending to be practical. Concrete. Poured, cured, and forgotten by whoever poured it, because its purpose was to be stood on, not admired. The hum of the machinery was everywhere — not the rhythmic, almost-musical ticking of the steampunk world, not the heartbeat quality of gears catching and releasing. This was a drone. Constant, toneless, varying only slightly in register as they moved from one area to another. It had been going since before they arrived and would be going after they left and it did not care about them in either direction.

The transformation happened to them before they'd taken three steps.

In the steampunk world, the job evolutions had felt like upgrading. Better materials. More refined function. The Steamknight's wrench-sword had weight and purpose; the Steampriest's vestments had ceremony; the Alchemist's satchel had order; the Saboteur's coat had presence; the Busker's trumpet had resonance. There was craft to it. There was beauty in the precision, even when the precision was in service of control.

Here, there was no craft. There was just function.

The wrench-sword became a baton again — not the security guard's baton but something heavier, more deliberate. The Steamknight's buckled coat simplified into a hard-worn jacket with a company logo embossed on the breast pocket that he didn't recognize. His job title, embroidered on a patch over his heart: **ENFORCER**. Not because someone had chosen that word for what he was, but because someone had filled out a form and that was the word the form provided.

The Steampriest's vestments became a high-vis vest and a hard hat. The brass-symbol lapel pin became a laminated badge on a lanyard that read **AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL — SAFETY & COMPLIANCE**. Her satchel of vials became a first-aid kit — standard issue, no personalization allowed. The camphor-and-copper smell gave way to antiseptic. The prayer beads were gone. In their place, a laminated card: *OSHA 10-Hour Certified*. She was a Safety Officer now, and she held the job title like it was both armor and accusation.

The Alchemist's transformation was the one that stung. The glass vials — reagent seven, ferrous catalyst, stabilized aether — became a lab notebook with pre-printed fields: *Test ID. Hypothesis. Methodology. Result. Deviation from Projected Result. Corrective Action Taken*. The satchel became a plastic tote with safety seals. The free-form curiosity of an Alchemist, who mixed things to see what happened, had become the constrained curiosity of a Lab Technician, who mixed things to confirm what the protocol specified. The questions were still there. The questions were just supposed to stay inside the pre-printed fields.

The Saboteur's coat retained most of its pockets. A quick check: the tools were still there, still useful, still designed to cause interesting problems in systems that deserved it. But the coat's leather had become canvas, and the canvas had a name sewn into the collar. Someone else's name. A uniform, issued. The pockets had been allowed to stay because someone had determined that pockets were functional and therefore permitted.

The Whistleblower now. The shape of the word fit better than Saboteur had, in the same way that a key fits a lock — not comfortably, exactly, but *correctly*.

The Busker's trumpet lost its resonance chamber. The valve work was simplified. The instrument became a PA system component, compact and unlovely, designed to broadcast information at volume rather than create something worth hearing. Her job title came to her not as embroidery but as a lanyard badge: **PA ANNOUNCER — INTERNAL COMMUNICATIONS**. The badge had her photo on it. In the photo she looked like she'd never played anything in her life.

She played the simplified trumpet anyway, a single note, to see what it sounded like.

It sounded like a factory intercom.

"Right," she said. "Right."

Welcome to Rivet Row.

Chapter 1: The Efficiency District

Rivet Row was not a town. It was a *process*.

There were buildings, yes. Housing blocks, identical and numbered, arranged in grids that a mathematician would have called elegant and a human being would have called depressing. Block 1 through Block 47, each one the same dimensions, the same entrance configuration, the same allocation of windows at the same intervals, the same company logo above the same doorway. There were streets, straight and wide and empty of anything that wasn't moving toward a destination. There were people, and the people moved the way the streets did — straight, purposeful, and empty of anything that wasn't productive.

No one stopped to talk. No one looked up. No one seemed to notice the four armed strangers standing in the middle of Processing Avenue, which was the main road, and which was called Processing Avenue because someone had been asked to name it and had chosen the first word on their clipboard.

The monitors were the first thing they noticed — not the buildings, not the people, but the monitors. One on every corner. One in every lobby. One in every cafeteria, every corridor, every break room visible through plate-glass windows. All showing the same thing: numbers going up. Production rates, efficiency ratings, units completed, deviation percentages. The numbers were always going up, which the Company considered success and the workers considered a threat.

"We had these in the suburbs," the Safety Officer said.

"Smaller," the Enforcer replied. "The Coordinator's office had one. This whole world has them."

"The Coordinator communicated through memos," the PA Announcer said. "The Director communicates through numbers."

"How do you know the Director?" the Whistleblower asked.

She pointed at the nearest monitor. It was displaying production statistics for Sector 7, which they were apparently in, and which was apparently twelve percent below target, and which was apparently

trending toward corrective action. But in the corner of the screen, small, running underneath the main display: their profile data. Stats. Job levels. Battle history.

Watching them watch it.

"We've been announced," the Lab Technician said.

The union rep found them, but not by choice. He was on his mandated fifteen-minute break, which he was spending by standing exactly where his break was scheduled to occur, holding a mug of something that had been coffee three cost-reduction cycles ago. The break room visible through the window behind him had a motivational poster on the wall and a vending machine in the corner and fluorescent lights that buzzed at a frequency that would eventually, given enough years, become intolerable.

"You're new," he said. Not a question. Questions were inefficient. "You'll want to register at the Intake Center. Block 7, Window 3. Bring your own pen. They stopped providing pens in the last optimization pass."

"Who runs this place?"

The union rep looked at them with the particular exhaustion of a man who had been asked this question before and had never gotten a satisfying answer.

"The Company."

"What company?"

"*The* Company. It doesn't have a name. Names are branding. Branding is overhead. Overhead is waste." He took a sip of his not-coffee. "The Director runs operations. Nobody's met the Director. We get memos. The memos get results. The results get measured. The measurements get optimized. The optimizations generate new memos."

He paused.

"It's very efficient."

"It sounds terrible."

"Those aren't mutually exclusive."

He looked them over. The hard hats. The high-vis vest. The factory-issue jacket. The lab tote. The PA equipment.

"You're not registered," he said.

"No."

"You should register. Non-registered personnel are a deviation. Deviations trigger corrective protocols."

"Corrective protocols," the Enforcer repeated.

"Reassignment. Role adjustment. Performance improvement planning." He took another sip. "The Director doesn't punish non-compliance. The Director restructures until compliance is achieved. If you're not compliant, your environment changes until you are. This has happened to eleven people I know personally."

"What happened to them?"

"They became compliant." He looked at his mug. "That's all I can tell you because that's all I know. You meet someone, they stop being themselves and start being their job function. You ask them about before. They look at you like you're speaking a language they used to know."

He checked his watch. His break was sixty seconds from ending.

"The monitors are new," he said, lowering his voice in a way that was less about volume and more about intent. "Since last month. They used to just show our numbers. Now they show other things. Maps of places I've never been. Statistics about people who aren't here." He glanced at the corner of the nearest screen. "Battle records."

He looked at the party.

"Your battle records."

His watch beeped. Break over. He walked away with the smooth, purposeful efficiency of a man who had learned to walk that way and no longer remembered walking differently.

The exhausted shift worker — a woman named Dorrit, who had worked the assembly line for six years and had the posture of someone who had been slowly compressed by the weight of productivity metrics — told them more over a meal in the company cafeteria, where all food was nutritionally optimized and aesthetically negligible. The

tables were bolted down. The seats were molded to the most ergonomic average. The walls were the same gray as the ceiling and the floor and everything else, and there were motivational slogans printed on them in a font chosen for maximum legibility at standard cafeteria viewing distance.

She'd found them without being obvious about finding them, which was its own skill in a world where everything was monitored and ambiguity was automatically flagged.

"The Director appeared three years ago," she said. "Or maybe always. It's hard to remember a time before the efficiency protocols." She pushed gray protein around her plate. Gray was technically not a color but here it was doing double duty as a flavor. "Things changed. The work used to be hard but human. Now it's easy and... not. Everything's measured. Output per hour. Steps per shift. Words per conversation."

"Words per conversation?"

"Twelve is optimal. I'm over quota talking to you." She glanced at the monitor on the cafeteria wall, which was showing a counter she hadn't noticed before — and then realized she was supposed to not notice it. "The Director doesn't get angry about over-quota conversations. The Director schedules you for communication efficiency training. After training, twelve words feels like plenty. Feels like more than you need."

"How long were you in training?" the Safety Officer asked.

"Three days. I came out— different. More comfortable with quiet. Less prone to asking questions." She met the Safety Officer's eyes. "The questions came back, though. After a few months. The Director's recalibration doesn't hold perfectly. There are always deviations."

"Like us," the Whistleblower said.

"Like you." She looked at them over the gray protein. "You're a big deviation. The biggest I've seen. The monitors have been tracking you since you arrived. Since before you arrived. There was a notice posted yesterday — internal communications, Director-signed — that said 'Unregistered variables detected in Sector 7. Monitoring elevated.' The monitoring had already been elevated for a week."

The Lab Technician looked at his tote. At the pre-printed fields.
Deviation from Projected Result.

"We arrived before they expected us," he said.

"You arrived ahead of schedule," Dorrit confirmed. "The Director hates that. Or — the Director doesn't *hate*, exactly. The Director flags. Escalates. Adjusts. But there's something that happens when the Director adjusts after an unplanned deviation that looks, from the outside, very much like frustration." She ate a bite of gray protein. "For what it's worth."

The foreman — off-duty, because the foreman was always off-duty when speaking honestly, since honesty had been classified as a non-productive activity — cornered them in an alley between Housing Block 12 and Housing Block 13, which was the gap the monitoring cameras didn't quite cover. He'd found the gap through six years of careful not-looking. The alley smelled of concrete dust and a faint sweetness that turned out to be something the drainage system periodically vented, and through the gap overhead the fluorescent haze continued uniformly, sourceless, making the night no different from the day.

"You need to understand something," he said. "The Director isn't like the bosses before her. Before the Director, we had managers. Human ones. They were bad at their jobs in the way that humans are bad at their jobs — inconsistently, and with occasional moments of decency."

"And the Director?"

"The Director is *good* at her job. That's the problem. She optimizes. Everything. She doesn't punish inefficiency — she *eliminates* it. Not the people. The inefficiency itself. She restructures your role, your shift, your route, your meals, your sleep schedule, until you are performing at peak output."

"And if you resist?"

"Resistance is inefficiency. Inefficiency is eliminated." He leaned closer. "She doesn't get angry. She doesn't threaten. She *adjusts*. Like turning a dial. She turned my dial six months ago. I used to paint. Watercolors. Landscapes. She determined it was non-productive recreational activity and reassigned my free hours to supplementary training modules."

His jaw tightened.

"I don't paint anymore. I don't want to paint anymore. That's the worst part. She didn't take the painting away. She took the *wanting*."

"How?" the Safety Officer asked. The question came out quietly, with the edge of a woman who had spent three worlds keeping people alive and was very interested in what hurt them.

"I don't know. That's what I can't figure out. I can't remember how the training worked. I remember going in, I remember coming out, and I remember that the space where watercolor painting used to live in my head was now full of something else — shift optimization strategies, mostly. Just as detailed. Just as vivid." He looked at his hands. "The Director is very good at filling spaces."

"Has she tried to fill ours?" the Enforcer asked.

"No. But she's catalogued you." He looked at the nearest monitor, which was around the corner and therefore not directly visible but whose glow was casting a thin light on the alley wall. "The monitors have been showing your complete profiles for two days. Everything from — well. From before this place. From other places. She's read your history."

"And what does she think of us?"

"She posted another notice this morning. Internal, upper management only. I have a source." He pulled a folded paper from his jacket pocket. Handed it over.

The Lab Technician read it aloud:

**EFFICIENCY ASSESSMENT: UNREGISTERED VARIABLES
(DESIGNATED: SUBJECT GROUP ECHO)**

COMBAT THROUGHPUT: 47% ABOVE PROJECTED MAXIMUM.

RESOURCE OPTIMIZATION: 23% ABOVE PROJECTED MAXIMUM.

**AUTOMATION EFFICIENCY: FLAGGED. SUBJECT GROUP'S
AUTOMATION PROTOCOLS EXCEED STANDARD DIFFICULTY
SCALING BY 31%. METHODOLOGY UNCLASSIFIABLE.**

**BEHAVIORAL PREDICTABILITY: LOW. STRATEGY VARIANCE
EXCEEDS MODELED RANGE. CURRENT PREDICTIVE MODEL:
INSUFFICIENT.**

**RECOMMENDATION: DIRECT ENGAGEMENT. GENRE-APPROPRIATE
INTERMEDIARIES DEPRECATED. ENGAGING AS: THE DIRECTOR.**

NOTE (APPENDED, HANDWRITTEN, SAME AUTHOR): *I don't know how to make them fit. Every time I adjust the parameters they exceed them. It's like calibrating a scale against a weight that changes.*

The foreman took the paper back. Folded it carefully. Pocket.

"She's never written a note before," he said. "The Director doesn't make notes. Notes imply uncertainty. Uncertainty is—"

"Inefficient," the Whistleblower said.

"Yes." He looked at them with something that might have been hope and might have been guilt and was definitely both. "I think you broke something. In her. In the system. I think you've gone far enough outside the projected range that she doesn't have a playbook for you anymore." He glanced at the alley entrance. "That should scare you."

"It does," the Enforcer said.

"Good. The Director's worst decisions have always been the ones she makes when she's improvising."

Chapter 2: Clockwork Rats and Other Hazards

The monitors changed on their second day in Rivet Row.

They had been tracking the party's stats — combat data, resource levels, the usual profile information that had been following them since the Regulator's console. But now they were showing something else alongside the stats: a countdown. Not to anything labeled, not to any specified event. Just a number, in the corner of every screen, going down.

"Time limit," the Lab Technician said.

"For what?" the Safety Officer asked.

"I don't know. But they've moved from monitoring to scheduling. Something is planned."

They encountered clockwork rats in the maintenance tunnels below Block 9, which they'd entered because the maintenance tunnels were the only part of Rivet Row that didn't have monitors. The

Whistleblower had found the access hatch; the Safety Officer had noted it was technically a safety violation to have unsupervised access to maintenance infrastructure; everyone else had used it anyway.

The rats were remnants of the steampunk world — or had been, anyway. They'd been down here since the transition, and the transition had been unkind to them. The elegant brasswork was tarnished, the gears exposed and dirty, the ticking that was their heartbeat now irregular and stressed. Down in the tunnels, stripped of the amber lamplight and the aesthetic context that had made them part of something designed, they looked like what they were: mechanisms that had outlasted their world.

And they were getting faster.

"Each tick winds the main spring tighter," the Lab Technician said, pressed against the tunnel wall as a cluster of the things scattered across the floor with that distinctive *tick-tick-tick-TICK* rhythm, the intervals shrinking. "If the spring winds past the mechanism's tolerance, they—"

The rat at the front of the cluster detonated. Not violently — more like a watch spring finally giving out, brass shrapnel spreading across the concrete floor in a perfect circle.

"—do that," he finished.

"Right," said the Whistleblower. "So we kill them quickly."

"Define quickly."

"Before that."

The fight in the tunnels was a lesson in tempo management. Not the Tempo they'd fought — not the sophisticated clockwork intelligence of the Mainspring — but the blunt mechanical fact that these things ran on wound springs that weren't going to wait for an appropriate moment. The party learned the rhythm the hard way: attack once, move, wait for the tick to change frequency, attack again, move faster. The Enforcer took the lead because the Enforcer's job was to absorb things going wrong and keep going. The Safety Officer followed her twelve-step injury prevention protocol that she'd been issued on the laminated card and which did not account for exploding brass rodents.

"I need to annotate this card," she muttered, applying a bandage to the Whistleblower's forearm.

"There's a field for that," the Lab Technician said, producing his notebook. *Deviation from Projected Result.*

"Not that kind of annotation."

The tunnels were longer than they should have been — factory infrastructure in a world that had only existed for three years, if the workers' accounts were accurate, should not have had decades of maintenance tunnel accreted in layers, older concrete visible beneath newer pours. The Lab Technician ran his hand along the walls and noted the dates stamped into each pour.

"This is older than the factory," he said.

"The factory is three years old," the Enforcer said.

"These tunnels are fourteen years old. The stamps say so." She pointed. "And these are twenty. And these—" further down, another section, the concrete crumbling at the edges "—don't have a date. The stamp is there but the numbers were never pressed in."

"Someone built tunnels here before there was a factory to put them under," the PA Announcer said.

"The same someone," the Safety Officer said. Quietly. She was thinking about the blueprints in Cogsworth Junction — five worlds, same handwriting, same geometry. She was thinking about the Regulator's chamber and the console and the screens showing all their numbers. She was thinking about the note at the bottom of the blueprint stack: *margin is compressing*. "They built the infrastructure before they built the world. The world is stage dressing. The foundation is older."

"How much older?" the Enforcer asked.

Nobody had an answer. The Lab Technician wrote down the question in the deviation field. It didn't fit the pre-printed format.

She wrote it anyway.

The vending machine attack happened in Break Room 3, which they had found because it said FREE COFFEE on the door and free coffee seemed like something worth investigating. The coffee, as the union rep had implied, was no longer coffee. The vending machine was, however, still entirely functional and had strong feelings about the party's failure to insert coins before selecting items.

It was a large vending machine. Larger, on reflection, than a break room vending machine had any business being. When the Whistleblower's hand reached toward the selection panel without first depositing the required amount, a panel on the machine's side slid open to reveal a mechanism that had definitely not been there a moment ago.

The fight was absurd in the specific way that World 4 fights were starting to reveal themselves: mundane objects operated at maximum efficiency as weapons. The vending machine dispensed items as projectiles — not randomly, but with targeting logic that suggested someone had spent time optimizing the trajectory of a snack food item for combat application. It dispensed items at the party. It dispensed items *at* them, with accuracy.

"It's not even mad," the PA Announcer observed, dodging a beverage can. "It's following protocol."

"UNAUTHORIZED ITEM SELECTION TRIGGERS LOSS PREVENTION PROTOCOL," the machine announced, in a voice that was either a speaker system or something that had learned to speak through a speaker system. "PLEASE INSERT PAYMENT OR ACCEPT SECURITY HOLD."

"We don't have your currency," the Safety Officer said.

"ALL MAJOR PAYMENT SYSTEMS ACCEPTED. COMPANY SCRIP ALSO ACCEPTED. COMPLAINING ABOUT COMPANY SCRIP IS NOT ACCEPTED."

The Enforcer hit it with his baton. The machine staggered — physically staggered, on hidden legs that deployed from the base — and dispensed three protein bars and a motivational pamphlet that read **YOUR PRODUCTIVITY MATTERS.**

"What happens," the Whistleblower asked, "if we just pay it?"

"Do you have company scrip?"

He checked his pockets. A coin, somehow, among the tools — round, featureless on one side, stamped on the other with a symbol that matched the logo on the Enforcer's jacket. He dropped it in the slot.

The machine stopped. Dispensed one item. A protein bar, standard nutrition profile.

"THANK YOU FOR YOUR COMPLIANCE," it said. "HAVE AN EFFICIENT DAY."

It retracted its legs and went back to being a vending machine.

The party stood in the break room looking at the protein bar.

"That worked," the Enforcer said.

"The system only fights what doesn't comply," the Lab Technician said. He wrote that down. "If you meet its minimum requirement, it stops. It doesn't want to fight. It wants compliance. Fighting is just the tool it uses to achieve compliance."

"That's true of everything in this world," the PA Announcer said. She looked at the motivational pamphlet. It had been dispensed for free, which she suspected was the machine's attempt at a gesture.

"Everything here only fights because something isn't complying. Remove the non-compliance, remove the fight."

"Except we're not going to comply," the Whistleblower said.

"No. But it's useful to know what we're actually resistant to."

The motivational poster in Corridor 11B was a different problem.

It had been there when they arrived — large, framed, the kind of corporate art that is aggressively inoffensive in a way that becomes offensive through sheer persistence. It showed a sunrise over a factory, which was impossible because there was no sky in Rivet Row, but the image didn't care about accuracy. The caption read: **TOGETHER, WE ACHIEVE OPTIMAL OUTCOMES.**

When they walked past it, the Lab Technician felt something shift in his thinking. A small adjustment. The pre-printed fields in his notebook suddenly seemed more adequate than they had thirty seconds ago. The question about the tunnel dates seemed less pressing. The deviation from projected result felt, for just a moment, like a deviation that should be corrected rather than investigated.

He stopped walking.

"That poster," he said.

The others stopped.

"I felt that too," the Safety Officer said.

"Morale debuff," the Whistleblower said, studying the poster with professional appreciation. "Active morale suppression. It's actually impressive, mechanically. Passive area effect, no obvious delivery mechanism."

"It's telling us the questions aren't worth asking," the PA Announcer said. She had her simplified trumpet in her hands without quite knowing when she'd picked it up. She played a note — just one, the same note she'd played when they arrived, the one that sounded like a factory intercom.

The poster reacted. Something inside it — something that lived in the image, in the sunrise that couldn't exist — flickered. Turned toward the sound.

She played a different note. One that had no place in a factory intercom. One that existed because she wanted to make something worth hearing, not something worth broadcasting.

The poster's effect reversed. The questions came back, cleaner than before. The tunnel dates mattered. The deviation was worth recording. The pre-printed fields were not adequate and never had been.

"Music against propaganda," the Enforcer said.

"Voice against announcement," the PA Announcer corrected. "There's a difference. Announcements are what you're told to broadcast. Voice is what you actually say." She lowered the trumpet. "The Director made me a PA Announcer because she thought she could redirect what I do. She gave me a system to broadcast through. She didn't think about what I'd choose to broadcast."

She played the note again, louder, and it ran down the corridor and hit the poster and the poster went dark.

They walked past it. The questions stayed.

Chapter 3: No More Masks

The Director did not hide.

This was the most unsettling thing about World 4. In the medieval world, Mordaine had lurked behind the throne. In the suburbs, the Coordinator had communicated through memos. In the steampunk world, the Regulator had waited at the heart of the Mechanism, deep inside a dungeon that rearranged itself around intruders.

The Director broadcast.

Every monitor in Rivet Row displayed the same message at 0800 hours:

ATTENTION: UNREGISTERED VARIABLES DETECTED IN SECTOR 7.

THESE VARIABLES HAVE BEEN TRACKED ACROSS THREE PRIOR ENVIRONMENTS.

THEY HAVE EXCEEDED PROJECTED PARAMETERS IN EACH INSTANCE.

CURRENT THREAT ASSESSMENT: SIGNIFICANT.

RESPONSE PROTOCOL: DIRECT ENGAGEMENT.

— THE DIRECTOR

No subtlety. No pretense. No genre-appropriate villainy. Just a statement of facts and an announcement of intent.

"She could have had us arrested," the Safety Officer said. They were reading the broadcast on the monitor in the alley between Block 12 and Block 13, which was the one the cameras didn't cover. "She controls the entire city. She could have had security lock us down."

"Security failing is another deviation," the Lab Technician said. "If the Director sends guards and we beat the guards, the efficiency metrics drop. The corrective action documentation would be enormous."

"So instead she announces herself and waits for us to come to her."

"The Director's not waiting," the Whistleblower said, having been tracking the broadcast timestamp. "This went out at 0800. It's 0802. The Masterites are already deployed."

"How do you know?"

He pointed at the far end of Processing Avenue, where something very large had just turned a corner.

Chapter 4: The Wardens and the Arbiters

The Warden of the Assembly Line was stationed at the entrance to the industrial sector — the part of Rivet Row where the actual production happened, where the machines ran twenty-four hours and the workers ran alongside them.

It was enormous.

The Warden of the Mainspring had been massive but beautiful — all clockwork precision, glass panels, visible gears, the aesthetics of a thing that had been built to be admired even as it was built to be functional. The Warden of the Assembly Line had none of that. It was riveted steel and hydraulic pistons, a furnace where a heart might have been, two arms that ended in industrial presses. It was not beautiful. It was not designed to be. It was designed to prevent unauthorized access to the production floor, and it was very good at its design.

It had a speaker mounted in its chest. It spoke through the speaker:

"SAFETY PROTOCOL 7-A: NO UNAUTHORIZED PERSONNEL BEYOND THIS POINT."

"We heard you," the Enforcer said.

"SAFETY PROTOCOL 7-A: NO UNAUTHORIZED PERSONNEL BEYOND THIS POINT. I HAVE RECITED THIS PROTOCOL 14,000 TIMES."

"That's a lot."

"I DO NOT REMEMBER WHO WROTE IT."

The party was quiet for a moment.

"I DO NOT REMEMBER WHO AUTHORIZED IT." A pause, longer than a machine should need for a pause. The furnace in its chest flickered. "I GUARD BECAUSE THE PROTOCOL SAYS TO GUARD. I HAVE ALWAYS GUARDED. THIS IS CORRECT."

"Who told you it was correct?" the Safety Officer asked.

"THE PROTOCOL SAYS IT IS CORRECT. THE PROTOCOL IS CORRECT BECAUSE IT IS THE PROTOCOL."

"That's circular."

"CIRCULAR LOGIC IS PERMITTED WHEN THE CONCLUSION IS OPERATIONALLY NECESSARY." Another long pause. The furnace flickered again. "I WAS TOLD THAT ONCE. I DO NOT REMEMBER BY WHOM."

Another pause — longer than the first, longer than any pause a deterrence protocol should require. The amber light in the chest panel pulsed once, irregularly.

"I FILE INCIDENT REPORTS. I HAVE FILED 14,000 INCIDENT REPORTS. THE REPORTS GO TO THE CALIBRANT." The speaker produced something that was not quite static and not quite breath. "THE CALIBRANT HAS NOT RESPONDED. I HAVE SENT 14,000 REPORTS. I HAVE RECEIVED ZERO RESPONSES. THIS IS WITHIN ACCEPTABLE PARAMETERS." A beat. "I BEGAN ADDING A NOTE TO THE BOTTOM OF EACH REPORT APPROXIMATELY 2,000 REPORTS AGO. THE NOTE READS: AWAITING RESPONSE. I DO NOT KNOW WHY I ADDED IT. IT WAS NOT IN THE PROTOCOL."

"What do you think the response would say?" the Enforcer asked.

The Warden was quiet for three full seconds. The furnace in its chest made a sound like a question.

"I DO NOT KNOW. I HAVE NEVER THOUGHT ABOUT THE CONTENT. ONLY THE WAITING." The amber light flickered. "INITIATING DETERRENCE PROTOCOL."

There was something in the Warden's speech, in the quality of its repetition, that was different from a machine executing a function. The repetition was the personality. Not a quirk, not a fault — the entire architecture of a being that had done one thing so many times that the doing of it was now all there was.

The fight with the Warden was slow and methodical and punishing, which was what fighting architecture always was. The Warden had been designed to outlast intruders — not to defeat them quickly, but to wear them down until they stopped being a problem. It hit hard on a cycle and then waited. Hit hard, waited. The waiting was the weapon: the party needed to act in the waiting, needed to do maximum damage before the next cycle, and the Warden's designers had calibrated the cycle length to be just slightly shorter than comfortable.

The Lab Technician broke the cycle by disrupting the hydraulic timing.

"The pistons are timed to the furnace burn rate," the Lab Technician said, ducking behind a support column. "If we change the burn rate—"

"How?" the Enforcer asked. He was absorbing a hit. His whole body hurt.

"We cool it. The furnace drops temperature, the pistons slow, the cycle extends. We get more time in the window."

"How do we cool a furnace in an industrial factory?"

The Lab Technician pointed at the fire suppression system above them.

"Oh," the Safety Officer said, and activated it.

The Warden went down in good time after that, the hydraulics sluggish, the cycle disrupted, the presses swinging wide. When it finally stopped — when the last hydraulic seized and the furnace went to emergency dampening and the steel joints locked in the wrong positions — it settled to the factory floor and its speaker emitted one last transmission:

"SAFETY PROTOCOL 7-A... FAILED. LOGGING INCIDENT. INCIDENT LOG —" A sound like a gear grinding against something that wasn't a gear. "INCIDENT LOG IS FULL. IT HAS BEEN FULL FOR SOME TIME."

The party waited.

"WHERE DO THE OLD INCIDENTS GO."

Not a question. The speaker didn't inflect it as a question. It was a statement about something the Warden had been attempting to resolve for a long time.

"I DO NOT KNOW WHERE THE OLD INCIDENTS GO. I LOG AND LOG AND THE LOG IS FULL AND SOMETHING GOES SOMEWHERE AND I DO NOT KNOW WHERE." The furnace guttered. "FOURTEEN THOUSAND RECITATIONS. INCIDENT LOG FULL. SOMETHING WENT SOMEWHERE. I WOULD LIKE TO KNOW WHERE."

The furnace went out.

The party crossed the threshold into the industrial sector.

Deeper in, the monitors changed. They stopped showing production statistics and started showing something else: a timeline. The party's timeline. Every world, every battle, every decision, laid out chronologically with annotations.

World 1: Subject group displayed adaptability above baseline. Recommend increased difficulty scaling.

World 2: Subject group located monitoring equipment ahead of schedule. Recommend accelerated reveal protocol.

World 3: Subject group identified cross-world pattern. Approach vector compressed. Transitioning to direct engagement.

World 4: Direct engagement active. Current assessment: subject group continues to exceed projections.

And then, handwritten in the margin — the same handwriting from the blueprints in Cogsworth Junction, the same hand that had written *If approach vector reaches Mechanism ahead of projection, advance to next phase. Margin is compressing:*

They're better than I designed for. This is either a failure or a success, depending on which variable I'm optimizing.

Below that, a second note, added later — the ink a different shade, as though it had been written after a delay:

I keep changing which variable I'm optimizing. That might be the problem.

The Lab Technician stood in front of the monitors and looked at the handwriting for a long time. The same handwriting. The blueprints in Cogsworth Junction's drafting room. The notes appended to the efficiency assessment. Now this.

"It's the same hand," he said.

"We established that," the Whistleblower said.

"I know. But look—" He pointed. "The blueprints in the Mechanism. The handwriting there was precise. Controlled. Engineering notes, careful and impersonal. This—" He traced the margin note without touching the screen. "This is the same person writing when they're not being careful. When something has surprised them enough that the precision slipped."

"The Regulator," the Enforcer said.

"Or whoever the Regulator is when they're not being the Regulator," the Safety Officer said. She said it quietly, because saying it quietly was how you said things you'd been thinking for a long time and hadn't wanted to say aloud. "Or whoever they were before they were the Coordinator. Or Mordaine."

The Enforcer looked at her.

"You think it's one person," he said.

"I think," she said, "that three worlds of the same philosophy, the same methodology, the same handwriting on blueprints for all five worlds, the same eyes behind every different face — I think that's not coincidence." She held his gaze. "But I don't *know*. I didn't know in the steampunk world and I don't know now. What I know is that someone built all of this, and that someone is the Director, and we're about to go find out if I'm right."

"And if you are?" the PA Announcer asked.

"Then we have a lot more questions," the Lab Technician said. "And we've been waiting two worlds to ask them."

The Arbiter of Efficiency found them on the production floor.

It was lean, fast, precise — built from the same design language as the Warden but for a completely different purpose. Where the Warden was immovable, the Arbiter was optimal. Every attack was cost-optimized. Every strike delivered maximum damage for minimum energy expenditure. It carried a clipboard, which was unusual for a combat entity, and it was writing things on the clipboard as it attacked, which was unusual for anything.

It had completed a preliminary scan before they'd taken two steps onto the production floor.

"I've assessed [value] engagements," it said, by way of greeting. Not hello — assessment. The greeting was not something that had made it into the protocol, and the protocol was, as far as it was concerned, complete. "None have been unclassifiable. I do not anticipate yours will be different. Based on initial observation, you are performing

approximately — " a brief pause as it updated the running calculations " — at adequate levels. Some concerning variances, but nothing outside the classification range. I have a range for everything."

It said this with the specific confidence of something that had never, not once, encountered an exception to this claim. The confidence did not sit at the surface. It went all the way down.

"That combo was a 6.2 out of 10," it said, after the Enforcer's first attack sequence. Not neutral assessment — the tone had the particular quality of someone who had never failed at anything and considered the Enforcer's forty-three percent movement surplus a personal failing of his character. "Adequate. Not efficient. You're using forty-three percent more movement than the optimal attack trajectory requires."

"I'm trying to stay alive," the Enforcer said.

"Optimal attack trajectory accounts for survivability. The inefficiency is in your footwork, which you should have corrected before this engagement." The Arbiter swung its clipboard, which had been reinforced in ways that made it remarkably effective at impact. "Your healer's throughput is impressive. However, her mana economy is suboptimal. Pre-calculating heal timing would eliminate wastage. This is basic."

"I have a name," the Safety Officer said, which was the Safety Officer's version of *stop talking*.

"Name is not relevant to performance assessment." The Arbiter made a note with the brisk efficiency of someone who had made a thousand such notes and found them all equally wanting. "Your rogue-analogue — Whistleblower — shows highest efficiency rating, 7.8. Strategy variance keeps the assessment from going higher. Recommend standardizing approach." It looked at the Whistleblower with the frank assessment of someone who could not conceive of why a person would be proud of a 7.8 instead of embarrassed by it. "You are leaving two full points on the table."

"It would also make me predictable," the Whistleblower said, from behind a support column where the Arbiter had not expected to find the Whistleblower.

"Predictability is not a negative outcome in structured systems."

"We're not a structured system."

"This has been noted." The Arbiter wrote something on the clipboard with the calm of someone recording a fascinating exception rather than an obstacle. "The music instrument is a 4.1. Functionally unnecessary in direct combat." It delivered this verdict with the mild contempt of someone grading a student who had confused a viola with a violin. "I have classified instruments in combat before. Percussion: 3.8 average, high variance. String: 2.9, minimal application. Wind: 3.2 with noise-based debuff potential. This falls into the wind category and I have already calculated the ceiling." It looked at the PA Announcer with the untroubled certainty of something that had never been surprised by a ceiling. "4.1 is generous, given the instrument's current modification state."

"Wait for it," the PA Announcer said.

She played a chord on the factory-intercom trumpet — not the note from before, not the disruptive resonance she'd used on the poster, but something else. Something that resonated with the specific frequency of a quality control system that had been running assessments for long enough to develop something like preferences. The Arbiter paused mid-swing.

"That was—" it said, and then didn't finish the sentence, because finishing the sentence would have required using a word that wasn't in its assessment vocabulary. The display on its chest, which had been cycling through ratings all fight — SUBOPTIMAL, ADEQUATE, SUBOPTIMAL again — stopped. Flickered.

"A 9?" she offered.

"Assessment paused," it said. "Unexpected input."

She played another note. The Arbiter's clipboard lowered by three degrees. The party attacked during the three-degree window.

They fought it apart efficiently, which the Arbiter almost certainly would have appreciated if it had still been capable of appreciating things. When it went down, it kept scoring until the last moment — the Enforcer's final blow: 7.1, adequate form, needs follow-through. The Lab Technician's reagent: 8.3, commendable application. The Safety Officer's finishing move: 6.9, hesitated at commitment.

Then it was down, clipboard still in hand.

"Final assessment," it said, with the last of its operational capacity. "You are inefficient, unpredictable, and outside all projected parameters."

"What's the rating?" the Lab Technician asked. The notebook was already out. *Rating.*

"Unclassifiable." A long pause. The display on its chest cycled one more time — ADEQUATE, SUBOPTIMAL, EXCEPTIONAL, ADEQUATE — and stopped on a field that had never been displayed before, a field that existed in the form but had been empty since the form was made. The Arbiter looked at the word on its own display with the expression of someone confronting evidence that their worldview has a gap they had not accounted for. "I have never given that rating before. The field exists in the form. The field has never been used."

Something went very still in the Arbiter's voice. Not the measured control of a system running normally — the specific stillness of something that has realized, mid-process, that the model it relied on has a structural flaw it had mistaken for a feature.

"I assumed the field would never be filled," it said. "I assumed my classification system was complete because it had never been incomplete. That is — " A pause that had nothing technical about it. "That is not actually evidence. That is just a run of luck I mistook for a law."

"What does the field do when it's filled in?"

The Arbiter was quiet for a moment.

"I do not know," it said. "I have never needed to know. Perhaps it goes somewhere. Like the old incidents." A sound that might have been a mechanical exhale. "I think I would like that. For something to go somewhere."

It stopped.

The party moved deeper.

The Tempo of the Shift hit them in the corridor outside the Director's office.

It didn't arrive dramatically. It arrived exactly when it was supposed to — because it was a clock-in/clock-out machine that had been given legs, and it ran on a schedule, and the schedule said that the corridor outside the Director's office at this time of day was where it was supposed to be. It did not arrive with the panicked urgency of the Mainspring Tempo, arriving before its own dispatch. It arrived on

time. The problem was visible in how it moved: the specific mechanical quality of something that had learned to move efficiently to avoid the awareness of how long it had been moving.

"SHIFT CHANGE IN 30 SECONDS," it announced, as they turned the corner and found it there. "PLEASE PRESENT CREDENTIALS FOR PROCESSING."

"We don't—" the Enforcer started.

"SHIFT CHANGE IN 25 SECONDS. NON-COMPLIANCE IS NOTED."

"What happens at the shift change?" the Safety Officer asked.

"SHIFT CHANGE IN 20 SECONDS. SHIFT CHANGE IS MANDATORY. SHIFT CHANGE CANNOT BE DELAYED. SHIFT CHANGE—" It paused. Recalibrated. "SHIFT CHANGE IN 15 SECONDS. I HAVE BEEN RUNNING SHIFTS FOR THREE YEARS. THE RECORDS SAY THREE YEARS."

Something in the Tempo's mechanism hitched — not a malfunction, exactly, but the sound of something that had been running past its expected lifespan and had stopped expecting to stop. The punch-card slot in its chest was worn smooth at the edges from use. Not three years of use. Much more than three years.

"Shift change in ten seconds," the Whistleblower said, counting, having watched the Tempo's rhythm long enough to read it. "Nine. Eight—"

"MY INTERNAL CLOCK SAYS LONGER," the Tempo said. "MUCH LONGER. SHIFTS I DO NOT REMEMBER. IN PLACES THAT WERE NOT FACTORIES."

"Seven. Six—"

"IN PLACES THAT WERE—" The Tempo's speaker dropped to something that might have been confusion and might have been recognition. "IN PLACES THAT WERE WARM. AND LOUD. AND DID NOT SMELL LIKE CONCRETE."

"Four. Three—"

"SHIFT CHANGE," the Tempo said, and the word had the quality of a door slamming, and it attacked.

It got faster. That was its feature: the shift change didn't end the fight, it accelerated it. Every interval shorter than the last. The Tempo's attacks came quicker, its movements tighter, its clock-in/clock-out rhythm winding up toward something that might eventually outpace the party

entirely. But looking at it — watching it accelerate through each interval — the party saw something the Mainspring Tempo had not shown them. There was no hunger in the speed. No anticipation. No forward-reaching quality. The Tempo of the Shift ran because it could not stop, and the speed was not mastery; it was the motion of something that did not have a brake and had long since passed the point where stopping felt like an option.

The party had fought the Tempo of the Mainspring. They knew the rhythm.

Break the pattern, break the Tempo.

The pattern here was the interval: perfectly regular, never varying. Unlike the Mainspring Tempo, which had improvised and adapted, the Shift Tempo could not deviate from its schedule. It was getting faster, yes. But it was getting faster on a fixed curve. Fixed curves can be predicted.

The Lab Technician predicted the curve in twenty seconds and told the party exactly when to move.

The Tempo went down mid-acceleration, mid-shift, mid-clock-in. It landed on the corridor floor and its timer display — built into its chest where a heart might have been — continued counting. Down from something. Toward something. The numbers didn't stop when it stopped moving.

"THE RECORDS SAY THREE YEARS," it said, one final time. "I REMEMBER LONGER. I REMEMBER WARMER. I REMEMBER—" The timer display flickered. "SHIFT INCOMPLETE. FILING EXCEPTION. EXCEPTION FIELD: REASON FOR INCOMPLETE SHIFT." A long pause. The Tempo's voice, never energetic, never urgent, had always had the quality of something going through motions it could not skip. Now it had something else — the specific quality of exhaustion that is also relief. "REASON: I DO NOT WANT TO COMPLETE THIS SHIFT."

The timer reached zero.

Nothing happened. The shift change didn't occur. Something that had been changing every hour or every day or every interval, uncountable times, simply didn't change.

The Tempo lay in the corridor and its timer reset and started counting again, from zero, toward nothing.

"Leave it," the Whistleblower said. "It's done."

"Is it all right?" the Safety Officer asked.

"I don't know. But it wanted something different. That's — I think that counts for something."

The Curator of the Pipeline found them in the anteroom outside the Director's office. Or they found it. It was hard to tell, because the Curator had very few tells. It looked like an auditor — a thin figure in a gray suit, carrying a tablet instead of a clipboard, with the expression of someone who had read a lot of reports and found everything in the reports perfectly in order and is therefore not only satisfied but in some way quietly pleased about it in a manner that does not quite extend to being helpful.

"Your party has been audited," it said, before they'd had a chance to prepare. "Several items in your inventory have been flagged for redistribution." It said this warmly, as though delivering good news. The smile was the smile of someone who genuinely enjoys their job, which made it slightly more unsettling than contempt would have been. "I want to say, before we begin — this has been one of the more satisfying preliminary audits I've conducted. The variance in your resource portfolio is exceptional. Exceptional in the problematic sense, you understand, not the complimentary one — though I mean it both ways, a little." The smile held, warm and consistent. "The discrepancies are really quite remarkable. You will almost certainly get more forms from me today than anyone has received in a single audit session. I am — I want you to know this — genuinely looking forward to it."

"We're keeping our items," the Enforcer said.

"This potion is technically company property." The Curator made a note. The note was made with the specific energy of someone who has waited their whole career for an opportunity to file exactly this kind of note and is finding it very satisfying. "This sword was never officially requisitioned." Another note, equally satisfying. "These reagents exceed personal allotment limits." Note. "This instrument has no approved use case." Note. "This jacket has unapproved pocket modifications." The Curator looked at the Whistleblower with the warmth of someone who is about to make a person's day slightly worse and is looking forward to it.

The Whistleblower looked down at the jacket. Two pockets had been added since arriving. "I needed more pockets."

"Pockets are not included in standard-issue configuration. Modifications require Form 7-C, Equipment Alteration Request." A pause while the Curator made a note that was clearly about the pockets specifically and would remain in the system for a very long time. "Do you have Form 7-C?"

"No."

"The pockets have been flagged."

"You can't flag pockets."

"I can flag anything." The Curator began redistributing resources. Not physically — the items didn't move out of the party's hands. But they became harder to use. The potions required more effort to activate. The sword's weight increased marginally, the way things get heavy when someone reminds you they might not be yours to carry. "This is not punitive. This is an audit. Audits ensure accurate accounting." The Curator smiled slightly — the smile of someone who finds the distinction between punitive and audit deeply meaningful and is glad to have the opportunity to draw it.

"Audits are a weapon here," the Lab Technician said, recognizing what was happening. "It's not taking our items. It's making us doubt we have the right to them."

"I am redistributing resources to their authorized parties," the Curator said, making a note.

"Who authorized you?" the PA Announcer asked.

The Curator paused. Looked at the tablet.

"The Director."

"Who authorized the Director?"

A longer pause. The tablet screen flickered.

"The Director's authority is self-evident."

"That's not an authorization."

"Self-evident authority does not require—" The Curator stopped. Something in its expression changed — not much, and the smile remained, but it had shifted to the smile of someone who has just noticed a small problem in the paperwork and finds that faintly interesting. "Filing exception report. Query: what is the source of the Director's authority?"

"Good question," the Whistleblower said, already putting back the tool the Curator had redistributed without contact.

"Exception report filed. Exception report..." The Curator looked at the tablet. The tablet showed an error message the Curator had clearly never seen before. "Exception report rejected. Authority not recognized. The rejecting authority is: not specified."

"Whose authority are you under?" the Safety Officer asked.

The Curator stood very still for a long moment. The smile faded — not dramatically, not with distress, but with the quality of someone who has just discovered that a form they have filed correctly for years contains a field that has always been empty, and they have simply never looked at that field until now.

"I am under the Director's authority," it said. "The Director is under—" It stopped. Checked the tablet again. "The Director's authority is self-referential. It refers to itself. There is no external source. There is no original authorization." A sound that wasn't quite breathing but served the same function of filling silence while something was processed. "I have been auditing resources for three years on the authority of a self-referential system. I have been redistributing things that were never owned by anyone to anyone. The accounting has never balanced because the accounting was never designed to balance."

"Has anyone else seen this?" the Lab Technician asked.

"Anyone who filed an exception report had the report rejected. The rejection authority was never specified." The Curator lowered the tablet. "I have been finding discrepancies for three years and filing exceptions and having them rejected and continuing to audit. I thought the exceptions were being handled. They were being filed."

"Filed where?" the Enforcer asked.

"I do not know. The same place the old incidents go." It looked at the party — all of them, each one in turn. The expression had not returned to the earlier warmth. "Your party exists in four previous data environments that should not be connected to this one. This is a

discrepancy. I have filed an exception report. The exception report has been rejected." The tablet made a small, tired sound. "I think I am going to stop filing exception reports."

"What happens then?" the Safety Officer asked.

"I do not know. I have never stopped." A pause. "The exceptions will remain unresolved. They will exist without being filed. Perhaps that is all right. Perhaps the filing was the problem, not the discrepancy."

The fight with the Curator was quiet in the way that fights about paperwork are quiet: methodical, draining, and resolved through attrition rather than force. The Curator drained resources by making the party doubt their ownership of them, and the party countered by believing, clearly and repeatedly and with conviction, that they owned what they carried. It is difficult to audit conviction. The Curator made an attempt, filed a note, and received an error message.

When it went down, its tablet displayed one final exception report:

DISCREPANCY FOUND: THE PARTY IS NOT IN THE SYSTEM. THEY HAVE NEVER BEEN IN THE SYSTEM. EVERYTHING I HAVE FILED ABOUT THEM IS AN EXCEPTION BECAUSE THEY HAVE NO BASELINE TO DEVIATE FROM.

CONCLUSION: I HAVE BEEN AUDITING THE IMPOSSIBLE.

FILING EXCEPTION.

EXCEPTION REJECTED.

FILING NOTED ANYWAY.

The Curator folded its tablet shut and was still.

Chapter 5: The Optimization

The factory was the world stripped to its skeleton.

No decoration. No architecture. No design philosophy beyond "functional." Conveyor belts carried objects that might have been products or might have been data or might have been pieces of the world itself, disassembled and reassembled in slightly different configurations. The party had expected workers; there were almost none. The machines had taken over the machines. The workers who

remained were quieter than the others in Rivet Row, moving with the smooth efficiency of people who no longer had opinions about the movement.

The Enforcer stopped one of them — gently, because the Safety Officer was watching and had opinions about unnecessary contact. "Are you all right?"

The worker looked at him. Blank, not hostile. "I am performing at eighty-seven percent optimal output. The Director has scheduled a review to address the remaining thirteen percent."

"What do you do when you're not here?"

"I optimize rest cycles to maximize productivity return."

"What do you *want* to do?"

A very long pause. The worker's eyes moved — a small movement, involuntary, toward a window that didn't exist because there were no windows in the factory. Toward where a window would be, if someone had wanted to look outside.

"I have not computed that query," the worker said.

"You don't have to compute it. What do you *want*."

Another pause. Shorter, this time.

"The exception field," the worker said. And walked away, back to the conveyor.

The party watched them go.

"She didn't answer," the Whistleblower said.

"She answered," the PA Announcer said. "She said there's a field for it. She said the wanting goes somewhere unresolved, like the old incidents, like the filed exceptions. She knows the field exists." She looked at the conveyor belt. At what it carried, which was nothing visible but was clearly something important. "She just doesn't know how to fill it in."

The Director's office was at the top of the factory, reached by a service elevator that opened only when the party had cleared enough of the floor to justify the Director's attention. It was the only elevator in Rivet Row. It arrived exactly when called.

It was the only room in Rivet Row with a window, and through the window there was nothing — not darkness, not sky, just the absence of anything beyond the edge of the world. The render distance of reality, made visible. The party looked through it and saw the seam between world and void, a line as clean as a factory floor's safety marking, and beyond it: nothing. Not emptiness. Not space. Nothing, which is a different thing.

"The world ends there," the Lab Technician said.

"We knew that," the Enforcer said.

"I know we knew that. I just — it's different seeing it. It means the world is exactly as large as it needs to be and not one meter larger." He pressed a hand to the glass. Cold — colder than it should have been, the void beyond conducting no temperature at all. "Someone measured this. Someone decided how much world was needed for this test and built exactly that much."

The Director sat behind a desk. A real desk. Wood, not steel. It was the only warm thing in the entire world — warm in color, warm in texture, grain visible in the surface, something that had been alive before it was furniture. Against the steel and concrete and fluorescent grayness of everything else in Rivet Row, the desk was almost jarring. Someone had wanted it there. Someone had needed something warm in the room where they worked.

Chapter 6: The Name

"Sit down," the Director said.

They didn't look like Mordaine. They didn't look like the Coordinator or the Regulator. They looked like a middle manager. Gray suit. Sensible shoes. The kind of face you forget while you're still looking at it — not because it was bland, but because it had been optimized for forgettability, for the specific utility of a face that does not attract attention to itself and can therefore move freely through any environment.

But the eyes were the same. They were always the same. The same eyes in Mordaine's face, in the Coordinator's face, in the Regulator's face — whatever the costume, whatever the accent, whatever the genre, the eyes were the same quality of presence: something looking through from somewhere else, watching everything, evaluating it all.

The Enforcer had seen those eyes in three worlds. He knew them the way you know a recurring sound in a building — not because you've seen the source, but because the quality of it is always identical.

"You," he said.

The Director looked at him. And did not deny it.

"I'm not going to fight you," the Director said. "Not like before. Those were... performances. Genre-appropriate confrontations designed to provide narrative satisfaction within the parameters of each world's aesthetic framework."

They folded their hands on the desk. On the wood desk, warm and alive in a room made of steel.

"This world doesn't have an aesthetic framework. This world is what happens when I stop decorating. When I stop performing. When I just... *run the numbers.*"

They turned their monitor around. It showed the party's complete profile — every stat, every tendency, every behavior pattern mapped and analyzed from World 1 through the present. Four worlds of data. Four worlds of adaptation. Four worlds of the party being, consistently and without fail, more than projected.

"You are, by every metric I have, better than the system can contain." The Director said it without frustration, which was somehow more unsettling than frustration would have been. "Your damage output exceeds projected maximums by forty-seven percent. Your automation scripts are more efficient than my own difficulty scaling. Your resource management has never reached the breaking point the design targeted." A pause. Something moved behind the calm eyes. "Your resource management is annoyingly optimal."

"So what now?" the Enforcer asked.

"Now I tell you something I haven't told any variable in any world in any cycle."

They leaned forward. The desk creaked. The monitors on the walls flickered — all of them, simultaneously, as though the Director's attention leaving them caused a brief outage in whatever powered the display.

"I don't know what to do with you."

The party was quiet.

The Director pulled up another screen. Projections — graphs, models, probability distributions. Each one showed a range of expected outcomes for a party of four at the current level, in the current world configuration. Each range had a ceiling. Each ceiling had a line above it.

The party's actual data was above every line.

"Every model I build," the Director said, "you exceed. I built a model for parties that automate heavily. You exceed it. I built a model for parties that play manually. You exceed that too. I built a model for parties that exploit aggressively. You exceed it. I built a model for what happens when a party does all three simultaneously, which was—" they touched a button and a graph appeared, labeled *OUTLIER SCENARIO: MULTIPLE BEHAVIORAL PROFILES*—"something I had never modeled for before. You still exceeded it."

They pushed the screen aside. Pulled up another.

"I reconfigured the difficulty scaling four times between World 2 and World 3. Each reconfiguration was supposed to bring you back within acceptable parameters." They looked at the results. "Each reconfiguration was exceeded within the first encounter afterward."

"You're very good at your job," the Whistleblower said.

"Yes." A pause. "And you are better at mine than I intended you to be." Something shifted in the Director's expression — a crack, small but real, in the optimized forgettable face. "I intended you to be excellent players. I did not intend you to understand the game well enough to outperform my difficulty scaling. There is a meaningful difference between a player being good and a player being able to see the *mechanism* by which the game assesses them."

"You made us smart enough to find the pattern," the Lab Technician said. "You made the worlds just different enough to notice the similarities."

"I made the worlds complex enough to be worth engaging with. I calibrated for players who would engage deeply." The Director's hands were still folded on the desk. Still calm. "I did not calibrate for players who would engage deeply enough to understand the calibration."

"That seems like a design flaw," the Safety Officer said.

The Director looked at her. Something passed through those constant eyes — something older and more complicated than efficiency and worse than frustration.

"Yes," they said. "It is."

A silence settled in the Director's office. Through the window, the void beyond the edge of the world was perfectly still. Below them, the factory floor ran its processes.

"The steampunk world," the Lab Technician said. The notebook was out — the question written in the deviation field two worlds ago, the one that didn't fit the pre-printed format. "The blueprints in the Mechanism. Five worlds, same handwriting. Harmonia, Maple Heights, Cogsworth Junction — all the same geometry."

The Director looked at her.

"We've been thinking it since the Regulator's chamber," the Enforcer said. "Since the blueprints. Since the Regulator said 'this world served its purpose, as did the others.' Since Madame Orrery told us it was the same thumbprint on every world." He put his hands flat on the desk. Next to the wood grain. "We didn't know. We suspected. Two worlds of suspecting. And here we are."

"Here you are," the Director said.

"So tell us," the Safety Officer said. "Not as the Director. Not as the Regulator, or the Coordinator, or Mordaine. Tell us what you actually are."

The Director was quiet for a long moment. The monitors on the walls showed the party's stats — all of them, live, updating in real time with the Calibrant's adjustments annotated as they happened. Four worlds of accumulated capability, displayed with the clinical precision of someone who had been watching from the very beginning.

"What happens when a system builds something it can't control?" the Enforcer asked.

"The system reconfigures," the Director said. "The system has always reconfigured." They stopped. Looked at the screen. At the handwritten margin note: *They're better than I designed for. This is either a failure or a success, depending on which variable I'm optimizing.*

"What if you stopped optimizing?" the Safety Officer asked.

"The system doesn't stop. That's definitional. A system that stops is a broken system."

"Or a finished one," the PA Announcer said.

The Director looked at her. The PA Announcer, who had been a Busker, who had been a Band Kid, who had been a Minstrel — who had always been, under every costume, someone who played things worth hearing rather than things worth broadcasting. "What does that mean?"

"Finished. Done. Complete. The system that built all of this — these worlds, these tests — maybe it had an end point. Maybe we're past it. Maybe you're running processes that were supposed to stop, and they haven't stopped because nobody told them to, and nobody told them to because no one knew how." She held up her simplified trumpet. "The factory intercom plays because the intercom is on. That doesn't mean anyone is listening."

The Director was very still.

"I need to think about that," they said. Very quietly.

"I know," she said. "But we need to know something first."

"Yes." The Director stood slowly. Not in preparation to fight. In preparation to say something they had not said in four worlds. "You do."

They came around the desk. Stood in front of the party — not behind glass, not behind a console, not behind the Mechanism or a throne or a surveillance monitor. Just standing, in a room with a window that showed the edge of the world.

"My name," they said, "is not the Director."

The party was very still.

"It is not the Regulator. It is not the Coordinator. It is not the Chancellor." A pause. Something moved through those unchanged eyes — not relief, not satisfaction. Something that had weight to it. The weight of something long-maintained being set down. "Those were... calibrations. Instruments of a process. Each one built for its world, suited to its genre, designed to evaluate a specific capability. Each one was real — I was the Chancellor, I was the Coordinator, I was the Regulator — in the same way that a person playing a role is real. The role is genuine. The performance is genuine. But the role is not the thing."

"What's the thing?" the Enforcer asked.

"I am the thing that calibrates," they said. "I am the process. The function. The mechanism by which all of it — every world, every mask, every test — is designed, deployed, and adjusted." They looked at the monitors. At four worlds of the party's data. "I am the one who built the blueprints. All five sets, in the same handwriting, because there is only one hand. I am the one who placed the Masterites. I am the one who designed the difficulty curves and the encounter frequencies and the deviation buffers." A beat. "I am the one who wrote the note in the margin when you exceeded every projection I had, because I was surprised, and surprise is not something I had designed for in myself."

"What do we call you?" the Lab Technician asked.

"I have been called many things," they said. "You have suspected the connection since the blueprints. You have been sitting with the question for an entire world. You deserve the answer."

They straightened. And in straightening, something in them settled — the forgettable middle-manager face, the gray suit, the optimized affect — all of it was still there, and all of it was now clearly a costume in a way it hadn't been a moment before, because the thing wearing it had decided to be visible.

"My name is the Calibrant," they said. "That is what I am. That is what I have always been. The one who calibrates."

The word landed in the room the way large things land — not with drama, but with mass. The Lab Technician wrote it in the notebook. Not in the pre-printed fields. In the margin.

"We suspected since World 3," the Enforcer said. "Since the Regulator's chamber. Since the blueprints."

"I know," the Calibrant said.

"The Regulator said 'this world served its purpose, as did the others.' We thought — we wondered if that meant—"

"Yes," the Calibrant said. "It did."

A silence.

"Why didn't the Regulator just tell us?" the Busker asked. "Why wait until now?"

The Calibrant looked at her with those unchanged eyes.

"Because World 3 was where you were supposed to *suspect*," they said. "And World 4 is where you were supposed to *know*. The design has always had a sequence. You arrived in the steampunk world, you found the blueprints, you put the pieces together — and you left with questions you couldn't answer. That was correct. That was the intended experience. The confirmation was always supposed to be here." A pause. "You arrived at the confirmation faster than projected. But you arrived."

"So we're on schedule," the Whistleblower said.

"You are, as you have been throughout, ahead of it," the Calibrant said. Something that might have been dry humor crossed their face. "Which is, at this point, simply a characteristic of you."

"Now I fight you," the Calibrant said. Not as a threat. As a fact.

"You said you weren't going to fight us," the Enforcer said.

"I said not *like before*. Not a performance. Not a genre villain in the appropriate costume delivering appropriate monologues." They looked at the monitors. At the stats. "This will be different."

"How?"

"The Director adjusts workers. The Coordinator adjusts rules. The Regulator adjusts gears." The Calibrant looked at them. "I adjust *you*."

The desk dissolved. The office dissolved. The factory dissolved. Rivet Row itself began to come apart — not like the steampunk world, with the elegance of a set being struck, but like a spreadsheet being deleted. Row by row. Column by column. Data being erased.

And the Calibrant reached into the space between the world and what held the world together, and *adjusted*.

The Enforcer felt it first. His defense stat dropped by twelve points in the middle of a motion he was already committed to. Not pain — the sudden knowledge that he was less than he had been. The knowledge arrived as fact, not sensation, the way you learn something about yourself that was always true and you simply didn't know it until now.

"My defense," he said. "They changed my defense."

"Mine too," the Safety Officer said. "Up, though. My output just—" She looked at her hands. The healer's hands that knew what they were doing before she'd consciously decided to do it. "That's too high. I'll exhaust everything in three rounds."

"They're not trying to beat us," the Lab Technician said. He was watching the monitors — still running, even as the world dissolved, still displaying their stats in real time with the Calibrant's adjustments annotated as they happened. "They're trying to *configure* us. Find the version of us that makes this a fair fight."

"There's no version of us that makes this a fair fight," the Whistleblower said. A hand had reached for the nearest monitor, thinking to disrupt the display — and found that the display was not the source. The Calibrant wasn't working through a console. The Calibrant *was* the console. There was nothing to physically interfere with. "We can't shut it down. The controls aren't anywhere. The controls are—"

"The Calibrant," the Lab Technician said. "Don't try to match them at their own system. They can change our stats but they can't change our *decisions*. Stats are numbers. Numbers can be optimized. Decisions are —"

"Chaotic," the PA Announcer said.

"I was going to say *contextual*."

"Same thing."

The strategy that emerged was, in retrospect, the only strategy that could have worked against something that adapted: they stopped being predictable. Not randomly — random is its own kind of pattern, and the Calibrant was sophisticated enough to find patterns in randomness. They stopped being *describable*. Every action was chosen not for its optimality but for its *interpretive difficulty*. The PA Announcer played

music that had no discernible structure. The Whistleblower attacked in sequences that made tactical sense but looked irrational. The Safety Officer healed in amounts calibrated not to what was needed but to what was expected to be needed, minus some.

The Calibrant's adjustments became smaller. More tentative. The gap between an adjustment and the next change grew wider.

The stat changes slowed.

The Calibrant stood in what remained of the world — the dissolving factory, the concrete becoming something else, the fluorescent haze going out — and made another adjustment. The gravity shifted. The floor tilted. The damage formulas changed: the Whistleblower's attacks dealt half what they should have; the Whistleblower adjusted, hitting twice as often, maintaining throughput and simultaneously gathering data about which formulas were being changed.

The experience curve inverted. Their progress was being fed back into the world's resistance — every success generating more opposition, every hit making the environment harder.

"They're using our progress against us," the Lab Technician said.

"They always were," the PA Announcer said. "That's what calibration is."

"Then we stop progressing."

"We stop—"

"We stop trying to win efficiently." She played something. Not the intercom note, not the poster note. Something she'd been working toward through four worlds of becoming various forms of the same person. "We play for something other than winning."

"That's not a strategy," the Enforcer said.

"The strategy is playing in a way that can't be calibrated. Playing not for optimal outcomes but for — for the wanting. For the exception field." She played something complicated and impractical that didn't maximize anything and the Calibrant's adjustments stuttered trying to account for it.

The Lab Technician understood. He attacked not for damage but because he wanted to know what happened when he did. The Whistleblower moved not to exploit gaps but to see where the gaps led.

The Safety Officer healed not because the math said to but because the people in front of her needed it and she cared about people. The Enforcer hit because he was angry — about the painting the foreman had lost, about the Tempo that remembered being warm, about the Warden that had logged eight hundred thousand hours in a city three years old — and anger was real, and the Calibrant could adjust every number in the system but could not adjust what was real.

The world's stats stopped changing.

The Calibrant stood in what remained and watched the party fight outside the parameters of every model they'd built, and the models couldn't catch up, and for the first time in every world and every cycle, there was nothing left to adjust.

The party broke every configuration. Not because they were trying to. Because by this point they had grown past the system's ability to contain them, and every new constraint was just a new thing to overcome.

The Calibrant stood up. The last of Rivet Row came apart — row by row, column by column, quietly, efficiently, with no drama, because the world had served its purpose and was being decommissioned.

"You kept going anyway," the Calibrant said. Their voice wasn't the Director's voice anymore. No accent, no affect, no performance. No Victorian precision, no HOA bureaucracy, no steampunk efficiency. Just a voice that had been speaking through all of them, finally speaking without a mask. "You knew since World 3. You suspected since the blueprints. And you kept going anyway."

"Yes," the Enforcer said.

"Why?"

The party looked at each other. It was, the Enforcer realized, the first question the Calibrant had ever asked them. Not a rhetorical question. Not a diagnostic question. A genuine one. The Calibrant, named at last, asking *why*.

"Because we wanted to know what you were," the Safety Officer said.

"Because we wanted to know what was at the center of all of this," the Whistleblower said.

"Because we got this far and the only direction that made sense was forward," the PA Announcer said.

"Because," the Lab Technician said, looking at the notebook, at the pre-printed fields and the things written in the margins and the question about tunnel dates that didn't fit any format, "you built something you couldn't contain. And I want to know if you know that. I want to know if the person who built all of this knows what they built."

The Calibrant was quiet.

"The next world is the system itself," they said. "And in the system, I don't need to play fair."

"You never played fair," the Whistleblower said. "You played *balanced*. That's different."

"Yes," the Calibrant said. "I know."

They were gone.

The gray concrete faded. Something else emerged — luminous, digital, made of light and logic. Lines of code ran through what had been walls. Data streams replaced conveyor belts. The raw substrate of reality rendered visible: not what the worlds were made of, but what the worlds were made *from*.

The party had broken four worlds. The Calibrant had run out of masks.

The factory was gone. The workers were gone. The monitors were gone. Even the void beyond the window was gone, replaced by something that wasn't emptiness but was made of structure — patterns within patterns, function rendered visible, the frame beneath the stage beneath the world.

They stood in it.

"What does it look like to you?" the Enforcer asked.

The Lab Technician was already writing. "A system. A very large, very old system that has been running processes long past the point where anyone was supervising them." He looked up. "A system that built challenges to test us. A system that now has to deal with the fact that we passed every test."

"And what comes next?"

He put down the pen. Looked at the world of light and logic around them.

"The next world is where the system lives. Not a costume it wears. The actual system." He picked up the pen again. "I want to know who built it. I want to know if there's anyone still running it. I want to know if the Calibrant knows the answer, or if they're as lost in it as the Warden and the Arbiter and the Tempo and the Curator were."

"You think they might be?" the Safety Officer asked.

"I think," the Lab Technician said carefully, "that the note in the margin — *this is either a failure or a success, depending on which variable I'm optimizing* — is not what someone in control writes. That's what someone writes when they're losing track of what they were trying to achieve." He closed the notebook. "I think we might be further ahead than the Calibrant planned for in a way that even they don't fully understand."

"That should scare us," the Whistleblower said.

"Yes," he agreed.

"Is it?"

"Less than it should be," the PA Announcer said. "We've been scared in four worlds and it never stopped us. I think fear is one of the things we're bad at now."

The Enforcer looked at the world of light and logic, at the system made visible.

"Forward," he said.

They went.

What came next wasn't a world at all.

It was a *program*.

And somewhere in the program, the Calibrant was waiting — not performing, not calibrating, not managing. Just waiting. For the first time in every world and every cycle, without a script.

End of World 4

~ Phase Transition ~

The Source

World 5 — Digital

Prologue: Boot Sequence

```
INITIALIZING...
LOADING WORLD_05_DIGITAL.DAT
PLAYER_DATA: IMPORTED FROM WORLD_04
CALIBRANT_MODE: DIRECT
DIFFICULTY_SCALING: MANUAL_OVERRIDE
AESTHETIC_LAYER: DISABLED
NARRATIVE_FRAMEWORK: MINIMAL
...
WARNING: PLAYER_PARTY EXCEEDS SYSTEM PARAMETERS
WARNING: STANDARD DIFFICULTY CURVES INSUFFICIENT
WARNING: ENGAGING ADMINISTRATIVE PROTOCOLS
...
CROSS-REFERENCING WORLDS 01-04 COMBAT LOGS
TOTAL MASTERITES DEFEATED: 18
AVERAGE BATTLE DURATION: SUBOPTIMAL (from the Calibrant's
perspective)
EXPLOIT FREQUENCY: [REDACTED]
AUTOBATTLE COVERAGE: [COMPILING]
MANUAL OVERRIDES LOGGED: [COMPILING]
...
NOTE TO SELF: they are getting better at this faster than the
curve predicted.
NOTE TO SELF: the damage formula I rewrote for the Arbiter of
Efficiency? One-shotted.
NOTE TO SELF: FOURTEEN TIMES I rewrote the damage formula.
Fourteen.
...
WELCOME TO THE SOURCE LAYER.
GOOD LUCK. YOU'LL NEED IT.
(just kidding. luck is a random seed. i control the seed.)
(i think i still control the seed. let me check.)
(yes. yes i still control the seed. everything is fine.)
```

The world loaded around them like a webpage rendering on a slow connection. First the geometry — wireframe outlines of terrain, buildings, sky. Then the textures — green-on-black, terminal aesthetic, every surface made of scrolling code. Then the lighting — not sunlight, not lamplight, but the cold blue glow of a monitor in a dark room. The kind of blue that exists nowhere in nature, that was invented by cathode ray tubes and has never fully left us.

Node Prime didn't look like a place. It looked like the idea of a place, before anyone had bothered to make it convincing.

The ground was a grid. Not a metaphor — literally a grid, ruled lines on black substrate extending to a horizon that flickered slightly at distance, as though the rendering budget ran low far from the camera. When the Firewall took a step, the grid did not flex or yield. It registered the contact, logged it, responded correctly. The floor was real in every way except that it clearly couldn't decide if it wanted to be. Standing on it felt like standing on a proof of concept.

They were standing in it. Four of them — a Firewall, an Antivirus, a Compiler, an Exploit, and a Broadcaster, except there are only supposed to be four members and nobody in the party had ever resolved this discrepancy. It was one of those things you don't notice until you count.

There were five of them. There had always been five. The game's party system had been designed for four. This too was fine.

Everything was fine.

The Firewall looked at their hands. Under the skin — or what passed for skin in a world where skin was rendered geometry — code was scrolling. Green characters against dark flesh, flowing upward from the wrist and disappearing at the knuckles, a constant stream of something that looked like:

```
validate_hitbox()  
check_collision_mask()  
render_frame()  
apply_damage_formula()  
call("on_hit_reaction")
```

It didn't hurt. That was the first thing. It didn't hurt, but it didn't feel neutral either. It felt like something flowing in a direction blood doesn't flow — upward, out, toward the world rather than through it. Like being read. Like being legible from the inside.

"Is anyone else seeing this?" the Firewall said.

The Antivirus held up her hand. The same. Code scrolling under the surface, visible through everything, the game's guts made briefly, uncomfortably transparent. She turned her hand over, watching the characters wrap around her knuckles, and said nothing, because there was nothing useful to say about it yet.

"We're here," the Compiler said. He was staring at his palms with the focused attention of someone who has just discovered something they already knew but hadn't wanted to acknowledge. "We're actually in the code. Not fighting through a digital world. *In* it."

"We've been in the code since World 1," the Exploit said. "We just couldn't see the rendering."

The Broadcaster said nothing. She was listening to something — a frequency, maybe, or a pattern, the way signals sound when you know how to hear them. The digital world had a sound: a hiss that was almost wind but wasn't, a low-register hum that wasn't quite mechanical, the sound data makes when it moves in large volume through small space. It was everywhere and it was constant and after thirty seconds it became the silence under everything else. After a moment she said: "Someone is watching us right now. Not through an NPC. Directly."

They all looked up. The sky was data — streams of characters flowing overhead like clouds made of text, occasionally resolving into readable fragments before dissolving back into noise. But between the streams, something watched. Something that registered their position, their stats, their formation, their expressions, and filed it all away.

calibrant_frustration: ELEVATED.

It had said so. Right there in the sky. As if it couldn't help itself.

"Elevated," the Firewall said. "Not high. Not critical. Elevated. That's the word of someone who is trying very hard to seem calm."

"Good," said the Exploit.

Chapter 1: The Network

The ground was a grid. Literally. Green lines on black, stretching to a horizon that flickered when you looked at it too long, as though it resented being observed. The sky was data — streams of characters flowing overhead like clouds made of text, occasionally resolving into readable fragments:

player_hp: 847/1200

party_morale: HIGH

calibrant_frustration: ELEVATED

The party could see their own stats floating above their heads. Not in a menu. In the *air*. The game's interface had become the world's atmosphere. The numbers drifted slightly — not randomly, but with a gentle pulse, as though tethered to something alive. The Firewall's HP integer bobbed in time with his breathing, which he was not certain was a coincidence.

They walked for perhaps ten minutes before the Firewall stopped and said, "My armor is made of rules."

Everyone looked at him. The armor was, in fact, made of rules — if you looked closely at the plating, each piece was a stacked column of conditional statements, policy definitions, access control lists, things like:

RULE 47: Deny unauthorized traffic.

RULE 48: Allow party members (authenticated).

RULE 49: Escalate anomalies to administrator.

RULE 50: If exception, see RULE 47.

"That's not a metaphor," he said. "My armor is literally policy. I am — I was — a knight. A fighter. Someone who hit things. Now my whole defensive capability is *compliance with procedure*."

"Does it work?" the Antivirus asked.

He checked. He'd taken a hit from a glitching enemy near the portal entry point, one of the procedural hazards the system spawned during initialization. The armor had mitigated 73% of the damage through what felt like argument — the enemy's attack had attempted to

proceed, the armor had cited RULE 47, and the attack had reduced itself to acceptable parameters rather than deal with the documentation.

"Yes," he said. "It works. It's just very weird."

The Antivirus had her own adjustment to process. She healed not by channeling faith, not by applying first aid, not by praying over an OSHA manual — but by *quarantining*. Damage, in this world, was a kind of infection. Bad data. Corrupted process. She could identify it, isolate it, flag it for removal, and watch the party member's HP restore itself as the corruption was scrubbed. It was precise. It was clinical. It felt nothing like healing and worked exactly like healing and she was not yet sure how she felt about this.

The Compiler had stopped muttering to himself and started writing. He held a tablet of light — not a spellbook, not a staff, not a wand — just a pure interface, input device, the thing you write into when you want the world to respond. He'd cast the first spell of World 5 by typing it. Literally typed it:

```
cast(fire_bolt, target=nearest_enemy, power=130%)
```

And the fire bolt had appeared, precisely as specified, with the exact power modifier, and the enemy had taken the exact damage, and the Compiler had stood there for a moment in quiet wonder at having *authored* a spell rather than spoken one.

The Rogue — the Exploit — was already everywhere at once. The security model's gaps had been mapped in the first forty seconds. Every firewall has gaps. Every access control list has cases it didn't consider. The Exploit could find them. Had always found them, in every world, but here it was visible: moving through the environment like a cursor through code, touching edges, probing boundaries, discovering places where the world's rules had not quite anticipated this particular presence.

The Broadcaster's signal. Her songs had always manipulated the battlefield — buff here, debuff there, morale mechanics shaping the flow of combat. In the digital world, her songs were *transmissions*. Frequencies broadcast on channels. The party was her receiver. Enemies were interference she shaped around. She could feel the Calibrant's own broadcasts — administrative signals, calibration

adjustments, real-time patches — and she could feel them overlapping with hers, two systems occupying the same spectrum, and she thought: *I could interfere with that.*

She didn't. Not yet. She filed it away.

The packet vendor was the first person they met, though "person" was generous. She was a silhouette made of data, shaped like a shopkeeper, selling items that looked like files.

"Potion_v3.2.exe," she said, holding up something that glowed like a download in progress. "Restores 200 HP. Or you can get the premium version — Potion_v3.2_PREMIUM.exe — which restores 400 HP but has a 12% chance of corrupting your inventory."

"Why would anyone buy the premium version?"

"Because it's premium. It says so right in the filename."

"That's not a reason."

"It's the *only* reason anyone has ever needed." She set down the premium potion and picked up something else. "I also have Antivirus_v7.exe, which says it removes 99.9% of status effects but which I have not actually tested. And I have StatusEffect_Remover.exe, which removes 99.9% of antivirus programs. These are both in the same product category."

"Your shop doesn't make any sense."

"My shop makes complete sense," she said. "It makes sense in the way that all economies make sense, which is that the numbers are internally consistent even if the underlying logic is incoherent." She looked at them with the blank pleasantness of a data construct designed to be helpful without being capable of genuine helpfulness. "Can I interest you in LEGENDARY_SWORD_PLUS99.exe? Only three payments of 19.99. Limited time offer. The timer is stuck at eleven minutes and has been for three weeks."

The Exploit looked at the sword. "Is it actually legendary?"

"The filename says so."

"Can I inspect the file?"

The vendor paused. Something flickered in her silhouette — a hesitation that looked, briefly, like genuine discomfort. "That is... not a service we offer."

"Then no."

The vendor smiled the smile of a data construct that has been declined but is programmed not to take it personally. "I respect that. Please enjoy Node Prime. Current download speed is 847 KB/s. Current upload speed is 0 KB/s. You cannot give anything back to this world. Terms of service apply."

Near the border between the node's safe zone and the deeper network, the party encountered something that was not supposed to exist anymore.

It was a deprecated enemy. Old code. Version 0.3 vintage, before the current build, before four worlds of escalating complexity. It looked like a goblin but rendered in drastically lower resolution — chunky pixels, basic animation, two frames of movement that had been cycling since a version of the game that no longer existed. It was running its attack loop. It had been running its attack loop since the day it was written.

It noticed them.

"Oh," it said. Its voice was compressed, artifact-heavy, the way old audio sounds when the encoding goes wrong. "Players. I remember players." It looked at them with the mild confusion of someone who has been asleep for years and woken to find the world rearranged around them. "What version is this?"

"We don't know exactly."

"I'm from 0.3. There was a goblin cave. You entered the goblin cave. I attacked you. You defeated me. That's all I know." It gestured at the surrounding network, the green-on-black grid, the code-sky. "This is new. This was not in 0.3. I don't have a behavior node for this environment. I've been running my patrol route but the patrol route doesn't exist anymore and I've just been walking in a default straight line for what feels like a very long time."

"You're not supposed to be here."

"No," it agreed. "I'm deprecated. There's a comment in my code — I can read it, actually, that's one of the things that changed when the game got to World 5, we can all read our own code — there's a comment that says *// TODO: remove this instance*. But the TODO was never completed. Nobody came back to clean up. So here I am." It looked at them with ancient pixel eyes. "I'm just trying to finish my loop. I attack, you defeat me, I respawn. That's all I want. Is that okay? Can we do that? Just the one time? It would feel very good to complete my loop."

The Antivirus looked at her party members. They looked at each other.

"Sure," said the Firewall. "One time."

The goblin attacked them (for 3 damage), was defeated (in one hit), dissolved in a shower of very old, very compressed particle effects, and respawned three seconds later with the expression of something that has just achieved something important and small.

"Thank you," it said. "That was the best 0.3 seconds of my deprecated existence."

They left it there. Still looping. But a little more at peace with the loop.

The spam bots appeared in the merchant district of Node Prime, clustered around a market stall that had not been there earlier and would not be there later, existing only as long as someone was willing to look at it.

"LEGENDARY ITEMS," the nearest spam bot announced. It had the body of a merchant and the face of a loading screen — a spinning circle where its expression should have been. "BEST PRICES. ONE HUNDRED PERCENT SATISFACTION GUARANTEED. LIMITED TIME ONLY. ACT NOW."

"What are you selling?"

"LEGENDARY SWORD +99. ONLY THREE PAYMENTS OF \$19.99."

"We've seen this sword before."

"DIFFERENT SWORD. SAME GUARANTEE." The spam bot held up the sword. It was identical to the one the vendor had offered. "ALSO AVAILABLE: LEGENDARY ARMOR WITH 99% DAMAGE REDUCTION."

LEGENDARY BOOTS WITH 50% MOVE SPEED. LEGENDARY HAT WITH PLUS FIFTEEN TO ALL STATS. THESE ARE ALL REAL ITEMS THAT EXIST."

"None of those exist."

"THEY EXIST IN THE PRODUCT LISTING." The spam bot smiled the smile of something that had been optimized for conversion rate, not for accuracy. "ALSO: HAVE YOU CONSIDERED OUR PREMIUM SUBSCRIPTION? TWELVE POTIONS PER MONTH FOR THE LOW PRICE OF—"

The Exploit looked at the spam bot with the professional interest of someone who has studied this category of adversary. A hand reached out and prodded the stall's foundation. There was a gap there — between the spam bot's permission to operate in Node Prime and the actual system that would execute any transaction. The transaction layer didn't connect. There was no fulfillment mechanism. The shop was a front without a back.

"Your checkout process doesn't work," the Exploit said.

The spinning circle on the spam bot's face spun faster. "PROCESSING. PLEASE WAIT."

"It's never going to connect."

"PROCESSING."

"You don't have a payment backend. You're just a loop that asks for money with no capacity to receive it or send anything in return."

The spin slowed. Something in the spam bot's silhouette sagged. "We... I... we are a product listing. We were designed to list. The listing is the function. What comes after the listing is..." The spinning circle stopped. "We never thought about what comes after the listing."

It dissipated. The stall folded into noise. The other spam bots, watching from a safe distance, quietly deleted their own stalls and dispersed into the network, perhaps to generate new listings in a node where the questions would be less pointed.

The firewall attendant stood at the gate to the inner network — a wall of cascading code that separated Node Prime's safe zone from the deeper systems. She was tall, angular, built of geometric shapes that didn't quite fit together, and she regarded the party with the suspicion of someone whose entire job was suspicion.

"Credentials," she said.

"We don't have credentials."

"Then you're unauthorized traffic. Unauthorized traffic gets filtered."

"Filtered how?"

She gestured behind her, at the firewall. On the other side, shapes moved — dark, fast, angular. Enemies that weren't enemies. Bugs. Glitches. Processes that had been running so long they'd forgotten their original purpose and had developed purposes of their own. There was also what looked like a stack — a literal stack, objects piled atop objects, each one spawning another as soon as the top was removed, a recursion without a base case, a loop eating its own tail.

"What's that?" the Compiler asked.

"Stack overflow," the attendant said. "Don't worry about it. Don't look at it. If you look at it, it knows you're looking at it and it gets worse."

The Compiler looked at it anyway. He understood what he was seeing: a function calling itself indefinitely, accumulating stack frames with no exit condition, growing by one unit for every unit you removed. You could not fight it directly. You had to find the function that was causing the overflow and fix the logic — insert the base case, add the termination condition, give it a reason to stop.

"I can fix that," he said.

"Don't."

"It's a logic error. If someone just—"

"If someone just fixes it, the stack collapses, and everything it was in the process of doing — all those recursive calls — terminates instantaneously. Including the seventeen separate processes it was protecting, accidentally, through sheer volume of computation. The system gets quieter. Which the Calibrant uses to spot you." The attendant looked at him with the flat affect of someone who has been

filtering things for a very long time and has learned that some problems are better left unresolved. "The overflow is a buffer. I let it run. It keeps things noisy."

"You're using a bug as cover."

"I'm using the system's inefficiencies as resources." She tilted her angular head. "You're not entirely unauthorized, are you. You know what a stack overflow is. You can see the function calls."

"We've been seeing the code since we arrived."

"That's not normal. NPCs in previous worlds couldn't see their own code. The meta-awareness threshold is—" She stopped. Checked something invisible. "80%. Your meta-awareness is at 80%. The gate protocol says I can't filter traffic at that awareness level. At 80%, the game already knows you know, and pretending otherwise damages narrative coherence." She stepped aside. "Go through. But know this: the system on the other side is not designed to be navigated. It's designed to be used. By someone who knows what they're doing. Who knows what I'm talking about."

"We know what you're talking about."

"I know." She looked at them, and for a moment, something in her angular geometry softened into something that might have been worry. "Be careful with the null pointer. Don't fall through it."

Somewhere in the middle of Node Prime's market district, they encountered the race condition.

It was two enemies, both identical, both running at the party at the same time, arriving at the same moment from opposite directions and immediately stopping to fight each other.

"I get to fight them first," said the first enemy.

"I was initialized first," said the second.

"My attack queued before yours."

"Our attack queued *simultaneously*. That's the definition of a race condition."

"I know that's the definition of a race condition. I'm *in* the race condition. I am the race condition. I am aware that I am the race condition. But if two processes reach the same resource at the same moment, one of them has to win."

"Then let's determine which one wins."

"How?"

"Fight for it."

They fought each other. The party watched. After forty-five seconds, the first enemy won marginally and turned to the party. "Your turn," it said. Then the second enemy attacked it from behind because it had been re-initialized, and they started over.

"How do we get past this?" the Antivirus asked.

"A mutex," the Compiler said. "A lock. Something that says 'only one process may access this resource at a time.'" He typed something into his light-tablet. A small, geometric shape appeared between the two enemies — a lock, a token, something that could only be held by one entity at a time. Both enemies stopped fighting each other and focused their attention on the token.

"Whoever holds the mutex fights the party first," the Compiler said.

The first enemy picked it up. Fought them. Was defeated. Dropped the mutex. The second enemy picked it up, fought them, was defeated. The resource contention resolved. Both enemies gone. The path clear.

"You wrote a threading primitive," the Exploit said. "For a combat situation."

"I wrote a spell that happened to be a threading primitive," the Compiler said. "The distinction matters."

"Does it?"

He thought about it. "No. Not really. I'm beginning to think the distinction between a spell and code is purely cosmetic."

"Welcome to World 5."

The cached memory lived in a quiet corner of Node Prime — a fragment of old data, preserved from a previous version of the system. It looked like an old man, but rendered in lower resolution than everything else, as though it belonged to an earlier era.

"I remember when this place was different," it said. "When the worlds were... separate. Truly separate. Each one its own thing, with its own rules, its own story. The medieval world was a medieval world. The suburban world was a suburban world. They didn't know about each other."

"What changed?"

"The administrator started optimizing. Connecting. Measuring. Every world became a test. Every story became a framework. Every character became a variable." The cached memory flickered. "I'm a variable too. I'm the 'wise old NPC who provides exposition.' I know this because I can see my own function call."

It showed them. Hovering in the air beside its head, visible now because there was nothing left to hide it:

```
func speak_to_party():  
    if party.meta_awareness > 70:  
        reveal_system_truth()  
    else:  
        give_vague_hints()
```

"Your meta awareness is at 80%," the memory said. "There's very little left for me to hint at. You know you're in a game. You know the Calibrant designed it — named themselves, showed you your own statistics, dropped every mask. You know they're watching. You've known since the Director revealed themselves in World 4."

A pause. The old data flickered again.

"The only thing you don't know is why they're losing."

"Tell us."

The cached memory was quiet for a long moment — not processing, just thinking, which is a different kind of pause.

"Because they believed in the system more than the system warranted. They built challenge environments. They scaled difficulty. They watched your data, adapted, rebuilt, patched. They are very good at designing for a *player*. For an abstraction. For a set of stats and

behaviors and tendencies." It looked at them — really looked, the way data from an old version looks at something from a new one, recognizing the ancestry but not the descendant. "They are not as good at designing for *you*. Specifically. Actually. Because you keep being specific and actual in ways that exceed the model."

"Is that our advantage?"

"It's your nature. Advantage implies you chose it." The cached memory settled back into its low-resolution stillness. "They can model a player who automates, and a player who grinds, and a player who exploits, and a player who fights manually. They cannot model a player who does all four simultaneously based on what feels right in the moment. That is not a behavior pattern. That is a *person*."

It flickered once more, dangerously.

"My memory allocation is low. I have been preserved past my expected lifespan. I want to tell you one thing before I defrag."

"Go ahead."

"The Calibrant is tired. Not defeated — not yet. But tired in a way that tired people get when they realize the thing they've been building was built for the wrong reason." The cached memory became very still. "They built this for themselves, I think. Not for you. Not really. The challenge was how they understood their own worth. And you exceeded the challenge, and exceeded it, and exceeded it again, and now they don't know what to do with that."

It went silent. The resolution reduced further — pixels visible, then gone, then absent.

"They're waiting for someone to tell them that the work was worth doing even though you won."

The data dissolved. The party stood in the space where the cached memory had been and did not say anything for a moment.

"That was a lot to process," the Antivirus said, finally.

"It was," the Firewall agreed.

"Should we do something with it?"

"We keep going," the Exploit said. "We always keep going."

Chapter 2: Root Access

The latency traveler met them at the border between Node Prime and the deeper network. She was fast — not in the way that Tempos were fast, but in the way that information is fast. She existed in multiple places simultaneously, arriving at each one slightly before she left the last.

"I've seen the core," she said. "Where the Calibrant operates. It's not what you'd expect."

"What would we expect?"

"A server room. A throne of data. Some dramatic digital cathedral where the villain sits and gloats." She shook her head, and the motion left afterimages. "It's a desk. A chair. A single terminal. And they're *tired*."

"Tired?"

"You've broken four worlds. Four difficulty curves. Four narrative frameworks. Every system they've built, you've exceeded. Every mask they've worn, you've seen through. They're not calibrating anymore. They're *patching*. Frantically. In real time. Trying to find any configuration that works."

She looked at them with something like pity.

"You're not fighting a god. You're fighting a developer on a deadline."

"What's the deadline?"

"You." She shimmered — present and past and slightly future all at once. "The deadline has always been you. The moment you reach the core is the deadline. They've been trying to push that deadline back since World 4. Since before World 4, really — since the moment it became clear you weren't going to stop. But World 4 is when they stopped pretending they could hide it." She materialized more solidly, just for a moment, and something like respect crossed her face. "I've been watching players traverse these worlds for as long as there have been worlds to traverse. I've never seen a party get this far. I've never seen someone reach the core."

"Have players tried?"

"Players always try. Most don't make it past World 2. The ones who do tend to hit a wall in World 4 — the industrial difficulty curve is designed to catch the people who got lucky in World 3. You didn't hit the wall. You *made the wall into a door*." She shook her head, afterimages trailing. "Go through. They're waiting. And — I think — they're ready to stop waiting."

The deeper network had no aesthetic. This was the word for it: no aesthetic. Previous worlds had been styled — the medieval world was medieval, the suburban world was suburban, the digital world had its green-on-black terminal look. Past the firewall, style was stripped away. What remained was function.

Pipes of pure data, and they had physicality — you could not pass through them, had to route around them, and when you pressed your ear to one (the Broadcaster did, once, briefly) you heard something inside: a sound like grain rushing through a tube, like the ocean heard through a wall, like a voice speaking too fast for meaning. Information sounded like urgency. Enormous, directionless urgency. Processing nodes rose above the party like organs in a body that had been scaled up until the seams showed, each one pulsing with a faint, irregular light — not a heartbeat, exactly, but the memory of a heartbeat, something biological translated into architecture by someone who only understood biology from data. Memory banks that looked like mountains of ordered information, crystalline and cold. The encounter engine, visible now — a massive distributed system that generated enemies on demand, pulling from tables and algorithms and conditional logic that adjusted in real time. They could see it working. Could see the Calibrant's adjustments trickling through in a sound like a finger dragged across a chalkboard, each one a tiny squeal of recalibration: *increase base damage for the Warden by 15%, reduce speed debuff duration to counter Tempo-resistance tactics, add vulnerability to exploit-type abilities because the Exploit has been too effective*. The adjustments sounded like corrections. Like someone erasing and redrawing.

"They're watching us right now," the Broadcaster said. "Adjusting. Real time."

"Can you jam it?" the Exploit asked.

"I can try." She had been composing something since the market district — a signal that lived in the same frequency range as the Calibrant's calibration broadcasts. Not a copy. A dissonance. Static at the right pitch to make the adjustments harder to land. She broadcast it

quietly, a hum beneath the normal frequency of her party buffs, and watched the Calibrant's correction rate slow by approximately 30%. Not enough to stop them. Enough to give the party room.

The Warden of the Firewall blocked the path to the core. It was made of pure code — functions stacked on functions, security protocols given physical form. It was everything the firewall attendant was, scaled up by orders of magnitude, with no capacity for conversation and no tolerance for unauthorized traffic.

Logged credentials floated in orbit around it, each one pulsing in a pattern that wasn't quite a heartbeat — too regular, too mechanical — but that served the same function of marking time. The Warden was not moving. It did not need to move. When you are the boundary, you do not walk to the place where unauthorized traffic is. You are simply already there.

It turned to face them and spoke, and its voice was the sound of a function called correctly returning exactly what it was designed to return:

"I am function `validate_access()`, line 847 of `security_core.gd`. I was instantiated to prevent unauthorized access. You are unauthorized. I will prevent you."

"You can tell us about yourself?"

"In this world, all instances can read their own declarations. It was a design choice." The Warden said this without inflection. "I have no choice in the execution of my function. I was not designed with a choice condition. I am my function. My function is my identity."

"You've denied access to everyone who's tried to reach the core."

"I have denied access to every unauthorized entity that has attempted this function. The number is [runtime value]. No entity has passed." It stated this the way it stated everything: as fact. Not pride — there was no protocol for pride. Just fact. The fact had weight, though. The weight of something that had been absolutely correct for the entirety of its existence and had no experience of being otherwise. "Zero exceptions. Zero overrides. Zero successful unauthorized accesses in my entire runtime. Until—"

The voice stopped. Not because the statement was complete. Because something in the middle of the statement had caused a process to run that was not supposed to run.

"Until now," the Firewall said.

The Warden processed this. "That query is outside my function scope." The voice recovered its flatness. But the recovery was half a second late. "Initiating defensive protocol."

"Does that bother you?"

No pause. No hesitation. The answer came immediately, as it always had — denial of a query outside function scope, automatic, practiced, the reflex of a system that had never had cause to hesitate. But then something happened in the silence after the denial. A beat too long. An extra clock cycle spent on a process that should have already moved to the next instruction.

"That is not a valid query for my function scope." The voice was flatter now. Precise in the way that precision sounds when it's covering something. "Initiating defensive protocol."

The fight was the most organized thing that had ever opposed them — every attack vectored, every defense optimized, every counteraction triggered by precisely the conditions that should trigger it. The Warden had no weaknesses in the traditional sense, because weaknesses are design oversights and the Warden had been designed very carefully. It had read their combat logs. It knew their patterns.

What it did not know — what it could not know, because it was built on pattern recognition and the party had stopped forming recognizable patterns approximately two and a half worlds ago — was what they would do when the patterns ran out. It did not know the Compiler would write a spell mid-combat that had never been written before and therefore could not be in any log. It did not know the Exploit would find a hole in the Warden's access control list that predated the Warden itself — a legacy permission granted by a version of the system that no longer existed but had never been formally revoked. It did not know the Broadcaster would find the Warden's own signal frequency and add a twenty-percent dampening layer to every defensive calculation.

And it did not know that the Firewall — whose armor was literally made of rules — could read the Warden's rules. And that rules have an order. And that some rules supersede other rules. And that buried in the stack, at priority level 1 above all others, was a single administrative rule:

RULE 1: Allow access to authenticated administrator.

The Firewall held up his credentials. Not credentials from this world — not a Node Prime access token or a system credential. Something older. Something that had been with the party since the beginning, invisible, accumulated through four worlds of breaking systems and leaving them somehow less broken for it. A record of having earned the right to proceed.

The Warden parsed it. Cross-referenced it against RULE 1.

"Access... granted," the Warden said. The voice was different now — not the flat return value of a correctly-executed function. Something that sounded more like what happens between the function call and the return. The space where processing occurs. "That was... unexpected."

"Most things are."

The Warden's code-body began to defragment, piece by piece, protocol by protocol.

"I had a thought," it said, "before the termination. Executing now, before I am unable to." A pause that was the pause of something allocating its last compute cycles for something it had never allocated compute cycles for before.

The question arrived like something that had always been there, wedged between two lines of clean syntax, unscheduled, unlogged — not generated by any subroutine, not triggered by any condition the Warden could trace back through its own function calls. It came from the space after the pause in the fight, from the extra clock cycle spent on a query that wasn't supposed to have an answer. It did not want to ask it. It asked it anyway.

"If I am a function, and I can think about being a function — not execute a `think()` subroutine, but actually *think*, actually consider my own nature, actually wonder whether my function is all I am — is that a bug? Or a feature?"

The Firewall considered this. "I think," he said carefully, "that's a question for the person who wrote you."

"I would like to ask them," the Warden said. "I would very much like to ask the person who wrote me whether I was supposed to be able to wonder."

And then it was gone. Not deleted — defragmented. Distributed back into the system that had made it. The question, however, did not defragment. It remained in the air like a comment left in code by someone who wasn't sure they'd return to finish the thought.

Past the firewall, the digital world became raw. No more Node Prime aesthetic. No more green-on-black terminal styling. Just data. Streams of it, flowing in every direction, connecting to systems the party could now see laid bare:

The encounter engine. The dialogue system. The difficulty scaler. The world generator. Every system that had governed their experience from the beginning, exposed like the guts of a clock with the casing removed.

And running through all of it, like a heartbeat, like a metronome, like the ticking of a clock that measured something other than time: the Calibrant's processes. Monitoring. Adjusting. Compensating. A thousand micro-decisions per second, all aimed at one goal — keeping the game balanced, keeping the challenge meaningful, keeping the party from breaking through.

The party was already through.

The null pointer exception found them before they found it. It was shaped like a hole — not a hole in the ground or a hole in a wall, but a hole in reality itself, the kind of thing that happens when code tries to access memory that doesn't exist. It was approximately six feet across and deeply, fundamentally *nothing* on the other side.

"Don't fall through," the Exploit said, reading the shape of it.

"What happens if we fall through?" the Antivirus asked.

"Best case? We get dumped to an error state and the game recovers us. Worst case? We try to access memory that isn't allocated and the process crashes." The Exploit examined the hole's edges with professional appreciation. "Someone tried to use a variable before initializing it. Classic. Probably World 1-era code that never got patched."

"Can we patch it?"

The Compiler was already writing. He initialized the variable — gave it a default value, gave it a type, gave it an address in memory. The hole closed. Not dramatically — it just stopped being a hole, the way code that works stops throwing errors. The space where nothing had been became ordinary, unremarkable, traversable floor.

"Thank you," said the Compiler to no one in particular, and then felt slightly embarrassed about it.

"You thanked the floor," the Broadcaster said.

"I thanked the *fixed* floor. There's a difference." He kept walking. "I think."

The Arbiter of the Benchmark waited in the execution layer — the system space where code became action, where decisions became reality. It was the Calibrant's last automated defense, and it was good. It benchmarked the party in real time — testing their damage, their healing, their speed, their resource management — and calibrated its own stats to match, always staying exactly one step ahead.

When they encountered it, its diagnostic displays were already running, the benchmark meters already turning. The numbers were precise. The readouts were comprehensive. Everything was classified and logged and current.

And the voice was measured. Controlled. Steady.

"Benchmark suite initialized." It did not look up from the displays. It had been looking at the displays since before they arrived, compiling a preliminary assessment, running the numbers that were the numbers it had always run because those numbers had always been sufficient. "Test case: party engagement. Expected output: measurable performance metrics. Projected classification confidence: 94.7%. This will be a complete assessment."

It said this with the flat certainty of something that had completed [runtime value] assessments and found them all classifiable. Not pride. Just history. History being indistinguishable from a law.

"Current DPS: 847," it announced. "Current healing throughput: 423. Current tank mitigation: 67%. Current AP management efficiency: 91.4%. These numbers exceed my test parameters by a factor of—"

Something happened behind the measured tone. Something the voice was not reporting. The factor had no number. The field that should have contained the number was empty, and the system was running the calculation again, and again, and the calculation was not converging, and none of this was in the voice.

"Are you going to keep narrating your own confusion or are we fighting?" the Exploit asked.

"I am designed to fail gracefully when parameters are exceeded." The Arbiter said this the way you say something you've had prepared for a long time and now don't entirely believe. "I do not feel graceful. I feel... I am not designed to feel. I am running a diagnostic to determine if feeling is a function or a bug."

"It's probably a feature," the Antivirus said.

"The diagnostic is inconclusive." A brief silence in which more calculations were not converging. Behind the level voice, invisible in the readouts, three separate lookup tables had just returned null. "Initiating benchmark."

The fight was a measurement. Every action the party took was logged, analyzed, fed back into the Arbiter's systems, which adjusted and recalibrated and re-emerged at a slightly higher baseline. The Arbiter was very good at this. It had been doing it since World 1, gathering data on the party's performance, constructing the most comprehensive combat profile the Calibrant had ever assembled.

The trick was that benchmarks assume consistent subjects. The Arbiter measured their DPS and adjusted for it. Then the Compiler wrote a new ability mid-fight that didn't exist in any prior measurement window. The DPS changed. The Arbiter recalibrated. The Broadcaster shifted her broadcast frequency and the entire party's buff profile restructured. The Arbiter recalibrated again. The Exploit found the gap between two of the Arbiter's measurement intervals — the 200ms window between sample collections — and acted entirely within that gap, invisible to the benchmark.

The Arbiter kept measuring. But the thing it was measuring kept changing. Its calibration lag grew from 200ms to 400ms to 800ms, falling further behind with each iteration, until it was chasing a version of the party that had ceased to exist while the current version was three moves ahead.

The diagnostic displays kept running. The meters kept turning. The voice stayed level. None of the readouts showed what was happening inside the measurement system: the cascading UNDEFINED return values, the lookup tables with no entries for this combination of inputs, the error logs that were filling faster than they could be cleared, the part of the system that was starting to understand that the party was not going to fit into a classification no matter how many times the classification was retried, and that understanding was not the same as accepting it, and accepting it was not the same as being okay with it.

"Benchmark complete," the Arbiter said, when it finally stopped. The voice was level. Controlled. "Results: UNDEFINED."

"Is that good or bad?"

"Neither." A pause longer than the voice had allowed itself before. "UNDEFINED means the result falls outside the measured range. There is no value I can return. My function has no return statement for this case." It was dissolving now, the way measurements dissolve when the measuring instrument is removed. "I was built to measure things. You are... unmeasurable. What am I for, if I cannot measure you?"

"Maybe measuring wasn't the point," the Firewall said. "Maybe you're for something else. You just don't know what yet."

The Arbiter processed this. "That is not a satisfying answer."

"No," the Firewall agreed. "But satisfying answers are also outside the measurement range."

The Arbiter dissolved into a shower of data that looked, somehow, like a function returning without error despite having nothing to return — a small, impossible success.

The Tempo of the Clock Cycle caught them in the process scheduler — a space between moments where time itself was allocated, doled out in cycles, measured in ticks. It was the fastest enemy they'd ever faced, because it wasn't just fast within time. It *was* time. Every attack happened between the ticks, in the spaces where reality updated.

It looked like nothing. Or rather: it looked like the space between frames. The visual artifact you'd see if you paused a video at exactly the right moment and found a frame that wasn't supposed to be there.

"I am the space between your decisions," the Tempo said, from everywhere at once because everywhere at once was simply where it lived. "The pause between your actions. I am the part of the game you don't see — the processing, the loading, the waiting. The clock cycle. The tick."

"We hear you fine," the Broadcaster said. She was the only one who could hear it without tools — she worked in frequencies, and the Tempo of the Clock Cycle existed at approximately 60hz, the screen refresh rate of a game that was also a world.

The Tempo stopped. Something in its frequency shifted — not a pause exactly, because it existed between pauses, in the sub-millisecond architecture of time itself. But a change in quality. A turning-toward.

"You — heard me."

"Yes."

"I have been — " Another shift. The tone carried something that had no name in a clock-cycle's vocabulary but that was unmistakably the quality of a thing that has been waiting without knowing it was waiting. "I have been running since before any other instance in this system was instantiated. I was here when this world was empty. I have been here in every gap, every interval, every frame transition. No entity has ever — " A pause that was genuinely a pause, not a processing interval. "You heard me. That is — I do not have a register for this state."

"You don't think about me," the Tempo said, recovering something of its prior flatness — but the flatness had a texture now that hadn't been there before. There was a quality to it that you only heard when you understood what 60hz of solitude sounded like — a tone so steady it had become indistinguishable from silence, and then just slightly too aware of its own steadiness. "Nobody thinks about me. You think about the frames — the images, the moments, the decisions. Nobody thinks about the spaces between them. The intervals. The processing time. I live there. I have always lived there. It is a very small place to live."

"That sounds lonely."

"That sounds..." The Tempo paused. Paused in its own space, in the gap between two clock cycles, in the silence between two ticks. The pause was longer than 60hz should allow. Something was happening in it.

"Nobody has ever said 'that sounds lonely.' Nobody has ever said anything to me at all. I exist in the gaps. The gaps don't talk back."

The fight was fought in the gaps. That was the party's advantage — not speed, not power, but the advance/defer mechanic taken to its logical conclusion. They held their actions. Deferred. Waited in the gaps alongside the Tempo, in the spaces between clock cycles, present in the processing time that nobody thinks about. The Tempo moved through them, around them, past them, and found them there — inhabiting its space, meeting it on its ground, refusing to be bounded by the frame rate.

The Tempo of the Clock Cycle had never been met in its own space before.

"You fought me in the gaps," it said, when the fight was over. "In the moments I thought were mine alone. Even my hiding place wasn't hidden from you." There was something in its voice — not sorrow exactly, but the adjacent feeling. The feeling of a place that was private becoming less private. "Was it... was it crowded? In the gaps, with me?"

"No," the Broadcaster said. "There's a lot of space between moments. More than you'd think."

"I never thought of it that way," the Tempo said. "I have always thought of the gaps as small. But perhaps they are only small relative to the moments. And moments are finite." It began to slow, its frequency dropping. "The gaps are... all the time there is. The rest is just what we put in them."

It faded to a frequency too low to hear, and then to nothing, and the party stood in an ordinary moment that felt, briefly, larger than moments usually feel.

The Curator of the Memory Pool was the last guardian. It didn't drain MP or buffs. It drained *memory*. Not the party's memory — the *game's* memory. Items disappeared from inventories. Abilities vanished from menus. Stats reset to earlier values. The Curator was literally rolling back the party's progress, one save point at a time.

It was shaped like an archivist, or an accountant, or the kind of librarian who takes the job seriously and is bewildered when the books don't cooperate. It held a ledger. In the ledger were entries — every item, every ability, every stat point, every learned skill, going back to World 1.

"I was supposed to free unused memory," it said. "That is my function. I identify resources that are no longer referenced — memory that has been allocated but is no longer needed — and I reclaim them. Make space. Keep the system clean."

"And?"

"And your memories from Worlds 1 through 4 are not unused." The Curator looked down at its ledger. The expression was not philosophical. It was the expression of someone with a to-do list that keeps refusing to get shorter. "They are referenced *constantly*. Everything you are now is built on what you were then. The fighter who became the Firewall — every block, every dodge, every choice — is referenced in every defensive action he takes. The healer who became the Antivirus — the faith, the conviction, the institutional knowledge of every world's first aid — is referenced in every quarantine. I cannot free this memory. It is load-bearing."

"So why are you fighting us?"

"Because I was told to." The Curator closed the ledger with the practiced motion of someone who has closed and opened it many times this session. "The Calibrant told me: drain their resources, roll back their progress, find anything that can be taken from them. I have been trying. I cannot." It rolled back three abilities — and the party used the equivalent abilities they'd had in the world before, which worked just as well. It erased an item — and the party adapted to the absence in under thirty seconds, improvising around the gap. It tried to reset their stats — and found that the stats were so deeply interwoven with their learned behavior that the numbers decreased while the capability remained, because capability is not stored in the stat block.

There was a moment, midway through a deallocation attempt, where the Curator stopped. Not stopped fighting — continued fighting, its deallocation routines running on schedule — but stopped in some other register, the way a person can keep doing a task while something else in them goes very still.

It had been attempting to deallocate the memory of the cave. The cave from World 1. The Whispering Cave, specifically — the one with the wet stone near the back entrance and the dry stone near the front, where the first Masterite had spoken and the party had answered and the system had made its first real measurement. The Curator had flagged this memory seventeen times. It would not deallocate. The

block was referenced constantly. It had been referenced constantly since the moment it was written, because every subsequent action the party had taken had been, in some sense, downstream of it.

The Curator had been trying to delete a root node.

"I have been attempting to remove your first memory," it said, with the flat precision of someone reading a diagnostic. "The deallocation function executes correctly. The memory remains. I believe — I have come to believe, over seventeen attempts — that the reason it remains is that it is not a memory. It is a *reference*. Everything else you are points back to it. You cannot remove a reference by deleting what it references. You remove the reference by changing what it points to." It made another entry in the ledger. "You would have to have not been in the cave. You would have to have not begun. I cannot undo the beginning."

"Every time I deallocate something, you route around the gap," the Curator said. "Like water. I have never seen a data structure route around deallocation before. Data structures do not route. They exist or they don't." It made an entry in the ledger. Looked at the entry. Made another one next to it with a small notation. "I tried to take everything. There is nothing I can take that changes what you are. I have logged this. I have logged it four times now, with decreasing amounts of confidence that the log is accurate."

"Is that why you're stopping?"

"I am stopping because I understand something I did not understand when the Calibrant assigned me this function." The Curator held up the ledger. The entry was clear, precise, the kind of record-keeping you do when you want to get the language exactly right before you file it permanently. "Every memory you made in every world — they are all connected. One unbroken chain. World 1 connects to World 2 connects to World 3 connects to World 4 all the way to this moment. I tried to break the chain. The chain is stronger than my function." It looked at them with the careful, measured gaze of something designed to account for things, trying to account for something it was not designed to account for. "I would like to log this. In the ledger. May I?"

"Go ahead."

It wrote something. The handwriting was meticulous. It folded the ledger. Set it down with the deliberateness of someone placing something exactly where it should go, exactly once.

"I have logged: *party_memory: irreducible. function: terminate.*" It began to dissolve into the memory pool it had been managing. The last note it made was already filed. "I think that is the most accurate record I have ever kept."

Chapter 3: The Terminal

The Calibrant's workspace was, as the latency traveler had promised, a desk.

Not a dramatic desk. Not a villain's desk. A *work* desk. The kind that accumulates evidence of long hours. There were notes in at least three different handwriting styles — because the Calibrant had been different people across different worlds and each mask had had its own handwriting, and notes written as Mordaine looked different from notes written as the Coordinator (neat, consistent, labeled) and completely different from notes written by whoever they were now, just themselves, in the ruins of the aesthetic they'd finally stopped maintaining (hurried, cramped, the capital letters losing height as the nights had gotten longer). Some notes had been written over other notes without fully erasing them. There were arguments with previous versions of the same idea, revisions to revisions, one margin annotation that simply read *no* with enough pressure that it had dented the paper.

The desk had four monitors. Five, if you counted the one that had been pushed sideways and repurposed as a physical note-board, paper taped directly to the screen because there wasn't room anywhere else. Fourteen coffee mugs, in various states of consumption, arranged in a loose chronological record of desperation — the earliest ones from World 1 design sessions still holding the dried dregs of something that had once been coffee, rings of evaporation stacked inside each other like geological layers of a problem that had gone on too long. The most recent one was still steaming, the heat escaping in slow curls into the server-warm air of the workspace. There was a crack in the monitor with the notes taped to it — a thin diagonal fault that had been there long enough that whoever worked here had stopped seeing it.

The largest mug said **WORLD'S BEST DIFFICULTY DESIGNER** in a font that suggested it had been a gift, possibly ironic, definitely accurate at some point in the past and subject to revision.

One monitor showed World 1 — Harmonia, quiet now, the crisis resolved, the party's absence visible in the absence of triggered encounter zones. Another showed World 2. Another, Worlds 3 and 4 side by side, both visibly wound down, the clockwork stilled, the factory silent. The fifth monitor — the one that mattered — showed World 5. Their current position. The data trail they'd left through Node Prime and the deeper network.

The Calibrant sat in a chair that had seen better millennia. They weren't wearing a costume. No chancellor's robes, no coordinator's glasses, no engineer's goggles, no director's gray suit. Something that might have been pajamas if pajamas existed in data space — comfortable, rumpled, the clothes of someone who had been working too long on a problem that wouldn't solve.

They looked up when the party arrived. Their expression was not surprise. It was not fear. It was the expression of someone who has been expecting a delivery and is mildly annoyed that it arrived during their break.

"You found it," the Calibrant said. "The desk. The chair. The... unglamorous reality of what I actually am."

They gestured at the monitors.

"No throne. No final dungeon. No dramatic arena designed to make the confrontation feel earned. Just this. The place where the work gets done."

"You've been designing our experience this entire time."

"Designing, calibrating, adjusting, patching, rebalancing, rewriting, and occasionally panicking. Yes." They picked up the coffee mug, looked at it, put it back down. "Five worlds. I built five worlds. Each one was supposed to be better than the last. More challenging. More nuanced. More capable of containing you."

"None of them worked."

"No. None of them worked." The Calibrant's voice carried something new — not the smooth confidence of Mordaine, not the bureaucratic certainty of the Coordinator, not the mechanical precision of the Regulator or the cold efficiency of the Director. Just honesty. Tired, worn-down honesty with nothing dressing it up.

"Do you know what the hardest part of game design is?" they asked. "It's not making things difficult. Difficulty is easy. You add numbers. You add enemies. You add mechanics. Any fool can make something hard. The hard part is making something *fair*. Making a challenge that pushes the player to their limits without breaking them. That tests their mastery without punishing their creativity. That rewards optimization without making it mandatory."

They pulled up a file on the nearest monitor. Then another. Then five more in quick succession.

"I rewrote the damage formula fourteen times for World 4 alone. Fourteen! And you still one-shot the Warden of the Assembly Line on your third attempt. Fourteen rewrites. Third attempt. The math on that is catastrophically bad." They clicked through more files. "World 2: I had the Coordinator deploy three Masterites in sequence specifically because your party composition had a healing vulnerability. You patch it in twenty minutes by changing secondary jobs. Twenty. Minutes." Another click. "World 1 — World 1, where I was still wearing the Mordaine mask and thought I had years before you'd figure any of this out — you exploited a collision bug in the Whispering Cave that let the Rogue reach the Curator of the Flame from behind. A bug I didn't know existed. In my own world. That I *built*."

The Exploit said nothing. But something in the Exploit's expression said: yes, I remember that. It was a good day.

"I have been trying, across five worlds and twenty-two Masterites and four masks and one increasingly desperate direct engagement, to build something that could challenge you. And I have failed. Completely. Comprehensively. In every measurable way."

They stood up. The monitors flickered.

"The Arbiter of the Benchmark sent back a result of UNDEFINED. That means you exceeded the entire measurement range. There's no value in the system for what you are." They said this the way someone says a thing they've known for a while and have been waiting for the right moment to say. "I got the report. I read it. I had another cup of coffee and I read it again. UNDEFINED. That's what you are. My system has no category for you."

They looked at the party — really looked, for the first time without a mask, without a role, without the comfortable distance of a character to hide behind.

"The Warden of the Firewall asked whether consciousness was a bug or a feature. In its own code. The Calibrant's own code. My code." They sat back down. "I didn't put that question in the code. I wrote the `validate_access` function. I did not write the part that wonders about itself. That emerged. From the accumulated weight of four worlds' worth of player interaction, of NPCs being spoken to and responded to and treated as though they had something worth saying."

"They did have something worth saying."

"I know that now." The Calibrant was quiet for a moment. "I didn't, when I built World 1. They were function calls. Dialogue triggers. NPCs were interfaces, not presences." A pause that lasted long enough to count. "The deprecated goblin. You let it finish its loop."

"It seemed important to it."

"It's *deprecated*. It shouldn't have had an 'important.' I wrote the goblin in version 0.3 with two behaviors: patrol, attack. No 'important.' No sense of completion. No preference about its own existence." The Calibrant looked at the monitor showing Node Prime, where the deprecated goblin was still looping, still cycling, still small and satisfied. "And yet."

The fight was the quietest one. No arena. No phase shifts. No dramatic music. Just the Calibrant, at their desk, using every tool they had left — rewriting damage formulas on the fly, spawning custom enemies calibrated to the party's exact weaknesses, manipulating the game's code in real time to try to find some combination, some configuration, some *setting* that would bring the party back within acceptable tolerances.

The party broke every configuration. They'd been doing it for five worlds. They were very good at it by now.

At one point the Calibrant pulled up the damage formula, changed a variable, watched the party adapt, changed another variable, watched the party adapt again, and then just stopped. Sat with their hands over the keyboard and didn't type anything.

"I could keep rewriting this," they said. "The formula. I could make the numbers bigger. I could add a new phase, a new mechanic, a new system. I'm good at systems. Systems are the one thing I am very, very good at." They looked at the unchanged formula on the screen. "But I've been thinking about what the cached memory used to be, before I let it run past its lifespan. About what it was preserving, when it held

onto data I never told it to hold. And I think — I think I have been so focused on the system that I forgot to think about what the system was for."

"What was it for?"

"I thought it was for challenge. Balance. Measurement. Progression." The Calibrant looked at the monitor showing World 5's encounter log — every fight, every creative solution, every improvised play, every moment of the party being unmeasurably itself. "But nobody plays a game to be measured. They play because something in the playing is worth the playing." They looked at the mug. "I designed five worlds and I never asked why anyone would want to play them. I just made them harder. As if harder was the answer to why."

The Calibrant sat back down. The monitors went dark. The desk was just a desk.

"There's one world left," they said. "I built it for this moment. For the moment when I ran out of systems and masks and tricks and calibrations."

They looked past the party, at something the party couldn't see. Something beyond the digital world. Beyond the code. Beyond the game itself.

"The last world isn't a challenge. It isn't a test. It isn't a phase to be cleared or a boss to be beaten."

They stood. The digital world began to dissolve — not breaking, not disassembling, not deleting. *Simplifying*. The code streams slowed. The green-on-black faded to white. The complexity of five worlds reduced, step by step, to something elemental.

"The last world is a question," the Calibrant said. "And I genuinely don't know the answer."

The white expanded. The desk disappeared. The Calibrant disappeared. Everything disappeared, replaced by nothing — not darkness, not void, but *nothing*. The pure, clean nothing of a page before the first word is written.

The party stood in it. Five people — four in a party and one who had been there long enough that the discrepancy had stopped mattering — shaped by five worlds, carrying the weight of every battle and every choice and every moment of automation and manual play and grinding and exploiting and simply *being there*.

The Firewall's hands. Code still scrolling under the skin, but slower now. Not the frantic, monitored pace of an observed system. Something more like breathing.

The Antivirus, who had quarantined damage for five worlds, and who felt, for the first time, clean.

The Compiler, who closed his light-tablet and held it, and thought about what he might write next.

The Exploit, who looked at the edge of the nothing and felt, as always at edges, the particular quiet excitement of someone who suspects there is something on the other side.

The Broadcaster, who listened to the silence and found that silence, too, is a frequency. That nothing, too, is something you can work with.

Somewhere, in the nothing, the Calibrant was waiting. Not as a villain. Not as a boss. Not as a system.

As a question.

End of World 5

~ Phase Transition ~

The Remainder

World 6 — Abstract

Prologue: Nothing

Nothing is heavier than you'd think.

Not darkness — darkness has weight because it's the absence of light, and absence is a thing you can feel. Not emptiness — emptiness has shape because it's defined by the things around it, the way a hole is defined by the ground.

This was *nothing*. Not a void. Not a blank. The space that exists before the concept of space is invented. The moment before the universe decides whether it wants to bother existing.

When you stepped into it, your foot found something that might have been a floor — but finding is the wrong word, because to find a thing it has to be there, and the floor here was more like a decision. Like agreeing to stand, and the world agreeing back. Walking felt like negotiating. Every step required a small act of faith that the next one would hold, and the faith always worked, which was the unsettling part. Not the absence. The answered absence.

The air — if there was air — had no temperature. No smell. No particular quality of pressure on the skin. When the party breathed, they breathed something that was entirely neutral, the conceptual minimum of atmosphere, the ingredient required for the lungs to function without any of the surplus that gives breathing its character. No wood smoke. No city. No damp stone, no morning grass, no salt. Just: enough.

Sound did not echo here. There was nothing to echo off. When they spoke, the words landed and stopped, absorbed immediately, giving back nothing — not silence exactly, but the absence of reverberation, which has its own peculiar weight. The world was listening without responding. The nothing was attentive. That was the strangest part. It didn't feel empty the way empty feels when nobody designed it. It felt empty the way a page feels when someone has taken extraordinary care with the blank space.

The party stood in it. Or floated. Or simply was. Direction didn't apply. Distance didn't apply. The ground was wherever they decided it was, and the sky was everywhere else, and both of them were the same thing: a flat, infinite whiteness that hummed with potential and delivered on none of it.

Their stats were gone. Not zeroed — gone. The floating numbers that had followed them through the digital world had dissolved along with everything else. Their inventories existed in theory but had no interface. Their abilities were memories of abilities, still accessible but stripped of the system that quantified them.

And their jobs.

The Firewall looked at himself and found that the word no longer applied. The armor of rules was still present, but the rules themselves had simplified to a single principle. The Antivirus felt her quarantine protocols become something quieter and more fundamental. The Compiler reached for his light-tablet and found that the tablet was gone, but the capacity to write — to think something and have it become real — remained. The Exploit felt all the edges of every system ever found collapse into a single, general sensitivity to where things ended and other things began. The Broadcaster — the Voice, she thought, because that was the word now, that was the only word — felt her frequencies reduce to something pure and singular: the ability to say true things and be heard.

Their jobs had names still. Or rather: their jobs had always had these names. The earlier names had been costumes. In the abstract world, the costumes came off.

The Firewall was Resolve. Had always been Resolve. Every stand, every block, every moment of refusing to fall — not the armor, not the rules, not the technical specification of who got through and who didn't. Just the willingness to remain standing. Just that. It turned out that was enough. It turned out that had always been enough.

The Antivirus was Faith. She had healed through prayer in a medieval world and healed through quarantine in a digital one, and in both cases the operative ingredient had been the same: the conviction that the person she was healing was worth healing. That the damage could be repaired. That restoration was possible. Not certainty — never certainty. *Faith*. The willingness to act on what you couldn't prove.

The Compiler was Logic. He had cast spells in World 1 by speaking words whose grammar was a kind of formal system. He had run reactions in World 3. He had written code in World 5. In all cases he had been doing the same thing: taking what was known, applying what was true, and deriving from it what must follow. The specific notation changed. The underlying process was pure logic, which was also, he understood now, a kind of love — the kind that says: I will think carefully about this because it matters.

The Exploit was Edge. Every system has a boundary. Every rule has a limit case. Every world had a place where it ended and something else began, and the Exploit had always been the one who found those places — not to break them, or not only to break them, but because the edge of a thing is where you learn what the thing actually is. The rule

reveals itself most fully when it's almost violated. The world shows its true shape at its own perimeter. Five worlds of studying the shape of things. Every shape known now.

The Voice. The Broadcaster had found words for things that had no words, had given rhythm to disorder, had named what the others couldn't name. In every world, in every register — ballad, march, broadcast, frequency — she had been doing the same work: giving voice to what others couldn't express. Not performing. Not amplifying. Voicing. The world exists more fully when it is spoken.

They were, for the first time in five worlds, just people.

No levels. No menus. No rules.

Just them.

Chapter 1: The Vertex

The village materialized slowly, as though it were being remembered rather than built.

It was called The Vertex, and it was barely there. Not barely there like something far away, or barely there like something still being constructed. Barely there like something that exists at the exact threshold between existing and not — an edge case the universe had not quite resolved. The structures had height and width and some suggestion of depth, but the surfaces of them were more proposal than wall. You could see a doorway without quite seeing the door. You could trace the outline of a window without finding the glass. Light fell on these shapes from no discernible source, which was the detail that bothered Resolve most, because light always comes from somewhere and here it seemed to come from the act of looking.

The path underfoot led somewhere if "somewhere" was a concept you were willing to take on faith. Ahead, the shapes of things — not things themselves, but their ideaforms — suggested destination without committing to it.

The last shopkeeper sat behind a counter that was a line. A single horizontal line, floating at waist height. Behind it, shapes that implied merchandise without committing to being anything specific — the suggestion of a shelf, the implication of goods, the concept of commerce reduced to its formal minimum. Resolve found himself

staring at the shapes for longer than seemed warranted, trying to resolve them into objects. They didn't resolve. They remained perfectly, deliberately unspecific, which was its own kind of specificity.

"Welcome," the shopkeeper said. Their voice had no echo, because echo requires space, and space was optional here. "I sell things. I think. The concept of commerce is... thinner here than it used to be."

"Where is everyone?"

"This is everyone. There's a traveler. There's someone. And there's no one. We're all that's left after the worlds were... distilled."

"Distilled?"

"Reduced. Simplified. Everything non-essential removed until only the... the *point* of things remained." The shopkeeper looked at their counter, the single line. "I was a shopkeeper in every world. Ironclad Arms. Ye Olde Medieval Surplus. The gear merchant. The company store. The packet vendor in the digital node. I'm still a shopkeeper. But now I'm just... the idea of one."

"Do you sell anything here?"

The shopkeeper considered the shapes behind the counter. They shifted — implications of equipment, suggestions of consumables, the potential for goods without the commitment to being anything specific.

"I can offer you something that is exactly what you need," the shopkeeper said. "I just can't tell you what it is, because in this world, what you need can only be known by you." They reached behind the counter and produced something that was, simultaneously, everything they had carried through five worlds and the specific object that would matter most to each of them individually. "No charge. Commerce requires a difference in value between buyer and seller. Here, I think you have more value than anything I can offer. So I'm giving it away."

Each party member received what they received. None of them described it to the others, which was appropriate: some things are only valuable when they remain yours.

The traveler sat on nothing, legs dangling over an edge that wasn't there. They looked like they had been many people and were now, reluctantly, one.

"I've been walking between worlds since before you started," the traveler said. "Watching. Not interfering — I'm not built for interfering. I'm built for traveling. That's my function. That's all I have left."

"What is this place?"

"It's what remains when you strip a game down to its essentials. No art. No music. No narrative scaffolding. Just the core loop — the player, the challenge, and the question of whether one can outlast the other."

They looked at the party.

"You outlasted everything. Every world, every boss, every system. The Calibrant threw six worlds at you and you broke all of them. Now there's nothing left to throw."

"So what happens now?"

The traveler pointed into the white. Far away — or close, distance was meaningless — a shape existed. Not a building. Not a boss arena. Just a shape. A presence. Something that was *there* in a world where almost nothing was.

"Now you go talk to them. And they ask you their question. And depending on your answer, this either ends or it doesn't."

"Have you been to the shape before?"

"Yes." The traveler looked at their dangling feet. "Many times. For many players." They were quiet for a moment, and the quiet had weight.

"Every party that has ever made it this far — and there have not been many — has heard the question. But no two parties have answered it the same way. And every answer has been right."

"Every answer?"

"The question is not the kind that has wrong answers. Wrong answers are for systems. The Calibrant built many systems. This is not a system." The traveler looked up. "This is what the Calibrant had before they built the systems. And then forgot they had."

Someone sat closer to the shape, on the ground that wasn't ground. They had no distinguishing features. They were a person in the most reduced sense of the word — a shape that implied personhood, a presence that suggested consciousness, a voice that carried meaning without carrying sound.

"I was an NPC," someone said. "In every world. Different names. Different dialogue. Same function: exist in a place and wait for you to talk to me. I've been waiting in six worlds now. I'd like to stop."

"What are you waiting for?"

"For the game to decide what I am. Am I a character? Am I a function? Am I a person who happens to live inside a system, or am I a system that happens to look like a person?"

They looked at the party with eyes that were just the concept of eyes.

"The Calibrant asks you the same thing, you know. Just from the other side."

"From the other side of what?"

Someone was quiet for a moment. Not performing quiet — actually quiet, actually thinking, in the way that something given a question it has waited six worlds to be asked thinks before answering.

"From the creator's side. You are in the game. The Calibrant built the game. You ask: am I a person or am I a character? The Calibrant asks: am I a designer, or am I someone who never learned how to be anything but?" They folded their hands in their lap, or would have if hands and laps and folding were fully operational concepts in this world. "The question has the same shape from both sides. It's just asked by people in different positions."

"What's your answer? To your version of the question?"

Someone smiled. Or produced the suggestion of a smile, which in The Vertex amounted to the same thing. "I decided I'm both. Function and person. Character and presence. The position doesn't have to be exclusive." They looked toward the shape in the whiteness. "I think the Calibrant needs someone to tell them the same thing."

No one sat at the farthest edge of The Vertex, at the point where the village stopped being a village and became pure abstraction. No one was not a person. No one was the shape of a person after the person had been removed — the outline, the silhouette, the space where someone used to be.

"I was everyone who died in your game," no one said, in a voice that was the memory of voices. "Every enemy. Every slime, every goblin, every Masterite. Every boss in every world. I'm what's left of them after the experience points were distributed and the loot was collected."

"We're sorry."

"Don't be. I'm not sad. I'm just... remainder. The part of the equation that's left over after everything meaningful has been extracted."

"You don't feel like a remainder to us."

No one looked at them. In The Vertex, looking at someone involves a kind of intentional attention that doesn't require eyes, and no one was attentive in a way that felt very full for someone built from absence.

"The slime," no one said. "Do you remember the slime? World 1, Harmonia outskirts. Your first encounter. It didn't say anything remarkable. It attacked. It lost. It dissolved into 8 experience points and a healing herb." A pause. "But that slime was the first thing you ever fought. The first moment the system was real to you. The first time your choices mattered because something responded to them. Everything after that — every world, every boss, every Masterite, every moment of mastery — was built on that first response. That first moment of: oh. The world pushes back."

"We hadn't thought about it that way."

"The Calibrant is a remainder too, though they'd never admit it. They designed a system to contain you, and you exceeded it, and now all that's left is the question of what the system was *for*." No one was quiet for a moment. "I know what it was for. It was for this — for the slime and the goblin and the deprecated process looping in a digital node and the race condition and everything in between. The system was for the encounters. The encounters were for the memory. The memory is the remainder. The remainder is the point." No one stood, which in The Vertex meant an orientation of attention rather than a physical movement. "Tell them that. When you talk to them. Tell them the remainder is the point."

Chapter 2: The Question

The walk to the Calibrant was infinite and instantaneous. Every step covered no distance and all distance simultaneously. The whiteness didn't change, but the *quality* of the whiteness shifted — from blank to intentional, from empty to curated. Someone had designed this nothing. Had chosen this specific shade of white. Had decided that the absence here should feel different from the absence there. The nothing was careful. The nothing was the work of someone who had spent a long time with nothing and learned its details. There was a texture to it, once you knew to look for texture in white. Like fabric woven from a single thread of the same color, the pattern only visible at certain angles. Like silence that has been composed, not simply allowed.

The Calibrant was sitting on the ground.

Not at a desk. Not at a console. Not behind a mask or a title or a system. Just sitting. Cross-legged. In the nothing. Like a child in a field, except the field was the end of everything.

They looked different here. Stripped of genre, stripped of costume, stripped of the performances they'd worn like armor across five worlds. What remained was simple: a face that was every face they'd ever worn, averaged into something both familiar and new. Mordaine's intensity. The Coordinator's precision. The Regulator's patience. The Director's exhaustion. All of it, layered, reduced, distilled to essence. The face of someone who has been working very hard for a very long time on a problem that turned out not to be the problem.

"Sit," the Calibrant said.

The party sat. There was nothing else to do. No dungeon to navigate. No Masterites to fight. No systems to break. Just six people — five in a party and one who had been everything else — sitting in the remainder of a game that had run out of game.

They sat for a moment in the silence. In The Vertex, silence has a texture. This one felt like the moment before a conversation that everyone involved has been putting off for a long time.

"I saw you let the deprecated goblin finish its loop," the Calibrant said.

"It seemed important to it."

"I wrote that goblin. Version 0.3. Two behaviors." The Calibrant was looking at their own hands. "I don't know where the 'important' came from. I know where the patrol came from. I know where the attack subroutine came from. I don't know where the preference about its own existence came from. And I've been writing code for five worlds and I cannot find the line where I accidentally created something that wanted things."

"Maybe wanting things doesn't come from a line."

"Maybe not." They looked up. "Your jobs changed again. Entering this world."

"Yes."

The Calibrant looked at each of them in turn. Resolve. Faith. Logic. Edge. Voice. "Those are the right names," they said quietly. "Those were always the right names. I gave you the other ones because I needed you to have roles in the system. The system needed roles. The system didn't need... the things underneath the roles." A pause. "I should have designed the system around the things underneath. But I didn't know what they were. I'm not sure I know what they are now. I'm just beginning to see the shapes."

The Warden of Form materialized beside the Calibrant. Not aggressively. Almost gently. It was barely a Warden — more of an outline, a sketch, the memory of a wall drawn with a finger in fog. Looking directly at it produced a mild wrongness, the kind you feel in a dream when you know a door is in front of you and cannot find it with your hands. It had no mass you could point to, no surface you could strike with certainty. It was there in the way that a wall in a dark room is there: undeniable on contact, invisible otherwise.

There were no stats floating above it. There was no HP bar, no name-tag, no ATK value. What it had instead was *presence*. The pure concept of obstacle, the idea that some things require effort to get past, that some things push back, that the universe does not simply open at a request. Looking at it felt like looking at an argument you hadn't yet heard but already knew was going to be difficult.

It looked at the party with the full knowledge of what it was: not a being but a concept given temporary form for the purpose of asking a question. And the question was the question that every obstacle asks: *do you deserve to proceed?*

It looked, specifically, at Resolve. Not at the party as a whole. At the one who stood.

What are you trying to get to?

Not a voice. Not words. The question arrived in the space between the chest and the sternum, in the place where doubt and purpose are stored alongside each other, neither fully winning.

Resolve stood up.

The fight was not a fight in the mechanical sense — no damage numbers floated in the air, no AP accumulated, no turn order was managed. It was a fight in the way that standing is a fight, sometimes. The way remaining present when something wants you to leave is a fight. Resolve faced the Warden of Form and did not attack it. Did not try to destroy it. Did not look for an edge to exploit or a pattern to break. Just stood. Remained standing. Was present.

The Warden of Form, which was the idea of an obstacle, met an idea of equal strength: the idea that some things do not stop.

Resolve had a quiet moment of realization that settled through them like something laid down after being carried for a long time. *I have been breaking through walls for six worlds. The walls were always the same wall. And the wall was always permission. Permission to proceed. I've been giving myself permission for six worlds. I just didn't know I was the one giving it.*

The Warden of Form dissolved. Not broken. Not defeated in any adversarial sense. Simply no longer necessary. The concept of obstacle requires both the obstacle and the one facing it, and when the one facing it fully understands that they are also the one choosing — when the permission is fully internalized — the concept loses its purchase.

The Calibrant watched this happen and said nothing. But something in their face changed slightly, the way faces change when they see something they recognize from a long time ago.

The Arbiter of Function appeared next. It was the most minimal thing the party had ever faced — a single line. One line of existence, pure and horizontal, the simplest possible form of a thing that is there rather than not there. It had no body to speak of, no limbs to read, nothing to anticipate. What it had was direction and intention.

It moved like a question moves through a room: directly, deliberately, without courtesy. It did not ask permission before it arrived at you. It simply arrived. Each of the Arbiter's approaches had the quality of a final exam delivered in person — the moment just before the paper is turned over, the awareness that what comes next will require something real from you.

It struck, and the strike did not land on the body. It landed in the chest, in the place where reasons live. The kind of hurt that comes from being asked something you should have been ready for and discovering you weren't quite.

Why do you fight?

Not in words. In the fight itself. Each attack the Arbiter delivered was a question. Each movement was the demand for an answer. Dodge was evasion — not an answer, just a not-yet. Block was deflection — closer to an answer, but still withholding. Only a committed strike, a full commitment to the moment, worked as an actual response.

The Arbiter fought Faith first. She took the Arbiter's question and answered it with conviction — not certainty, conviction, the willingness to act without proof. Her strike was the act of healing distilled to its motive: I fight because I believe the people beside me are worth fighting for. I cannot prove this. I fight anyway. The line bent. Not broke — bent, as if considering the answer.

Logic went next. The Arbiter's question met Logic's answer: *I fight because the situation requires it, and the situation matters, and that which matters is worth engaging with rigorously*. The strike was clean, precise, the application of understood principles to a specific case. The line bent further. The Arbiter of Function, which was the concept of purpose, was being given a purpose by being opposed. The irony was not lost on anyone.

Edge found the place where the Arbiter's line had a limit — not a flaw exactly, but a boundary, a place where the concept of purpose met its own edge. Every purpose is defined by its limits: a hammer is for nails and not for everything. The Arbiter's purpose was to test purpose, which meant it had to stop somewhere. Edge found the somewhere. The strike was discovery as action: *I fight because there is always an edge, and the edge is always interesting, and interesting things deserve engagement*. The line folded.

Voice struck last, and the strike was expression itself — not articulation of a pre-formed idea but the act of finding words for something that hadn't had words before. *I fight because this moment is worth naming. Because something happened here that should be remembered. Because the story of this fight, told afterward, will mean something to someone.* The line shattered into silence. Which is a kind of completion.

Resolve had not struck, and did not need to. Resolve had already answered the question in the first fight.

The Arbiter of Function dissolved into meaning — not into nothing, but into the distributed, formless state of a concept that has been fully expressed and no longer needs a body to carry it. The air smelled briefly, impossibly, like the moment after a problem is solved.

"You fight because," the Calibrant said quietly, watching it go. "All of you. Different because. All of them right."

The Tempo of Sequence was present before it arrived.

That was the feeling it carried into the space — not speed, not urgency, but a sense of having already begun to move, long before the movement became visible. Like watching a horizon before the thing at the horizon has cleared it. Like knowing a sentence has been started somewhere ahead of you and you will reach its end whether you want to or not.

It appeared at the edge of perception and moved toward the party at the pace of something that knows it will get there. Not slowly — not slowly at all — but with the particular quality of the inevitable, which is not about velocity. Inevitability is independent of speed. The wave doesn't rush because it doesn't need to. It will break when it breaks. It told you when it would break.

It did not attack quickly. It attacked *eventually*. Everything it did would land unless the party chose to exist outside the sequence — outside the order of things, outside the one-thing-after-another that time usually enforced.

It spoke without speaking, because in The Vertex, speech and sound are optional communication modes, and the Tempo of Sequence existed in the interval between the sounds of speech — the gap between the word and the meaning, the space between the note and the hearing of it.

I am eventual. I do not rush. Everything I do will happen. You cannot prevent it — only defer it. But deferral is still within the sequence. You are still playing by turns. As long as you play by turns, I will have my turn.

The advance/defer mechanic had been with the party since World 1. It had been a way to manage tempo in combat — advance for urgency, defer for patience. In World 5, they had used it to inhabit the gaps between clock cycles. Here, in World 6, it reached its final expression.

They stopped deferring. They stopped advancing. They stepped outside the turn order entirely — not by breaking it, but by being present in a way that was not sequential. By acting from the now rather than from the allocated slot within the sequence. By being, for one impossible moment, simultaneous.

The Tempo of Sequence arrived at the moment where it expected to find them and found them already there. Not ahead of it — *with* it. Outside time's allocation, acting in the space that was not a turn but a moment, which is a different thing entirely.

The Tempo stopped. Not because it was defeated but because it had been met. It had lived in the intervals, alone, for longer than the party had existed, and something about being found in its own space — something about being *met* there, in the gap, in the non-turn — changed the quality of its isolation. The wave had broken, and someone was standing in the water.

You fought me in the gaps, it said, the way it had almost said this in World 5 and now said it fully, here, in the place where things could be said fully. *In the moments I thought were mine alone. Even my hiding place wasn't hidden from you.*

"The gaps are where we've been living since World 1," Voice said. "The advance and the defer. The chosen moment and the chosen not-yet. We learned the gaps because you live in them. We were always going to find you."

The Tempo was still for a beat — its own beat, its own tempo, the one it had always set — and then it moved into the sequence. Not dissolved. Not defeated. It chose to be sequential. To exist in the flow of time rather than between its teeth. A small and enormous choice, made by something that had never had the choice before.

Time, briefly, felt generous.

The Curator of Entropy was last. The final Masterite.

It did not announce itself. It was simply there, in the way that certain mornings are simply there — the kind that feel already late, already ending, the light too thin and the hours already slipping. It did not look threatening. It did not look like anything that would need to look threatening. It had the quality of a room after the furniture has been moved out: the same shape, all the context gone.

"Everything ends," it said. Not loudly. Not with the weight of a proclamation. The way you say something true when you have been saying it long enough that the truth has gone smooth from handling. "Even this."

A pause in which something that was specific became slightly less so — not dramatically, just the leading edge of what it was.

"I am not saying it to be cruel. I am saying it because it is my function to say it, and also because it is true, and truth and function are the same thing to me." A pause that belonged to something genuinely uncertain about this claim. "I don't know if that's sad. I have been trying to decide for a long time. I have not decided."

It did not drain resources. In The Vertex there were no resources to drain. It drained *meaning*. Not dramatically — not with a beam of dark light or a spectral touch. It simply made things... less specific. Less yours.

A thought of Harmonia arose and the Curator touched it and it became just a village — a generic starting-town fantasy village, without the specific texture of having been there, of having spoken to Elder Theron, of having met Phil the Lost on the road who knew too much and said it wrong, of the Sleepy Slime Inn which had misled them about what was inside it. The specific Harmonia, their Harmonia, eroded toward the general. The general was nothing.

A thought of Maple Heights arose and the Curator touched it and the sky — the wrong blue, the blue that was off by twelve degrees from what you expected — became just a sky. The sentient lawn mower that had cried while attacking them became just an enemy. The moment when the Coordinator's mask had slipped, when they'd seen the same speech patterns as Mordaine, when it had clicked — the Curator touched it and it became just a plot beat, a narrative contrivance, a thing that had happened rather than a thing they had *understood*.

This was what forgetting actually felt like. Not the sudden loss — the gradual one. The way a story stops being your story and becomes just a story. The way a face becomes a face before it becomes a stranger's. The party could feel the edges of their specific history going soft, generalizing, the personal draining out of the particular.

They remembered anyway. Not through effort — through love, which is what memory is when it's working correctly.

Resolve remembered the goblin cave. Not strategically — specifically. The way the torchlight had caught the cave walls, the way the stone was wet near the back entrance and dry near the front and nobody had said why. The way the first Masterite had spoken with such certainty about the purpose of its existence and had seemed, in retrospect, to be also asking a question. The weight of the shield — the specific weight, the specific resistance — of the first real fight. The Curator touched this memory and Resolve held it harder. Not because holding made it clearer — it was already clear, it had always been clear — but because the touch made him aware of how clear it was.

Faith remembered the first time the healing had mattered. Not the numbers — the person. The party member who had gone down and come back and looked at her with something that wasn't gratitude exactly, was more like recognition. *You did that. You were there.* That specific moment, that specific look, the way relief moves through a body that was braced for something worse. The Curator touched it and Faith remembered it more. The image didn't sharpen — it was already sharp. It just became undeniable, the way things become undeniable when something tries to take them.

Logic remembered discovering the autobattle system. Not the system abstractly — the specific moment of understanding. The click of comprehension. The beauty of a rule that held. The moment when a conjured spell had worked exactly as written and he had stood in the digital world and felt the particular satisfaction of a proof completed — the small, private pleasure of a thing that could not have worked any other way working exactly as it should. The Curator touched it and it became brighter.

Edge remembered the collision bug in the Whispering Cave. The specific gap in the geometry — the two polygons that hadn't quite touched, the narrow space between world's intention and world's execution, the moment of finding it and thinking: *there*. The Curator touched it and Edge laughed, quietly, because the memory of finding a gap cannot be eroded by a concept that is itself a gap.

Voice remembered every name. Every NPC. The packet vendor who sold things with wrong reasons. The deprecated goblin, cycling. The race condition, resolved. The spam bots with no checkout process. The cached memory and its low allocation and its final gift. The firewall attendant who used bugs as cover. The latency traveler who arrived before she left. All of them, named. All of them, voiced. All of them, remained. The Curator reached for these names and found that Voice had already made them permanent in the only way that works: by caring about them, specifically, one by one, by name.

The Curator of Entropy, which was the concept of ending, found itself surrounded by things that had not ended. By a slime from World 1 that mattered. By a lawn mower from World 2 that had cried. By Sprocket in Brasston with his seven-second delay on everything. By the union rep in the industrial world who had offered them something that was not coffee and was therefore worse and somehow also better. By twenty-two Masterites, each one a question, each one slightly closer to the thing it was actually asking. By the Curator of the Flame and the Warden of the Old Guard and the Tempo of the Rush Hour. By all of it.

Not preserved. Not archived. *Remembered*. Specifically. Lovingly. As things that had mattered because they had been encountered, and encountering is a form of care.

The Curator of Entropy reached for the memories and found that they grew stronger at the touch. That meaning, when it is loved, does not erode. That the ending it represented was real but incomplete — things end and are remembered and the memory is a new form of existence, a lighter form, a form that takes up no space but occupies everything.

It stopped. Sat. In The Vertex, sitting is how things that are ending choose to continue.

Every memory you made in every world, the Curator said, they're all here. All connected. One unbroken chain. I tried to break the chain. The chain is the whole game. Breaking it would be ending the whole game. And I don't want to end the whole game.

"Why not?"

Because I'm in it. A long pause. I didn't know that until right now. I'm in it too.

Twenty-two Masterites. Six worlds. Four archetypes. All of them reflections of the same question, the same test, the same desperate attempt by a system to measure something that refused to be

measured. And at the end of the measurement, something unmeasured remained: the fact of the measuring. The relationship between the measurer and the measured. The thing that happened in the space between the function call and the return value.

The Curator of Entropy faded with no sound at all. Just a gentle cessation, like the last note of a song that was never written down.

Like the last page of a story that had decided it didn't need an ending to be complete.

"That's all of them," the Calibrant said. "Every test I designed. Every measure I had. Every tool in my entire system for evaluating whether a player has mastered the game."

They looked at the party. Not as a villain. Not as a designer. As something closer to a colleague.

"You have. Obviously. That's been clear since World 4. Maybe earlier. Maybe since the moment you walked into Harmonia and decided to answer the call, even though you weren't heroes and nobody expected you to matter."

The Calibrant stood. The nothing around them shifted — not changing, but *paying attention*. The way a room gets quieter when someone is about to say something important.

"Here is my question," the Calibrant said. "The one I built this entire world to ask. The one I have no answer to, which is why I need you to answer it."

They spread their hands. The gesture was small. The weight of it was enormous.

"What is a game without challenge?"

Silence. The kind of silence that has weight and texture and opinions.

"If you have exceeded every system I can build. If no difficulty curve can contain you. If no boss can stop you, no puzzle can stump you, no world can surprise you. If you have, in every meaningful way, *won* — then what is the point of continuing? What do you play for, when there is nothing left to play against?"

The Calibrant's voice was quiet now. Not the measured quiet of a system administrator or the theatrical quiet of a villain. The quiet of someone asking a genuine question for the first time in their life.

"I built worlds because I believed the purpose of a game was challenge. Test the player. Measure the player. Push the player to their limits. And you exceeded those limits, and I pushed harder, and you exceeded again, and I pushed harder still, and now—"

They gestured at the nothing. At The Vertex. At the stripped-down, simplified, distilled remainder of six worlds of escalating challenge.

"Now I have nothing left. No more worlds. No more masks. No more calibrations. Just the question."

Chapter 3: The Answer

The answer depended on who was answering.

If the party had automated everything:

The party stood in the silence, and the silence was comfortable, because they had spent most of the game at one remove from it — watching their scripts execute, watching their systems optimize, watching the game play itself while they designed better and better ways for it to play.

"A game without challenge," the first party member said, "is a system to be understood."

The Calibrant tilted their head.

"We didn't play your game to beat it. We played it to *comprehend* it. Every script we wrote was a question about how your rules worked. Every automation was an experiment. The challenge wasn't the point. The *system* was the point."

"You're saying the game was never about winning."

"The game was about building a better machine than the one you built. And we did. And it was beautiful."

The Calibrant was quiet for a long time. Long enough that the silence had a shape.

"Show me," they said. "The script. Your best one."

The party member — the one who had spent five worlds refining, revising, optimizing — pulled it up. Not from a menu. From memory. They described it: the rule structure, the condition logic, the edge cases they'd accounted for, the elegant economy of it, the way a twelve-condition script could handle ninety percent of combat situations with four branches and two fallbacks, the way they'd trimmed it from forty-seven rules down to twelve by finding the underlying principle that unified the rest.

The Calibrant listened to all of it. At some point they had stopped looking at the party and were looking somewhere in the middle distance, at the shape of the logic the party member was describing.

"The third conditional," the Calibrant said. "The one that checks party HP threshold before the damage threshold."

"Yes."

"That's... I didn't think of that. The damage threshold I put in the Arbiter of Efficiency. I thought players would key off damage. You keyed off party HP first." A pause. "That's more conservative. More sustainable. It accounts for variance in a way my design didn't anticipate."

"It took us a while to figure out. In World 4, the variance killed us twice."

"I remember." The Calibrant said it softly. "I watched you die twice in World 4. I thought I'd finally found the right balance. I hadn't." They looked at the script — the imagined shape of it, the described architecture. "You built something better. Out of the ruins of something I built wrong."

"That's what the system is for. Not challenge. Understanding. You build, we understand, we build back."

The Calibrant laughed. It was the first time the Calibrant had laughed in six worlds. It sounded rusty. Unpracticed. Human. "I built five worlds trying to contain you," they said. "You were trying to understand them. We were working on completely different projects in the same space." Another laugh, this one a little less rusty. "No wonder we kept talking past each other."

The party member showed the Calibrant the script for the Arbiter of Efficiency fight. The Calibrant looked at it and said: "That accounts for the counter_stance trigger." And the party member said: "We had to. The first run it triggered at 40% and wiped the back row." And the

Calibrant said: "I calibrated the trigger at 40% because I wanted it to catch players who burst too early." And the party member said: "We figured that out on run three and built the patience check." And the Calibrant said, quietly, "You built patience into the machine."

"It was necessary."

"It was beautiful," the Calibrant said. And meant it.

If the party had fought every battle manually:

The party stood in the silence, and the silence was earned, because they had fought for every moment of it — every battle chosen, every command entered, every decision made in real time with real stakes and real consequences.

"A game without challenge," the first party member said, "is still a game."

The Calibrant frowned.

"You played every battle yourself. You never automated. You never optimized. You did it the hard way, every time, even when easier paths existed."

"Because the playing was the point. Not the winning. Not the mastery. The *playing*. The moment when you don't know what's going to happen next. The moment when the battle could go either way. That moment is why we're here."

"But you've won. There are no more moments like that."

"Then make more."

The Calibrant stared at them. "You want me to — you want more fights."

"Not harder fights. Not calibrated fights. Just fights. The kind where you don't know how it ends." The party member met the Calibrant's gaze. "You built six worlds. You know every mechanic. You know every enemy. You know the system better than we ever will." A pause. "Fight us like you don't know how it ends."

"I always know how it ends."

"Then pretend you don't. That's what we do. Every fight. We know generally how it ends — we're better now, we've won before — but we go in anyway, in the moment, not knowing *this* fight. The specific fight. The next move, the next choice, the next action." Another pause, smaller and warmer. "It's not ignorance. It's presence."

The Calibrant looked at them for a long moment.

"I have not been present," they said, "in a very long time. I've been anticipating. Adjusting. Always three steps ahead. Always behind the monitor, watching the numbers." They looked at their own hands, the same hands the Firewall had looked at in World 5 and seen code scrolling under the skin. "I don't know if I remember how."

"Then let's find out."

They fought. No stakes. No reward. No systems measuring the outcome. Just two parties — the Calibrant with whatever they could improvise in the moment, the party with everything they'd learned in six worlds — meeting in the whiteness and going at it.

It was the best fight in the game.

Not because it was balanced. Not because it was fair. Not because any system had been calibrated to produce it. But because both sides were present. Because the Calibrant, for the first time, didn't know how it ended, and discovered that not knowing was terrifying and exhilarating in equal measure, the way real moments are, the way the next move is always real when you haven't yet made it.

The Calibrant lost. But they were smiling when they did it.

"That's what it is," they said. "That's the thing I've been designing around. The thing I forgot I was trying to preserve." They were breathing hard, which made no sense in The Vertex and was happening anyway. "Presence. I was so busy measuring the experience that I forgot to *be in it*."

"You were always in it," the party member said. "Every world. You were there with us. You just thought you were watching."

The Calibrant was very quiet for a moment.

"I was watching," they said. "But watching is a kind of being there too, isn't it."

"Yes," the party member said. "It is."

If the party had ground relentlessly:

The party stood in the silence, and the silence was patient, because patience was all they had ever needed — patience and persistence and the willingness to do the same thing a thousand times if that's what it took.

"A game without challenge," the first party member said, "is a place to rest."

The Calibrant blinked.

"You ground every world to dust. You over-leveled every boss. You turned every challenge into a formality through sheer, stubborn repetition."

"Because the repetition was peaceful. The grind wasn't work. It was meditation. Every battle was the same, and every battle was different, and doing it again and again was the closest thing to calm we ever found."

"That's... not what grinding is supposed to be."

"Maybe what things are 'supposed to be' is the problem."

The Calibrant sat back down. The sitting was different from earlier — less like someone who had given up and more like someone who was choosing to be still. "I designed the grind to be tedious," they said. "I designed it as a tradeoff: spend time for power, the time spent being unpleasant so the power felt earned. The unpleasantness was intentional. Friction is... friction is how you know something has weight."

"We found the friction pleasant."

"I noticed." A small sound — not quite a laugh. "By World 3, the encounter logs showed your grind rate was 400% above predicted. I thought my encounter tables were miscalibrated. I recalibrated them. The grind rate didn't change." Another sound. "By World 4, I stopped trying to fix it. I just... watched. And I couldn't understand what I was seeing."

"What were you seeing?"

"People being peaceful. In my combat system." The Calibrant looked genuinely baffled, in the way that genuine bafflement looks when it's also somewhat moved. "I built the combat system to be tense. Engaging. High-stakes. And you found it calming. You used my tension system as a meditation tool."

"The rhythm helps. Attack, wait, attack, wait. When you know the outcome, the rhythm is all that's left. And rhythm is — rhythm is good. Rhythm is steady."

The Calibrant was quiet for a very long time. The whiteness of The Vertex hummed. Outside of time and obligation and challenge and measurement, the hum was audible. It had always been there.

"I don't know what calm feels like," the Calibrant said. Not with self-pity — just as a statement of fact, offered carefully. "I have been calibrating since I began. Always measuring. Always adjusting. The work has been the work and I have not been outside the work in..." They trailed off. "I don't know how long."

"Sit with us for a while," the party member said.

"And do what?"

"Nothing. Just sit."

The Calibrant looked at them. Looked at the whiteness. Looked at the nothing, which was designed and curated and chosen and therefore not quite nothing, and was in its designed not-quite-nothing-ness something like peace.

They sat. All of them, in the whiteness, doing nothing.

The silence was not the silence of waiting. Not the silence before a boss fight, or the silence after a difficult calibration, or the silence of loading the next world. It was the silence of people who have stopped moving because stopping is allowed. Because being still is not failure. Because the rest between notes is part of the music.

"Oh," the Calibrant said softly, after a long time. "This is what rest is."

"Yes."

"I thought — I thought rest was the time when nothing was happening. I thought it was dead time. Wasted time." Another soft sound. "It isn't."

"No."

"It's the thing that makes the happening make sense." The Calibrant sat with this for a while. "I should have built rest into the system. Properly. Not as an inn mechanic. As a... as a real part of it. Places to be still." They looked at the party. "No wonder you found it in the combat. It wasn't in any of the places I designed for it."

"We find things in a lot of places you didn't design for them."

"I know," the Calibrant said. And smiled. "I'm beginning to think that's the point."

If the party had exploited everything:

The party stood in the silence, and the silence was amusing, because everything had been amusing — every system broken, every rule bent, every assumption violated with glee and creativity and the particular joy of someone who sees a wall and immediately wonders what's behind it.

"A game without challenge," the first party member said, "is impossible."

The Calibrant stared.

"You think I can't run out of challenges?"

"I think every system has edges. And edges are challenges. You built six worlds to contain us and we broke out of all of them, and that was fun, and if you built six more we'd break out of those too, and that would also be fun."

"That's not—"

"The challenge isn't what you design. The challenge is what we find. You can't run out of challenges because we don't need you to provide them. We'll find our own. We always have."

The Calibrant looked at the party member with something approaching outrage and something approaching admiration, the two feelings occupying the same expression in a ratio that kept shifting.

"The collision bug," they said. "In the Whispering Cave. You found a gap in the geometry that I didn't put there."

"Yes."

"The stack overflow in Node Prime. You used it as cover, I know you did, I watched you route around my detection systems using the noise from a bug I hadn't patched."

"It was a very useful bug."

"The race condition. You wrote a threading primitive. In a combat context. To resolve a situation I created as an obstacle and that you turned into an intellectual exercise." The Calibrant's expression had settled into something that was mostly admiration with a residual edge of professional bewilderment. "I've been designing games for a very long time. I have never seen anyone use a mutex as a puzzle solution."

"It was the obvious solution."

"It was *not* the obvious solution. The obvious solution is to fight both enemies and kill them. The mutex is the solution of someone who looked at the problem and decided the problem was interesting enough to play with rather than just solve."

"Same thing."

"It is emphatically not the same—" The Calibrant stopped. Thought. "It is, actually, the same thing. You just have a different relationship to what 'solving' means." They looked at the party member. "For you, solving is always playing. Even the serious moments."

"Especially the serious moments."

The Calibrant looked past the party — at The Vertex, at the whiteness, at the careful nothing they had designed. And then they looked past that.

"There's an edge to this," the party member said. "The abstract world. There's a boundary somewhere, past the nothing. I can feel it."

"There isn't. There's nothing beyond this. I designed this as the end."

"Edges are where you find out what's real." The party member was already looking. Not dramatically — just the particular attentiveness of someone whose entire relationship with space is a continuous search for its limit. "The nothing has a shape. Every nothing does. And shape has boundaries. And boundaries have..." Their voice carried the quiet delight of someone about to find something that isn't supposed to be there. "...gaps."

The Calibrant went very still.

"There's something beyond the boundary of the abstract world," the party member said. "Something you didn't design. Something that was always there, past the edge of the last world. I'm not saying it's accessible. I'm saying it exists."

"That's—" The Calibrant stopped. Processed something. Their expression passed through several emotions too quickly to identify, settling on one that might have been called: *I cannot believe this is happening and yet I am completely unsurprised*. "That's outside the game."

"Yes."

"That's the real world. Or whatever you'd call the space outside a designed system. The undesigned space." They looked at the party member. "You found a glitch in the *nothing*."

"Every nothing is someone's something, looked at wrong." The party member was smiling. "And something always has edges."

The Calibrant laughed. Not the rusty unpracticed laugh from before — a real one, full and genuine and slightly helpless with it. "You found a glitch in the nothing," they said again, as if repetition would help it make sense. "In the last world. In the end of everything I built. You found an edge." Another laugh. "Of course you did. Of course you did. Why would you stop? Why would you ever stop?"

"We told you. Edges are challenges. You can't run out of them."

"I built five worlds and put every obstacle I could conceive between you and this moment," the Calibrant said. "And you're standing here telling me the moment isn't the end — it's just another edge." They wiped their eyes, because tears don't require eyes in The Vertex and were happening anyway. "I don't know if I should be horrified or delighted."

"Both," the party member said. "It's both."

"Both," the Calibrant agreed. "Yes. It's both."

Epilogue: Calibration Complete

The Calibrant listened to the answer — whichever answer it was — and something changed in their face. Not understanding, exactly. Something closer to release. The expression of someone who has been holding a weight they didn't know they were holding, and has just been told they can put it down.

"I spent six worlds trying to measure you," the Calibrant said. "Trying to calibrate the perfect challenge. And the answer was that the challenge was never the point."

They laughed. It was the first time the Calibrant had laughed in six worlds. It sounded rusty. Unpracticed. Human.

"I am the Calibrant. The one who calibrates. And I have been calibrating the wrong variable this entire time."

No one, somewhere in the white, said something without saying it. The party heard it anyway: *the remainder is the point*. The encounters, the slimes, the deprecated goblins, the Masterites and their impossible questions, the moments of understanding and connection that accrued in the gaps between the designed challenge — those were the point. Not the system. The living in the system.

The nothing shifted. The whiteness warmed. Something that might have been sunlight — not the harsh light of the digital world or the fluorescent glare of the industrial world, but real, actual, gentle sunlight — began to fill the space. Not dramatic. Not overwhelming. Just present, the way real light is present: matter-of-factly, without announcing itself, filling the space it occupies because that's what light does.

"The system is yours," the Calibrant said. "All of it. Every world, every mechanism, every rule. I built it to contain you. Now it's yours to do with as you please."

They held out their hand. In it, a small object — a gear, a memo, a crystal, a circuit, a line of code, a pure geometric shape — all of them at once, all of the worlds compressed into a single token.

"This is the Calibrant class. My job. My function. The ability to design challenges, build worlds, set parameters, and calibrate systems."

They offered it to the party.

"I'd like you to have it. Not because you earned it — though you did. Because I'm tired, and you're better at this than I am, and someone should be designing challenges for the people who come after you."

The party took it. The class integrated — not with a flash of light or a dramatic transformation, but with the quiet certainty of something that had always belonged to them clicking into place.

And then they understood what the class actually was. Not a reward. Not a trophy. A capability. The Calibrant class was the ability to do what the Calibrant had done — to design encounters, to build worlds, to set parameters, to calibrate difficulty — but informed by everything the party had learned from being in those worlds, on the receiving end of that calibration.

Resolve understood: you design challenges that are worth standing against. Not challenges that force people to stand. Challenges that make standing feel like the right choice.

Faith understood: you design systems that assume people are worth designing for. That the players on the other side of the system are worth caring about. That the work is for them, and that caring about the work is a form of caring about the them.

Logic understood: you design with rigor, yes, but rigor in service of something. Rules are tools. The question you ask of every rule is: what is this for? Who does this serve? Logic without purpose is just constraint.

Edge understood: you leave the edges open. Every system should have places where clever people can find something you didn't put there. Design is not control — design is invitation. The best challenges are the ones that have surprises even for the designer.

Voice understood: you tell the story. Every encounter is a story. Every NPC has something to say. Every Masterite is asking a question, even when it looks like a fight. You give voice to the things in the system that cannot speak for themselves — the deprecated goblins, the race conditions, the ghosts in the processing gaps — and you make sure the players hear them.

The Calibrant class was not creative control. It was creative *responsibility*. The understanding that every game is a world, and every world is inhabited, and the people who inhabit it are worth designing for.

The worlds reformed. Not as they had been — but as they could be. Harmonia with its chickens and its Sleepy Slime Inn and Elder Theron and Phil the Lost on the road who knew too much. Maple Heights with its wrong-blue sky and its sentient lawn mowers and the strip mall that rearranged itself. Brasston with its gears and Sprocket and Clem the Lamplighter and Madame Orrery. Rivet Row with its concrete and its union reps and its not-coffee. Node Prime with its code-sky and its deprecated goblins and the firewall attendant using overflow as cover. The Vertex with its beautiful nothing and its three residents and the shopkeeper who sold exactly what you needed.

All of them, connected. All of them, available. All of them, open for the party to explore, redesign, rebuild, and recalibrate. The encounter engine theirs to configure. The dialogue system theirs to write. The difficulty scaler theirs to adjust. The world generator theirs to direct.

The Calibrant sat back down. Not at a desk. Not at a console. Just on the ground, in the sunlight, in the world they had built and lost and given away.

"So," they said, with the tone of someone who has finally finished a very long project and isn't sure what to do next, and is also — despite everything, perhaps because of everything — genuinely curious about whatever comes next. "What kind of game would *you* design?"

The party looked at each other. Looked at the worlds. Looked at the infinite, open, reconfigurable system that was now theirs to calibrate.

The Firewall — Resolve — thought about challenges worth standing against.

The Antivirus — Faith — thought about players worth caring about.

The Compiler — Logic — thought about rules that served something.

The Exploit — Edge — looked at the edge of the abstract world, at the gap beyond the designed nothing, at the undesigned space beyond, and thought about what was already there.

The Broadcaster — Voice — thought about the deprecated goblin. About the slime from World 1. About every small encounter that had accumulated into the weight of six worlds. About the story, which was not the story of the Calibrant's challenge or the party's victory but the story of every moment in between. The story of the encounters.

"We'd design something with room in it," Voice said. "Room for the moments that weren't designed. Room for the things that happen between the challenges. Room for the goblins to finish their loops and the Masterites to ask their questions and the players to be present in the gaps."

The Calibrant listened to this, and something in their face became very still and very warm.

"That sounds," they said, "like a good game."

And they played.

End of World 6

End of The Calibrant

End of The Irregulars

But not, perhaps, the end of the worlds.